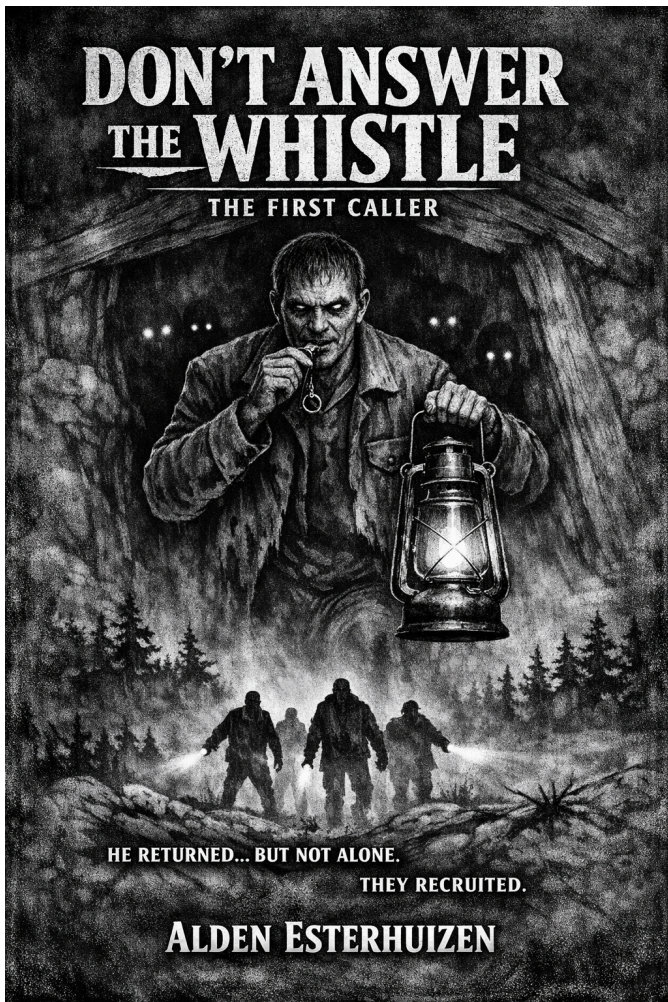


DON'T ANSWER THE WHISTLE

THE FIRST CALLER



Chapter One: The Trip

The last time all of them had been in the same place was three years ago, at Jordan's cousin's wedding in Asheville — a reception that ended with Taylor dancing on a picnic table and Sam crying in the parking lot over something nobody could quite remember anymore. It had been that kind of night. The kind that felt like a closing door even while it was happening.

This trip was supposed to be different. A reopening.

Alex Mercer had planned it down to the trailhead. Six friends, five days, one loop through the backcountry of Great Smoky Mountains National Park — the kind of place that made you feel small in a way that was supposed to be good for you. He'd printed the permits, researched the elevation changes, bought a new water filter he'd watched three YouTube videos to understand. He'd done all of it because someone had to, and because doing it kept him from thinking too hard about why everyone had drifted in the first place.

The van smelled like gas station coffee and Casey's lavender hand lotion. Six of them packed in with their packs wedged in the back like a game of Tetris nobody had won cleanly. Jordan was asleep against the window before they hit the highway, mouth slightly open, his fleece pulled up over his shoulder. Taylor had claimed the far back seat and was scrolling through something on her phone with the focused silence of a person who did not want to be talked to. Sam sat up front with Alex, navigator in title only — she'd already missed two exits but seemed unbothered by this, which was very Sam.

"You're going to have us driving into a lake," Alex said.

"The lake is scenic," Sam said without looking up. "I'm expanding the itinerary."

From the middle row, Riley laughed — that short, real laugh that Alex had always liked, the one that came out before they had a chance to decide whether something was funny. Riley Voss had cut their hair since the last time Alex had seen them, shorter on the sides now, and they were wearing a flannel shirt that had definitely been worn enough times to achieve a kind of softness that new clothes never had. They were sharing the middle row with Casey, who was braiding a small section of her own hair with the absent concentration of someone running through a mental checklist.

"Did everyone remember bear canisters?" Casey asked.

"Yes," said Alex.

"Taylor?"

"Yes, Casey."

"You said yes last time and then showed up with a paper bag."

"That was one time and it was a very sturdy paper bag."

Jordan stirred against the window. "Are we there."

"We're in Tennessee," Sam said.

"Cool." He went back to sleep.

This was them. This had always been them — the loose, overlapping rhythms of people who had known each other long enough that silence was comfortable and irritation was affectionate and the specific way Jordan could fall asleep anywhere was something you filed under *things I know about a person I love* rather than something that annoyed you. Alex felt something ease in his chest the longer they drove. Something he hadn't realized was clenched.

They reached the Laurel Falls trailhead parking area just after noon. The sky was the particular pale grey of early October in the Smokies — not threatening, just overcast, the kind of sky that turned the tree line into something impressionistic. The leaves were mid-turn, amber and rust bleeding into green, and the air had that cold-clean quality that made you breathe deeper than usual just because you could.

Sam took one step out of the van and stood still for a moment, her face tilted up.

"Okay," she said. "Okay, yes. I forgive Alex for making us wake up at four in the morning."

"Five," Alex said.

"Four-fifty is four in the morning."

They unpacked with the practiced semi-chaos of people who had done this before in various configurations — Riley and Alex fitting tent poles together,

Casey reorganizing her pack with a precision that made Taylor visibly anxious on her behalf, Jordan eating a granola bar and providing moral support. The air smelled like pine resin and something softer underneath, damp earth and leaf decay, the smell of things quietly composting back into the mountain.

Alex had the guitar strapped to the outside of his pack. It was a travel guitar, a parlor-sized thing with a spruce top he'd owned for seven years and taken everywhere from a beach house in the Outer Banks to his friend Marcus's bachelor party in Denver. It was scratched along the lower bout where he'd knocked it against a coffee table, and two of the tuning pegs were slightly stiff, and he loved it in the specific way you loved something that had been present for most of your significant moments.

"You actually brought it," Riley said, not surprised, just noting it.

"I always bring it."

"I know." They looked at him for a moment with an expression he couldn't fully read — warm, a little complicated. "I'm glad."

They set off around one o'clock.

The trail climbed gently at first, switchbacking up through a section of old-growth hemlock that turned the light green and diffuse, the canopy so thick overhead that the overcast sky became irrelevant. Somewhere above them, unseen, a woodpecker was working at a dead trunk with rhythmic focus. Their boots found their cadence on the packed earth.

Jordan fell into step beside Alex as the group spread out along the trail in the natural way of hikers, some faster, some slower, conversation pooling and dispersing.

"This was a good idea," Jordan said.

"We'll see."

"No, I mean it. I needed this." He looked up at the trees. "I've been in an apartment for like eight months with bad lighting. I forgot what things looked like."

Alex understood that. The last few years had settled over all of them differently — jobs that paid the bills or didn't, relationships that solidified or quietly dissolved, cities that were supposed to be temporary and then weren't. They were all in their late twenties now, which meant they were old enough to know that nothing was guaranteed and still young enough to feel mildly betrayed by this fact.

"How's things with Priya?" Alex asked.

Jordan made a sound that wasn't quite a word. "Complicated."

"Okay."

"She's good. We're just — I don't know. Figuring stuff out." He paused. "How are things with you and Riley?"

"There's nothing with me and Riley."

"Sure."

"There isn't."

"Alex," Jordan said, with the patient tone of a man who had watched Alex fail to say true things about Riley Voss for approximately five years. "I'm not going to tell anyone. We're in the woods."

Alex didn't answer, which was an answer, and Jordan didn't push it, which was why they were still friends.

They made camp in the late afternoon at a designated backcountry site beside a creek that moved fast and shallow over flat grey stones. The hemlocks gave way here to a clearing ringed by red maples, their leaves gone deep scarlet, and in the early evening light the effect was something close to cathedral. Casey set up her tent with startling efficiency. Taylor built the fire — she was unexpectedly good at fires, always had been, some combination of patience and instinct that translated well to kindling.

They ate freeze-dried pasta that tasted better than it had any right to, and Sam produced a bag of peanut butter cups she'd hidden in her pack as a surprise, and for a while they were just six people around a fire in the mountains, passing

chocolate back and forth, the creek noise running underneath everything like a low continuous note.

Alex tuned the guitar, working through the stiff pegs. Riley sat to his left, close enough that their shoulders were almost touching, turned partly toward the fire.

He started playing — nothing particular, just the kind of meandering that hands do when they know where they're going without being told. A chord progression that wanted to become a song but hadn't decided which one. The fire crackled. Somewhere in the trees an owl made its presence known and then went quiet.

Sam leaned back on her hands and looked up at the sky, where a few stars were beginning to show through the cloud gaps.

"This is perfect," she said. "Someone remember this moment so we can talk about it when we're old."

"I'm already writing it down," Casey said, and she actually was — small notebook, ballpoint pen, the words forming in her careful left-handed slant.

Alex played. The notes moved out into the trees, past the firelight, into the dark where the creek noise swallowed them. It was perfectly quiet otherwise. The kind of quiet that felt full rather than empty.

And then, from somewhere up the ridge — distant enough to be uncertain, close enough to be real — there came a sound.

A whistle. Single note. High and clean and brief.

Alex's fingers paused on the strings.

Nobody said anything for a moment.

"Wind," Taylor said.

"Yeah," said Sam. "Probably."

Alex looked out past the treeline, into the dark where the ridge rose invisible against the sky. He held the guitar's neck without playing. The creek ran on. The fire popped.

He didn't write about it in his journal that night, not exactly. Just a small note at the bottom of the day's entry, almost an afterthought:

Strange sound from the ridge around 9pm. Probably nothing. Wind does weird things up here.

He closed the notebook and went to sleep.

On the ridge above them, if anyone had been watching, the dark was perfectly still.

Chapter Two: The Warning

They broke camp just after eight the next morning, when the mist was still sitting low in the hollow and the creek had gone silver in the flat early light. Breakfast was instant oatmeal and bad coffee and the comfortable silence of people who didn't yet need to perform wakefulness for each other. Taylor emerged from her tent looking like she'd slept twelve hours. Sam emerged looking like she hadn't slept at all but was making peace with it.

Jordan found a spider web strung between two hemlocks, jeweled with condensation, and took six photographs of it with his phone.

"That's going to be my lockscreen," he announced.

"You said that about the gas station in Kentucky," Sam said.

"That gas station had *character*."

They were on the trail by eight-thirty, packs settled, boots laced, the mist beginning to lift as the temperature climbed by small degrees. The plan for the day was straightforward — seven miles along the ridge trail to the next backcountry site, with a side detour to a creek crossing that Alex had marked on the topo map as worth seeing. Easy enough terrain. The kind of day that was supposed to be about the walking itself, the way the body found its rhythm and the mind went quiet.

The trail took them up out of the hemlock hollow and onto the first of the long ridgelines, where the trees thinned enough that you could see out across the folded mountains in every direction — wave after wave of them, blue-grey with distance, the nearest slopes lit amber and rust and deep red where the maples had turned. The sky had cleared overnight into something high and pale, the

kind of autumn sky that felt almost fragile, like it could crack along the horizon if you looked too hard.

Riley stopped at the first overlook and stood for a long moment without saying anything.

Alex stopped beside them.

Below them, fog still pooled in the valleys between the ridges, thick and white, so that the mountain tops appeared to float like islands. It was the kind of view that did something involuntary to your chest — pressed against it from the inside, made you aware of how large the world was and how briefly you occupied it.

"I keep forgetting it looks like this," Riley said.

"I know."

"Like — I know it in my head. I've been here before. But then you see it and it's like you've never actually seen it before."

Alex looked at the side of their face. The light was good on them. It was always good on them, which he was aware was not an objective observation.

"Yeah," he said.

They stood there another minute before Casey called from behind them that she needed to keep moving or her hip flexors were going to seize up, which broke the moment cleanly, which was probably for the best.

They passed the first ranger station around eleven — a small weathered structure at a trail junction, more symbolic than staffed, with a bulletin board under a plastic cover mounted to the exterior wall. Casey stopped to read the notices the way she always stopped to read things posted in public spaces, a habit she'd had since college that everyone had long since stopped teasing her about.

The others caught up in pieces. Sam crouched to retie her boot. Jordan drank from his water bottle and looked out at the tree line.

And then a voice from the side of the station:

"You all doing the loop?"

He was older — late sixties, maybe, with the kind of weathered face that came from decades of mountain exposure rather than age alone. He wore a canvas jacket the color of dry leaves and carried a walking stick that looked like it had been cut and carved by hand, the wood worn smooth at the grip. He wasn't in a ranger uniform. Just a man who had appeared from the side of a building the way some people in remote places seemed to appear — as if they'd been there all along and you'd simply failed to notice them.

"Five days," Alex said. "Backcountry loop, up through the north ridge."

The man nodded slowly. He was looking at the group with an assessment that wasn't unfriendly but wasn't entirely casual either — the kind of look that was taking stock of something.

"North ridge takes you past the old mining area," he said. "Up past Calhoun Hollow."

"We're not planning to go off trail," Alex said.

"Nobody plans to." He shifted his weight on the walking stick. "You hear anything up on the ridge last night? Coming in?"

The question landed with a small particular weight. Alex thought of the whistle — the single clean note, the pause in his playing. He'd almost forgotten it by morning.

"Wind, maybe," he said. "Something from up the ridge. Faint."

The man looked at him for a moment. Something moved behind his eyes that was either concern or recognition — it was hard to tell which.

"There's an old thing they used to say up here," he said. "People who worked the mines, people who've been in these mountains a long time." He paused. Not for dramatic effect — it felt more like he was choosing which version of the thing to say. "Don't answer the whistle."

Nobody spoke.

"That's it?" Taylor said, and her voice came out slightly sharper than she probably intended, the sharpness of someone who was unsettled and covering it with skepticism.

"That's most of it," the man said. He looked at her evenly. "The rest of it is — if someone calls your name at night and you don't know where the voice is coming from, don't answer that either."

"What are we talking about here," Sam said. "Like — wildlife? Some kind of —"

"I'm talking about what I said." He wasn't dismissive of her question, just clear. "Don't answer the whistle. Don't follow voices after dark. And if someone in your group goes missing, don't go looking alone." He looked around at them — six faces in various states of reaction. "You seem like smart people. I'm just telling you what I know."

He touched the brim of an imaginary hat, a small automatic gesture, and walked back around the side of the station the way he'd come.

They stood in silence for a moment.

"Okay," Jordan said.

"He was just trying to spook us," Taylor said. "Local color. It's a thing people do."

"He didn't seem like he was trying to spook us," Casey said quietly. She was still looking at the corner of the building where he'd disappeared. "He seemed like he was trying to tell us something."

"Same thing," Taylor said.

"It's not, though," Casey said. "Those are actually pretty different things."

Alex had already pulled out his journal — a slim hardcover he kept in the top flap of his pack, the pages slightly warped from a rainstorm two summers ago. He wrote quickly, standing up, his handwriting smaller and more cramped than usual:

Ranger station at junction. Older man, not in uniform. Said: "Don't answer the whistle. Don't follow voices after dark. Don't go looking alone." Didn't explain further. Didn't seem like theater. Riley thinks there's something to it — didn't say so, but I could tell. Drew a rough sketch of the ridge symbol on the bulletin board

— two parallel lines with a third cutting through them at an angle. Looked old. Looked like it had been there a long time.

He closed the notebook.

"Should we be worried?" Sam asked. She was looking at Alex, which meant she was asking seriously, not rhetorically.

Alex thought about the whistle. The single clean note from up the ridge. The way his fingers had stopped on the strings.

"I think we're fine," he said. "I think we just pay attention."

It was the right thing to say. It was also, he knew, not quite an answer.

They ate lunch on a flat outcropping of rock with a long view south, the mountains layered out before them in their blue distance. Someone had left a small cairn at the edge of the overlook — stacked stones, three of them, balanced with the careful patience of a person with time and intention. Casey photographed it. Jordan added a fourth stone.

The conversation moved to other things — Sam's new apartment, Casey's job, a TV show three of them had watched and two of them refused to. The morning's encounter settled into background, the way unsettling things did when the sun was out and lunch was good and the view was long enough to make problems feel small.

But Riley caught Alex's eye once, across the group, while the others were talking.

Just a look. Brief.

I heard it too, the look said. *Last night. I didn't say anything, but I heard it.*

Alex gave a small nod.

They packed up and kept walking.

Above them, the ridge rose in its long unbroken line, dense with trees that the wind moved in slow waves. The trail wound upward between the roots and stones.

If anything was watching from up there, from the tree line where the shadows gathered thickest, it was very still. Patient in the way that things are patient when they are not in any hurry.

The group walked on, their voices carrying back down the slope, growing smaller with the distance.

Until they didn't.

Chapter Three: Off the Trail

The detour was Alex's idea, which everyone would remember later.

It wasn't off the official trail — not exactly. The topo map showed a spur path, unmarked but worn enough to suggest regular use, that broke east from the main ridge trail and dropped down through a section of old-growth forest to a creek crossing he'd read about on a hiking forum the previous winter. Someone had posted photographs: a wide shallow creek over pale limestone, a natural arch of rhododendron on the far bank, afternoon light coming through at an angle that made the water look lit from underneath. The post had forty-seven comments, most of them variations on *where is this* and *I need to go here*.

Alex had bookmarked it in February, in the particular way you bookmarked things in February when the winter was long and the idea of being outside felt theoretical.

"It's maybe a quarter mile off the main trail," he said, holding the map out so the others could see. "We come back the same way. Adds forty minutes, maybe."

"Forty minutes in hiking math or forty minutes in real math," Sam said.

"Forty-five minutes in real math."

"I'm in," Riley said.

That settled it, the way Riley's easy agreement had always had a slight gravitational effect on the group's decision-making, though nobody had ever said this aloud.

The spur path was narrower than the main trail and less maintained — roots crossed it at ankle height, and in two places the leaf litter had drifted deep enough that the path itself disappeared for a few yards, requiring them to pick their way through by instinct and the faint compression of previous footsteps in the soil. The trees here were older, the canopy closing overhead until the sky was reduced to irregular patches of pale light. The temperature dropped by a few degrees as they descended, the way temperature always dropped when you moved from ridge to hollow.

Alex led. Riley walked just behind him, close enough that he could hear them breathing on the uphill sections.

"You're quiet," Riley said.

"I'm navigating."

"You've been quiet since the ranger station."

"So have you."

A pause. The path curved around a boulder twice Alex's height, its surface covered in a thick layer of moss so vivid it looked almost artificial.

"He wasn't doing a bit," Riley said. "That man."

"No."

"The way he said it — it was like he was passing something on. Something he'd been told the same way."

Alex thought about this. It was true. There had been nothing performative about the old man's delivery — no relish, no watching for their reactions. He'd said it the way you told someone to watch for ice on a particular stretch of road. Practical. A thing you said because not saying it would be a failure of responsibility.

"Taylor's probably right that it's folklore," Alex said. "Old mining communities, remote areas — there's always something like this. Local warning stories that accumulate over generations."

"Sure," Riley said.

"But?"

"I didn't say but."

"Your voice said but."

Riley was quiet for a moment. Through the trees ahead, Alex could hear water — still distant, but present, the sound of the creek beginning to reach them.

"Last night," Riley said. "That sound from the ridge. Did it sound like wind to you?"

Alex didn't answer immediately. He held a branch back so Riley could pass.

"No," he said. "It didn't."

The creek was everything the forum post had promised.

It emerged from the forest as a widening, the trees pulling back from both banks to allow a corridor of sky overhead, and the water moved over pale flat limestone in thin clear sheets, braiding and rejoining, the sound of it filling the hollow with a clean continuous white noise that made everything else go quiet by comparison. The rhododendron arch was there on the far bank, exactly as photographed, its dark waxy leaves trembling slightly in a current of air that didn't seem to reach the creek's surface.

Sam walked straight to the bank and crouched down, trailing her fingers in the water.

"This is real," she said. "This is actually real."

Taylor sat on a flat boulder and took her boots off. Her socks were bright orange, which seemed to please her. Jordan waded in up to his ankles in his boots, making the face of a person who had decided to accept consequences.

Casey was looking at the far bank. At the rhododendron. At the shadows behind it, where the arch curved down and the undergrowth thickened into something darker.

"Does anyone else feel like this place is very quiet?" she said.

"There's a creek," Taylor said. "It's loud."

"I mean — behind the creek. Past it." Casey's voice was measured, the way her voice always was when she was thinking carefully about something. "Like the birds stopped."

Alex listened. She was right. Since they'd come down the spur path, he hadn't heard a single bird. On the main ridge trail the woods had been full of them —

the small percussion of unseen movement in branches, occasional calls. Here there was only the creek and the wind and the sound of Jordan's boots getting wet.

"Birds go quiet sometimes," Sam said, but she'd stopped trailing her fingers in the water.

"They go quiet when something's moving through," Casey said. "That's the thing they say."

"Who says that?"

"Everyone who's spent time outside says that." Casey wasn't being pointed about it. Just stating a fact. "When you stop hearing birds, it means something bigger is moving through the area."

"Or it means we made a lot of noise coming down the path and scared them off," Riley said. Gently. Not dismissively — Riley was never dismissive — but like someone offering a more comfortable interpretation as a small kindness.

Casey nodded. She accepted this. But she kept looking at the far bank.

Alex stood at the edge of the water and looked at the rhododendron arch. The light was doing something interesting in there — the shadows shifted in a way that seemed inconsistent with the movement of the leaves above. He watched for a moment. The shadows stilled.

He got out his journal.

Creek crossing, spur path east of main ridge trail. Limestone bottom, rhododendron arch, everything as described. Beautiful. But — birds silent the whole time we were here. Casey noticed first. Shadows on far bank moved strangely when we arrived. Probably just eyes adjusting to the change in light. Probably.

Reminder: ask someone who knows this area about the ridge symbol. Two parallel lines, third cutting through at an angle. Felt significant.

He snapped the notebook shut. Riley was watching him from a few feet away, sitting on a rock with their knees drawn up, eating a handful of trail mix with the methodical patience of someone fueling a machine.

"You write in that every day?" Riley asked.

"Most days."

"What do you write about?"

"Whatever seems worth keeping."

Riley considered this. "What did you just write?"

"Observations."

"About?"

Alex looked at them. At the easy way they sat, the particular quality of their attention — Riley had always looked at you like you were the only person in the room, even when there were other people in the room. It was the most disarming thing about them and always had been.

"About the birds," he said. "About the shadows."

Riley nodded slowly. They looked back at the creek, at the water moving over the pale stone.

"I think we should head back to the main trail before it gets later," they said.

"Yeah," Alex said. "Me too."

Getting the others moving took longer than it should have. Jordan had committed fully to the wet boot situation and was now sitting on a rock with both socks draped over a branch, wringing them out with the philosophical acceptance of a man past the point of regret. Taylor had fallen asleep on her boulder, which was impressive given the angle of it. Sam was skipping stones with focused competitive energy, each throw assessed and critiqued by herself in a running quiet commentary.

"Okay," Alex said. "Let's go."

"Five more minutes," Sam said.

"That's what you said five minutes ago."

"I'm improving."

He got them moving by degrees — Jordan's socks retrieved, Taylor roused with the promise of a better campsite view, Sam given the dignity of three more throws before she shouldered her pack. Casey had already shouldered hers, waiting with the patient readiness of someone who had anticipated the logistical difficulty of moving five people and had built extra time into her mental schedule.

They climbed back up the spur path in the late afternoon light, the shadows longer now, the trees darker on either side. Alex counted them automatically — a habit he'd developed without noticing, the way you counted when the stakes were low enough that counting felt like paranoia but present enough that you did it anyway.

One. Two. Three. Four. Five.

Him, six.

Good. All accounted for.

He was near the back of the group, last in line, and he paused once near the top of the spur path where it met the main ridge trail, turning back to look down at the hollow. The creek was invisible from here, just the sound of it drifting up through the trees. The rhododendron arch was somewhere down there in the darkening green.

The shadows in the hollow were very still.

He stood there for a moment longer than made sense.

Something in the way the hollow looks from up here, he would write later that night, by headlamp, while the others slept. Like it doesn't want to be looked at. Like looking at it is the beginning of something.

I don't know what that means. I'm going to leave it there and see if it means something later.

He turned and followed the others back onto the main trail. The ridge rose ahead of them, the trees dark against the fading sky.

Behind him, down in the hollow, something moved through the rhododendron with barely a sound. A slow, deliberate passage. Patient.

The creek ran on.

They made camp an hour before dark at the second backcountry site, a wider clearing than the first with a fire ring and a bear cable strung between two oaks. The mountains had gone purple in the last of the light, and the first stars were appearing in the east, and someone — it was Sam — found a fallen log the perfect height for sitting and declared it the best chair she'd ever owned.

Alex built the fire. Taylor helped without being asked, which was one of the things about Taylor that people who didn't know her well tended to miss — she operated in sudden precise bursts of usefulness that appeared without announcement and disappeared the same way.

Dinner. The easy talk of tired people. Jordan's spider web photographs, shown around on his phone with the quiet pride of an artist unveiling work. Casey reading. Sam in the best chair she'd ever owned.

And Riley, sitting beside Alex after the food was packed away, close enough that their shoulders touched, looking at the fire in the comfortable way of someone who didn't need to fill the silence.

Alex had the guitar across his knees but wasn't playing. Just holding it. The firelight moved on the spruce top.

"Are you going to play?" Riley asked.

"In a minute."

The forest around them was dark and very quiet. No birds, still. But the fire was bright and the company was good and the mountains were enormous and permanent in their ancient way, and for a while that was enough.

He started to play. A slow fingerpicked pattern, unhurried, the notes falling into the dark and dissolving. Riley made a small sound beside him — not words, just acknowledgment. The kind of sound that meant *yes, that, keep going*.

He played for twenty minutes. The fire burned down.

And when he stopped, in the silence after the last note faded, from somewhere up the ridge — closer than last night, closer by what felt like half the distance — the whistle came again.

Single note. High and clean.

Nobody spoke.

Alex's hands stayed on the guitar strings, still, the way you went still when you weren't sure if moving would make something worse.

The fire crackled. The mountains held their dark.

Then: nothing. Just the wind moving through the high branches.

"It echoes up here," Jordan said finally, his voice carefully normal. "Sound does weird things on ridges."

"Yeah," said Sam.

Nobody argued. Nobody agreed too quickly either.

Riley didn't look at Alex. But under the cover of the darkness beyond the firelight, their hand found his wrist and pressed once, briefly, and let go.

He wrote in the journal before sleep:

Whistle again. Closer. Same single note — not an echo of my playing, different pitch. Jordan says sound echoes on ridges. True enough. But it waited until I stopped playing. Both nights. It waited until the music stopped.

I don't know what to make of that.

I don't know that I want to.

Chapter Four: First Night

The dreams came strange that night.

Alex didn't remember the details when he woke — they dissolved the way dreams do, leaving only texture and residue. Something about the creek. Something about standing at the edge of the rhododendron arch and looking into the dark beyond it, and the dark looking back with the quality of attention rather than absence. He woke at 2am by his watch, heart slightly elevated, the tent black around him and the sound of the wind in the high branches coming through the nylon walls like a long slow exhale.

He lay still and listened.

Wind. The creak of an oak somewhere nearby, its weight shifting. The distant sound of the creek from the hollow below, barely audible, more felt than heard.

Nothing else.

He turned onto his side and went back to sleep, and in the morning the dream was gone entirely, leaving only a faint residue of unease that dissolved with the coffee and the cold air and the ordinary business of breaking camp.

But that was later. Before the dreams, before the waking, there had been the evening — the fire burning down to coals, the conversation going soft and unhurried the way late-night conversation did when everyone was pleasantly tired and the dark outside the firelight was complete and close.

Taylor had started it, the way Taylor sometimes started things — sideways, not quite looking at what she was actually asking about.

"So the whistle thing," she said.

The fire popped. Jordan stirred his coffee with a stick.

"What about it," Sam said.

"I'm just saying. Two nights. Same sound. Roughly the same direction." She was looking at the coals rather than anyone in particular. "I'm not saying it's — whatever the old man was implying. I'm just saying it's a pattern."

"Animals make patterns," Jordan said. "Territorial calls, mating calls. Could be something that calls from the same ridge every night."

"What animal makes a single clean whistle like that?"

"Birds do," Casey said. "Certain thrushes. The wood thrush has a —"

"It wasn't a bird," Taylor said. Not rudely. Just flatly.

Silence.

"How do you know?" Sam asked.

Taylor looked up from the coals. "Because I heard it differently than the rest of you," she said. "You were all sitting around the fire. I was at the tree line getting more wood when it happened." She paused. "It was directional. Like — it came from a specific point. Not diffuse the way bird calls are. And it wasn't continuous. It started and stopped. Deliberately."

Nobody spoke for a moment.

"Why didn't you say something?" Alex asked.

"I'm saying something now."

Riley was looking at Taylor with focused attention. "Did you hear it move? Like — was the source in the same place both nights, or different?"

Taylor thought about this. "Same general direction," she said. "But last night felt closer."

Alex thought about what he'd written in the journal. *Closer than last night, closer by what felt like half the distance.*

"Okay," Jordan said, in the tone of a man applying reason to a situation that had started to resist it. "So there's something on the ridge. An animal. Maybe a person — a hermit, a camper, someone who lives up here. That's the most likely explanation."

"A person who whistles one note every night after the music stops," Taylor said.

"People are weird," Jordan said.

This got a small strained laugh from Sam, which released something in the air around the fire. Not dissolving the tension exactly, but giving it somewhere to go.

"The old man said don't answer it," Casey said quietly. She had her notebook open in her lap, pen in hand, but she hadn't been writing. "So we haven't. That's the thing — nobody answered it. Whatever the logic of that rule is, we're following it."

"We're following it because we're sensible people who don't yell into the dark at unknown sounds," Sam said.

"Sure," Casey said. "But also — we're following it."

She wrote something in her notebook. Small, careful letters. Alex caught a glimpse of the page from where he was sitting — not enough to read, but he could see that she'd drawn something in the margin. A shape. Two lines with a third cutting through.

The ridge symbol from the bulletin board.

He looked at her. She looked back at him. Neither of them said anything about it.

They turned in by ten. The clouds had come back in, covering the stars, and the dark was total beyond the dying fire's last orange suggestion. Alex lay in his sleeping bag and listened to the tent settle around him and the wind move through the canopy in long irregular pulses.

Beside him — not beside him, they were in separate sleeping bags, there was appropriate distance — Riley's breathing had gone deep and even. Asleep within minutes, the way they'd always been able to sleep anywhere, a talent Alex had always envied. He lay awake and looked at the tent ceiling and thought about the creek hollow and the shadows and the whistle waiting for the music to stop.

It waited until I stopped playing, he'd written. Both nights.

He thought about that. What it meant, if it meant anything. Whether meaning was something he was imposing on a pattern that was random, the way humans

always imposed meaning on random patterns because the alternative — that things happened for no reason and in no particular direction — was harder to live with.

The wind moved through the trees.

He slept.

The dream:

He was at the creek. The limestone pale under clear water, the rhododendron arch on the far bank, everything as it had been in the afternoon but different in the quality of the light — or the absence of it, the hollow lit by no source he could identify, just a diffuse grey luminescence that made everything visible without casting shadows.

He was alone. The others weren't there.

The rhododendron was still.

And then — not sudden, not frightening in the way things were frightening in the moment, only in retrospect — he became aware that something on the far bank was watching him. Not visible. Not a shape or a figure. Just a quality of attention directed his way from the dark behind the arch, the specific weight of being observed by something that was very still and very patient and had been there, he understood without knowing how he understood it, for a very long time.

He didn't move.

From somewhere up the ridge, the whistle came. Single note. High and clean.

In the dream, without deciding to, he opened his mouth.

And then he woke up.

2am. Heart elevated. The tent dark around him.

He lay still for a long time, listening to Riley breathe beside him, listening to the wind, listening for the whistle. It didn't come. The mountains were quiet.

I almost answered, he thought. *In the dream, I almost answered.*

He told himself it was just a dream. That dreams were the mind processing the day's input, filing things away, constructing narratives from whatever material was available. He'd been thinking about the whistle before he fell asleep. Of course it showed up in his dreams.

Of course.

He got out his journal and wrote in the dark by feel, the words slightly unsteady on the page:

Woke at 2am. Dream about the creek. The arch. Something watching from the far bank — no shape, just presence. Whistle in the dream. I almost —

He stopped. Looked at what he'd written.

Woke at 2am. Dream about the creek.

He crossed out everything after that. Closed the notebook.

Lay back down. Listened to Riley breathe.

After a long time, he slept again.

Morning came grey and cold, the clouds sitting low on the ridge, and Alex emerged from the tent to find Casey already up and sitting on the log by the dead fire with both hands wrapped around her camp mug, looking at the middle distance with the expression of someone who had been awake for a while.

"Morning," Alex said.

"Morning."

He started rebuilding the fire from the coals, a task that gave his hands something to do. Casey watched.

"Did you sleep okay?" she asked.

"More or less. You?"

A pause. "I heard something at about two in the morning," she said. "From outside the tent." She was speaking carefully, the way she spoke when she was describing something precisely. "Not the whistle. Closer than that. Like — movement. In the trees just at the edge of camp."

Alex looked up from the fire.

"Animal, probably," he said.

"Probably." She looked at her mug. "It stopped when I unzipped my tent a few inches to look. Whatever it was. And then it was just quiet." She paused. "But it was quiet in a specific way. Like something had stopped moving rather than nothing being there."

Alex held her gaze for a moment.

"Casey," he said. "Are you scared?"

She considered the question with her usual seriousness, not dismissing it. "I'm alert," she said finally. "There's a difference."

"Yeah," he said. "There is."

The fire caught. Small yellow flames worked their way up through the kindling. Alex sat back on his heels and watched them grow, feeling the first thin warmth on his hands.

"The symbol you drew in your notebook last night," he said. "The one from the bulletin board."

Casey looked at him carefully. "You saw that."

"Just the shape. Not what you wrote."

She was quiet for a moment. "I've seen it before," she said. "Not here. In a book — a collection of Appalachian folk symbols, mountain community markings. I

read it years ago." She paused. "I couldn't remember what it meant. I've been trying to remember since we passed that station."

"And?"

She looked back at the fire. "I still can't," she said. "But I remember that it was a warning. The ones in the book that looked like that — they were all warnings." She paused. "Markers. Put somewhere to tell people not to go further."

They sat with that for a moment.

"And we went further," Alex said.

"Yes," Casey said. "We did."

The others began to wake around them — the small sounds of tent zippers, the shuffle of boots, Jordan's voice saying something that made Sam laugh from inside her tent. The ordinary morning machinery of the group starting up, warming up, the social engine turning over.

Alex looked out past the clearing, into the trees where the ridge rose above them, invisible in the low cloud.

We went further, he thought.

He wrote it in the journal later, after breakfast, before they packed up:

Casey heard movement at the edge of camp at 2am — same time I woke from the dream. She said it stopped when she looked. Like it knew she was looking.

The symbol is a warning. We're past it.

Seven miles further in today. The mine area is still days away — we don't have to go near it. We stay on the trail, we don't answer the whistle, we pay attention.

We're fine.

He read that last line back.

Closed the notebook.

Shouldered his pack.

Chapter Five: The Sound Again

The fog came in around midday.

Not dramatically — not the sudden wall of white that happened in movies, rolling in from nowhere with obvious intent. It came the way fog came in the Smokies, which was gradually and from everywhere at once, seeping up from the hollows and down from the ridge tops simultaneously until the middle distance simply ceased to exist. One minute you could see fifty yards through the trees. Then forty. Then twenty. Then the world ended at the nearest trunks and everything beyond was white and featureless and still.

They were four miles into the day's stretch when it closed in fully, and Alex called a brief stop at a flat section of trail where a fallen beech made a natural bench. He got out the map and compass — his phone's GPS had been unreliable since yesterday afternoon, dropping signal in the hollows — and confirmed what he already knew, which was that they were exactly where they should be and the trail ahead was straightforward and the fog was an inconvenience rather than a danger.

He said this to the group.

"It feels like a danger," Sam said pleasantly.

"Feelings and facts," Alex said.

"Are both valid," Sam said. "I read that somewhere."

"On a coffee mug," Taylor said.

"Knowledge doesn't care about the vessel."

They walked slower in the fog. This was instinctive rather than decided — the pace dropped the way conversation dropped when something changed in the environment, the body making adjustments the mind hadn't caught up to yet. Footsteps became more deliberate. The space between hikers shrank. Jordan, who had been ranging ahead and behind all morning with the restless energy of someone who processed landscape by moving through it quickly, pulled in closer to the group and stayed there.

The trail wound along the eastern flank of the ridge, neither climbing nor descending significantly, the trees on both sides close and dark in the fog. Water dripped from the canopy in a slow irregular percussion. Everything smelled of wet earth and bark and the particular cold mineral smell of fog at elevation, the smell of clouds made solid.

Riley walked beside Alex.

They'd fallen into this arrangement naturally over the first two days — not by design, just by the repeated small choices of proximity that added up to a pattern. Riley would drift into step beside him on the longer flat sections. Alex would slow fractionally when he heard their pace behind him. Neither of them had remarked on it.

"Tell me something," Riley said.

"What kind of something?"

"Something you've been thinking about. Not the trail. Not the whistle." A pause.
"Just — something."

Alex considered. The fog moved around them. Somewhere above, invisible, a branch dripped steadily onto a lower branch onto the trail surface.

"I've been thinking about the fact that we're all worse at keeping in touch than we think we are," he said. "Like — I genuinely believed I was staying connected to everyone. Texts, occasional calls. I thought we were all fine." He paused. "And then I got in a van with these people and realized I'd missed eighteen months of actual information. Jordan and Priya might be breaking up. Sam changed jobs twice. Casey moved across the city and I didn't even know."

"You knew she moved," Riley said.

"I knew in a general sense. I didn't know the specifics. I didn't know she'd hated the process and that her new place is smaller and that she cried about it." He paused. "She told me that yesterday when we were filtering water. Just — casually. Like it was old information. It wasn't old to me."

Riley was quiet for a moment. The trail curved around a large outcropping, the rock face bearded with moss that dripped steadily in the fog.

"I think that's just what happens," Riley said. "It's not failure. It's just what happens to time when you're not careful."

"Are we careful enough?"

Riley looked at him sideways. The fog softened everything — their features, the trees, the distance. "I don't know," they said. "I think we're trying." A pause. "I think this trip is trying."

Alex thought about the eighteen months of missed specifics. The texts that had felt like maintenance and apparently hadn't been. The particular cruelty of believing you were present in someone's life while missing the texture of it entirely.

"I should have planned this sooner," he said.

"You planned it when you planned it," Riley said. "That's when it happened. There's no sooner that exists."

This was the kind of thing Riley said that Alex had spent years trying to decide if it was wisdom or deflection. He'd concluded it was usually both, which was its own kind of wisdom.

They stopped for water at a creek crossing — a narrow channel, easily stepped across, running fast in the fog — and while the others filled bottles and ran them through filters, Taylor sat on a root at the trail's edge and ate an energy bar with the methodical focus of someone fueling up rather than eating.

She'd been quieter than usual today. Not withdrawn exactly — Taylor's version of quiet was still more present than most people's engaged — but turned inward, processing something.

Casey sat beside her. Not asking. Just present.

After a moment Taylor said, without preamble: "You know what bothers me most about the whistle thing?"

"Tell me," Casey said.

"That I want to answer it." She said it flatly, examining it. "Not — not like I'm going to. I'm not an idiot. But there's a part of my brain that hears that sound and wants to respond. Like a reflex." She finished the energy bar, folded the wrapper precisely. "My brain keeps framing it as a signal. Like something that needs acknowledgment."

Casey looked at her carefully. "That might be exactly how it works," she said.

Taylor looked back. "What do you mean?"

"I mean —" Casey paused, choosing her words. "If the old man's warning has any basis in real observed behavior, then whatever makes that sound has probably adapted to make it compelling. To make the response feel instinctive." She paused. "Predators do that. Sounds that trigger response. Certain birds mimic distress calls to draw other species."

"You're saying it's evolved to make us want to answer."

"I'm saying it might have. I don't know what it is." Casey looked at the creek, the fast cold water. "I'm just saying — the urge you're describing makes sense. It doesn't mean anything is wrong with you. It might mean you're paying attention."

Taylor was quiet for a moment.

"That's either very reassuring," she said, "or extremely not."

"Yes," Casey said. "I know."

They were two miles from the day's campsite when Alex heard it.

Not at dusk, not after dark, not in the night silence after the music stopped. Mid-afternoon, the fog still thick, the group strung out along a straight section of trail — Jordan and Sam ahead, visible but barely, their shapes going in and out of the white; Riley beside Alex; Taylor and Casey behind.

A whistle.

Not from the ridge. From the left side of the trail, maybe thirty yards into the trees. A single note, the same pitch as before, but closer. Much closer.

Alex stopped walking. Riley stopped beside him.

Ahead, Jordan and Sam kept moving — they hadn't heard it, or the fog had carried the sound differently, or they'd heard it and dismissed it in the same motion.

"Alex," Riley said quietly.

"I heard it."

They stood still. The fog moved between the trees in slow eddies. Water dripped from branches. The trail ahead showed Jordan and Sam's shapes receding into the white.

Thirty yards into the trees to the left: nothing visible. Just trunks and fog and the dark spaces between.

Alex became aware of something that wasn't quite sound — more like the feeling of sound, the sense that the air in the trees to the left had a texture that the rest of the air didn't. Like something occupying space in there. Like displacement.

He did not look directly at it. He wasn't sure why. It seemed important not to look directly at it.

"Keep walking," he said. Quietly. Calmly. The voice he used when he needed people to do something without turning it into a thing.

Riley didn't argue. They started walking. Alex fell into step beside them, pace measured, not hurrying. Behind them he heard Taylor's and Casey's footsteps resume without prompting — they'd stopped too, had heard it too, and they were doing the same thing he was doing, which was moving without appearing to flee.

Thirty yards to the left.

He didn't look.

They walked.

After two minutes the sensation — the textured quality of the air in the trees — faded. Or he moved out of the range of it. Or it withdrew. He couldn't have said which.

Jordan and Sam were waiting at a bend in the trail ahead, having noticed the gap.

"You guys stop for something?" Sam asked.

"Bootlace," Riley said, without hesitating.

"Ah." Sam accepted this and turned back to the trail.

Alex and Riley exchanged a look. Then they walked on.

He didn't write about it immediately. He held it for the rest of the afternoon, turning it over, waiting to see if it clarified or compounded. It was only after camp was set up and dinner was done and the others were settling into the evening's rhythms that he opened the journal.

Heard the whistle at 2:47pm. Daytime. Fog. Thirty yards left of trail, not from the ridge — from ground level, in the trees. Same pitch. Riley heard it. Taylor and Casey heard it — they stopped without being told.

Jordan and Sam didn't hear it. The fog was carrying sound inconsistently, or they were too far ahead. Or it wasn't for them.

He stopped. Read that last sentence back.

Or it wasn't for them.

He left it. Continued:

I didn't look directly at it. Don't know why. Felt like the right instinct. We kept walking, normal pace. It didn't follow — or if it did, I couldn't tell.

The guitar is in my pack. I haven't taken it out today. Haven't wanted to.

Tomorrow is day three. We're almost at the halfway point of the loop. Two more days in, two days out. We could turn around from here — take the access trail back to the trailhead, three hours, out by dark.

I'm not going to suggest it. I don't think I need to. But I'm noting that the option exists.

He looked at that last line.

Added: Nobody is going to suggest it. That's also worth noting. Why aren't we suggesting it?

He didn't have an answer. He closed the notebook.

Around the fire, Jordan was telling a story about a work trip to Portland that had gone wrong in a series of escalating and apparently hilarious ways. Sam was laughing. Taylor was smiling despite herself. Casey was writing in her notebook. Riley was looking at the fire.

Alex looked at the tree line. At the darkness between the trunks where the firelight didn't reach.

He stayed looking for a long time.

If anything looked back, it was very still about it.

Later — after Jordan's story wound down and the fire was low and people were drifting toward their tents — Riley stopped beside Alex on their way past.

Not sitting down. Just stopping. Standing close in the dark.

"I keep thinking about what you said," Riley said quietly. "About missing eighteen months."

"Yeah."

"I think I've missed more than that." They weren't looking at him. Looking at the fire's last light. "I think I got comfortable with the idea of people and stopped paying attention to the actual people." A pause. "That's a hard thing to realize about yourself."

"You're realizing it," Alex said.

"Late."

"Still counts."

Riley looked at him then. In the dark, with the fire almost out, their expression was hard to read precisely. But the quality of it was something — open in a way they didn't usually allow, the careful management of their face set aside for a moment.

"I'm glad we came," they said.

"Me too," Alex said.

Riley's hand found his arm briefly — not the wrist this time, the arm, just above the elbow — and pressed once.

Then they went to their tent.

Alex stood by the dead fire alone for a moment, the mountains dark and enormous around him, the fog still in the hollows below. He was aware of his own heartbeat in a way that had nothing to do with fear.

He looked up at the ridge.

Somewhere up there, something was quiet.

Waiting, maybe.

Or just there.

He went to his tent.

Behind him, at the edge of the firelight's last reach, in the space between two hemlocks where the darkness was complete, the air moved. Once. Slowly.

Like breathing.

Chapter Six: The Voice

The morning of day three began with an argument about eggs.

Not real eggs — the powdered kind, the ones Casey had packed in a ziplock labeled *SCRAMBLED (optimistic)* in her precise handwriting. The argument was about whether they were edible, which Jordan maintained they were not, and whether Jordan's opinion on food was credible, which Taylor maintained it was not, given that he had once voluntarily eaten gas station sushi on a road trip through Ohio.

"That was a dare," Jordan said.

"You did it without being dared," Taylor said. "I was there."

"I was very hungry."

"You'd eaten an hour before."

This went on for a while. Sam ate the eggs without comment, which was either a verdict or just hunger. Casey ate them slowly, with the expression of someone taking detailed mental notes. Alex made oatmeal and stayed out of it.

Riley laughed at something Jordan said — the short real laugh — and Alex felt the morning settle around him like something functional. Like a thing that worked. Six people in the mountains, the fog gone overnight and the sky a clean pale blue, the trees lit gold where the early sun caught the turning leaves. The argument about eggs was the kind of argument that existed to fill space pleasantly, the verbal equivalent of passing a ball back and forth, and it was good. It was genuinely good.

He held onto that.

They broke camp efficiently and were on the trail by eight-thirty, the same time as the previous mornings, a rhythm establishing itself without being mandated. The trail today climbed more seriously — the topo map showed a sustained ascent over the first three miles, gaining twelve hundred feet before leveling along the upper ridge. Alex had flagged it in his planning as the hardest day's hiking, which meant Jordan had immediately designated it his favorite.

Jordan was a specific type of person who got better the harder things got, which Alex had always found both admirable and slightly exhausting.

The climb broke the group into its natural fragments — Jordan out front, Sam close behind him with the steady pace of someone who didn't sprint but never flagged, Taylor moving in her characteristic efficient way that somehow covered ground without appearing to hurry. Casey and Riley mid-pack. Alex near the back, which was where he always ended up, the instinct to count pulling him to the rear position where he could see everyone ahead.

One. Two. Three. Four. Five.

Six with himself.

Good.

The forest changed with the elevation — the hemlocks and beeches of the lower slopes giving way to spruce and fir as they climbed, the trees shorter and more wind-shaped, their branches bent all in one direction as if still remembering the last big storm. The light was different up here, sharper and more direct, the canopy thinner. You could see further.

Alex wasn't sure if that was better or worse.

The first thing happened at the top of the climb.

They'd reached a flat section where the trail ran along the actual crest of the ridge — a narrow spine with long views on both sides, the mountains falling away east and west into their blue distances. It was the kind of place that earned the climb, and they stopped without discussing it, letting the views do what views did, the bodies glad for flat ground.

Sam had walked to the eastern edge, where the ridge dropped sharply into a hollow far below. She stood there with her hands in her jacket pockets looking out.

And then she turned back to the group with an expression Alex couldn't immediately read.

"Did one of you just say my name?" she asked.

They looked at each other.

"No," Jordan said.

"Nobody said anything," Taylor said. "We just got up here."

Sam looked back toward the drop-off. Then back at them. "I heard my name," she said. "Clear as anything. From —" she gestured vaguely downslope, toward the eastern hollow. "From down there."

Silence.

"Echo?" Jordan offered. "Sound carries weird on ridges, we said that —"

"I know what an echo sounds like," Sam said. She wasn't frightened, exactly. She was using the same precise tone Casey used when she was being careful about something. "It wasn't an echo of anything anyone said. It was my name. Someone said my name."

Alex looked at the hollow. The trees fell away below them in a long dense slope, and the bottom of it was in shadow, and there was nothing visible down there but green going dark going nothing.

"Was it a voice you recognized?" Casey asked.

Sam looked at her. Something passed between them. "Yeah," Sam said quietly. "Actually. Yeah, it was."

"Whose?" Alex asked.

Sam shook her head. Not refusing to answer — more like she didn't want to say it out loud. Like saying it would do something. Make it more real or give it more weight than she wanted it to have.

"It doesn't matter," she said. "It wasn't — nobody's down there. I know that." She turned back to the view, deliberately. Resetting. "I just wanted to check if I was the only one who heard something."

"You're not always the only one," Riley said carefully.

Sam looked at them. "The whistle?"

"And other things."

Sam nodded slowly. She looked back at the eastern hollow one more time. Then she stepped away from the edge and shouldered her pack.

"Okay," she said. "Let's keep moving."

They didn't talk about it on the trail. This was a group decision made without discussion, the way some group decisions were — everyone independently arriving at the same conclusion that the thing did not need to be processed out loud, at least not yet. The walking continued. The ridge narrowed and then widened. The views came and went as the tree cover varied.

But Alex noticed the way Sam stayed in the middle of the group for the rest of the morning, not ranging up to walk beside Jordan the way she usually did. And the way she didn't put her earbuds in, which she did most mornings after the first hour. And the way she checked behind her twice on a straight section of trail, casual enough that you could miss it if you weren't paying attention.

He was paying attention.

Riley fell back to walk beside him around noon.

"She heard a voice," Riley said quietly. Not a question.

"Yeah."

"Not the whistle. An actual voice saying her name."

"That's what she said."

Riley walked in silence for a moment. The trail had leveled out and they were moving through a section of old spruce, the trees close on both sides, their roots breaking through the trail surface in complex patterns that required attention underfoot.

"The ranger," Riley said. "He said — don't follow voices after dark."

"After dark," Alex said. "It was mid-morning."

"I know." A pause. "I'm just noting what he said versus what's happening."

Alex looked ahead at the others. Jordan telling Sam something, Sam's posture slightly loosened — Jordan was good at that, the unconscious project of making people comfortable just by being himself near them. Taylor and Casey walking close, Casey's head slightly tilted in a way that meant she was thinking hard about something.

"It mimics voices," Riley said. "That's what you think."

"I don't know what I think."

"Yes you do."

Alex was quiet for a moment. The spruce trees moved around them.

"The forum post," he said finally. "The one about the creek crossing. The comments. One of them — I didn't think about it much at the time — one of them said something like *beautiful spot but we had a strange experience the second night, heard people calling from the trees, turned out to be nothing*. I remember thinking it was just someone being atmospheric." He paused. "It's a thing people do in outdoor forums. Add a spooky line for flavor."

"But now."

"But now I'm thinking about it."

Riley nodded. They walked.

"It learns voices," Riley said. "Hears them and uses them."

"That's folklore logic," Alex said. "That's the kind of thing that gets attached to stories in mountain communities to make them more compelling."

"Sure," Riley said. "Or it's the part of the story that got attached because it was true and people needed to warn each other."

Alex had no answer for that.

They ate lunch at a trail junction where a wooden sign pointed left toward a fire tower, two miles. The sign was old, its lettering faded, and someone had carved something into the post below the official text. Alex looked at it for a long time before he placed it.

Two parallel lines. A third cutting through at an angle.

The ridge symbol.

It had been carved deep, the edges worn smooth by weather and time. Old. Much older than the sign itself, which meant someone had added it after the fact, or the sign had been replaced and the carver had transferred the mark. Either way — deliberate. Someone had wanted it here, at this junction, at the place where the trail split.

Casey saw him looking. She came to stand beside him.

"Left goes to the fire tower," Alex said.

"Yes."

"Which means left goes further up the ridge."

"Yes," Casey said. "And the symbol is on the post, not the sign itself. The sign tells you where to go. The symbol tells you something else."

"Don't go further," Alex said.

"That's my best guess." She looked at the mark. "The mine area is up there. Past the fire tower, off trail." She paused. "We're not going to the mine."

"No," Alex agreed. "We're not."

They ate lunch on the right side of the junction, backs to the sign. Nobody suggested the fire tower detour, which two days ago would have been exactly the kind of thing Jordan would have proposed. Nobody mentioned the symbol. They ate and drank water and Jordan found a beetle of unusual size and documented it extensively with his phone and Sam explained to him, at length, that beetles were not interesting, and Jordan explained to Sam, with equal length and greater patience, that she was wrong about that.

The ordinary business of them. Alex held onto it.

The campsite for the night was a wide clearing beside a seasonal stream, the water reduced by the dry autumn to a trickle over mossy stones. They set up camp with the practiced efficiency of the third day, everyone knowing their tasks, the tents going up quickly, the fire ring cleared and laid before the light started to go.

Alex did not take out the guitar.

This was noticed. Not commented on, but noticed — he saw Riley's eyes move to his pack, where the guitar's neck protruded from the side pocket, and then move away. He saw Jordan glance at it and then start a different conversation.

They all knew, without discussing it, that something had changed about the guitar. About music in general, out here. The pattern was there whether they'd named it or not: the whistle came after the playing. The whistle came in the silence the playing left behind.

So the guitar stayed in the pack.

Dinner was quieter than previous nights. Not uncomfortable — just reduced. The group seemed to have settled into a lower register, the high-energy conversational mode of the first day replaced by something more watchful. More interior.

Sam was sitting close to Jordan, their shoulders touching, and Alex thought she probably didn't know she'd done it.

After dinner, while Casey wrote and Taylor stared at the fire with her particular focused intensity and Jordan showed Sam the beetle photos with aggressive enthusiasm, Riley moved to sit beside Alex on the log at the fire's edge.

"I'm going to tell you something," Riley said quietly.

"Okay."

"And I want you to just hear it. You don't have to respond to it."

Alex looked at them. "Okay."

Riley looked at the fire. "Three years ago," they said. "When I went quiet. When I stopped reaching out to everyone." A pause. "It wasn't because I stopped caring. I want you to know that. I know I let it — I let too much time go by. I know what that looked like." Another pause, smaller. "But it wasn't because I stopped."

Alex was quiet. He'd promised to just hear it.

He heard it.

After a moment Riley looked at him. The firelight was moving on their face.

"I know," Alex said. And then, because it was true and because the mountains were dark around them and because three years was a long time: "I know it wasn't."

Riley held his gaze for a moment. Then they looked back at the fire.

They sat there for a long time, shoulders touching, not talking.

The stream trickled over its mossy stones somewhere in the dark. The fire burned steadily. Above them, through the clearing, the stars were extraordinary — dense and cold, the Milky Way a visible smear from horizon to horizon.

It was peaceful. It was genuinely, specifically peaceful, and Alex was aware of it the way you were aware of good things when you'd learned to pay attention to them while they were happening.

And then, from somewhere in the trees behind the camp — not the ridge, not the hollow, but close, within the dark ring just beyond the firelight — his name.

His name, in a voice.

Not the whistle. A voice. Clear and deliberate and familiar in a way that hit him somewhere below thought, below reason, the animal part of the brain that recognized voices before the conscious mind had time to process.

His mother's voice.

Alex.

Just that. Just his name.

He went perfectly still. Beside him, Riley had gone still too.

The fire crackled. The stars burned. The stream ran.

He did not answer.

He did not turn around.

He sat with his hands on his knees and his eyes on the fire and he did not make a sound, and after a long moment — ten seconds, thirty, he couldn't have said — the night went quiet again.

Riley's hand found his. Not his wrist, not his arm. His hand. Their fingers laced through his and held.

He held back.

Neither of them said anything.

Later, in the journal, he wrote only this:

It knows our voices. It's been listening. It used one tonight and it used the right one — the one I would have answered without thinking. The one that would have had me on my feet and turning around before I knew I was moving.

I didn't answer.

I have to keep not answering.

I don't know how long that stays easy.

Chapter Seven: First Disappearance

Nobody slept well.

This wasn't discussed in the morning but it was evident — in the particular flatness behind Jordan's eyes that meant he'd been awake too long, in the way Sam moved through the camp breakdown with less of her usual commentary, in Taylor emerging from her tent already fully dressed as if she'd never quite committed to sleep in the first place. Casey had dark circles she wasn't trying to hide. Riley drank two cups of coffee standing up, looking at the tree line with the focused patience of someone standing watch.

Alex had written in the journal until nearly midnight, then lain awake until well past it.

He'd written:

Question: if it can mimic voices, how long has it been listening? Since the first night? Since we arrived at the trailhead? Since before that — is there a range, a perimeter, some boundary we crossed before we knew we were crossing anything?

Follow-up question: does it matter? We're here now.

The voice sounded exactly right. Not approximately. Exactly. The specific cadence my mother uses when she's calling me from another room. The slight rise at the end. I've heard that sound ten thousand times. It reached into wherever sounds like that are stored and pulled out a perfect copy.

How many times has it heard us? How carefully has it been listening?

He'd stopped there because the direction the questions were going wasn't useful.

Breakfast was oatmeal and silence broken by the necessary logistics of the day. They were at the midpoint of the loop — two and a half days in, two and a half days out. Alex spread the topo map on the flattest section of ground and went through the plan: today's route took them along the upper ridge before dropping into the northern hollow, a gentler day than yesterday's climb, six miles to the next campsite. The mine area was marked on the map as a historical notation —

Calhoun Mine (disused, est. 1887–1923) — roughly a mile off the trail to the northwest, up a drainage that the map showed as intermittent stream.

"We're not going near the mine," Alex said.

"No argument," Taylor said.

"Just so it's said out loud."

"It's said," Jordan confirmed.

Casey was looking at the map. At the drainage that led to the mine. At the ridge symbol Alex had penciled in from memory at the trail junction yesterday — he'd added it to the map as a reference, small and careful in the margin.

She didn't say anything. She folded her side of the map and helped pack it away.

They set out into a morning that had cleared completely, the sky a hard autumn blue, the temperature cold enough to see breath for the first hour. The trail ran north along the ridge crest, the views enormous on both sides, the world below them layered in haze and color. It should have felt expansive. It did feel expansive. It also felt, in a way Alex couldn't precisely articulate, observed.

He counted. One through six. Everyone present. Good.

Jordan set the pace today — slower than his usual, Alex noticed, which meant Jordan was also recalibrated, the relentless forward energy modulated into something more measured. Sam walked beside him. Their conversation was quieter than usual, words exchanged in the lower register that the mountains seemed to call for today.

Two miles in, the trail descended from the ridge crest into a section of dense rhododendron — a tunnel of it, the branches arching overhead, the light going green and filtered. The kind of place that was beautiful in photographs and slightly claustrophobic in person, the path hemmed on both sides by the thick waxy growth, visibility reduced to the few yards ahead.

It was in the rhododendron tunnel that Alex first noticed Taylor falling behind.

Not dramatically — just a gradual increase in the gap between her and the main group. He slowed. She was moving at her usual pace, maybe slightly less than usual, her head slightly tilted as if listening for something. He waited for her to close the distance. She didn't increase her pace.

"Taylor," he said.

She looked up. "What?"

"You're falling back."

"I know." She didn't sound distressed. She sounded like someone walking and thinking simultaneously. "I'm fine."

He waited for her to come alongside him. She did.

"What are you listening for?" he asked quietly.

She looked at him. For a moment she seemed to be deciding something. "You know how I said I wanted to answer it," she said. "The whistle."

"Yeah."

"It hasn't stopped." She said it plainly, no drama in it. "The feeling. The — it's like a pull. Like something tugging at the back of my attention." She paused. "I thought it would go away but it keeps getting stronger."

Alex looked at her carefully. She looked like herself — same flat precise gaze, same economy of expression. But there was something underneath it, some layer of effort that shouldn't have been required for a normal conversation.

"Does anyone else feel it?" she asked.

"I don't know," he said honestly. "You're the first one to name it."

"But?"

"But I haven't been wanting to name things."

Taylor nodded. "That's what I thought." She looked ahead at the rhododendron tunnel, the path curving away into the green. "I'm not going to answer it. I want to be clear about that. I'm telling you because someone should know."

"Thank you," Alex said.

"Don't thank me. Just —" she paused. "Just keep an eye."

"On you?"

"On everyone."

They emerged from the rhododendron into a wide flat section where the trail crossed an old logging road, two deep tire ruts grown over with grass, barely recognizable as anything man-made. A wooden marker confirmed the trail route. Casey stopped to photograph it — the reclamation of it, the way the forest had been quietly absorbing the evidence of human presence for decades.

They stopped for water.

Alex counted. One. Two. Three. Four. Five.

He counted again.

Five.

He turned around. The rhododendron tunnel entrance behind them, dark green and close.

"Where's Jordan?" he asked.

Heads turned. The group looked at each other — the moment of collective uncertainty, each person assuming Jordan was just behind them or just ahead.

"He was right here," Sam said. And then, immediately, her voice changing: "He was right behind me in the tunnel."

"How far back?" Alex said.

"I don't — I wasn't watching. We were talking and then I was out and I assumed —"

"Jordan!" Taylor called.

The rhododendron tunnel absorbed her voice. Nothing came back.

"Jordan!" Sam, louder.

The forest. The wind. The distant sound of a bird, first one they'd heard in a while, and then silence.

Alex was already moving back toward the tunnel. "Stay together," he said. "Everyone together, right behind me."

They went back in.

The tunnel was maybe two hundred yards long — it hadn't felt that long going through it, but returning now with the light at the wrong angle and Jordan missing it felt very long. The rhododendron pressed in on both sides. Their footsteps on the packed earth. Five sets of breathing.

Alex moved at a pace that was faster than a walk and slower than running, the pace of controlled urgency.

"Jordan!" Casey, her voice steady.

Twenty yards in. Fifty. The tunnel curved, the exit behind them gone, just green on all sides now.

"There," Riley said.

Jordan was standing in the rhododendron about ten yards off the right side of the trail, his back to them, his pack still on, facing into the dense growth where the branches closed in and the light gave out entirely. Standing still. The absolute stillness of him was the first wrong thing — Jordan was never still, Jordan was in constant low-level motion, shifting weight, turning, reacting to things.

He was not moving at all.

"Jordan." Alex stepped off the trail, pushing through the rhododendron branches. The others followed.

Jordan didn't turn.

Alex reached him. Put a hand on his shoulder. "Jordan."

Jordan startled — a full-body flinch, spinning around, his eyes wide. For just a moment — a fraction of a second — his face showed something Alex didn't have a name for. Not fear exactly. Something more like interrupted concentration. Something like the expression of a person pulled back from somewhere they'd been about to go.

Then it collapsed back into Jordan's face. Normal Jordan. Slightly confused Jordan.

"What — sorry, what happened?" He looked around at them. At the rhododendron. At the trail, visible ten yards away. "Why are we off the trail?"

"You walked off it," Sam said. She was looking at him with unconcealed concern. "You just — you went into the rhododendron and stopped."

Jordan looked at the dense growth behind him. At the dark where the branches closed in. "I don't —" He stopped. Shook his head. "I heard something," he said slowly. "I heard — I thought someone called my name."

Sam's expression changed. She looked at Alex.

"Which direction?" Alex asked.

Jordan pointed into the rhododendron. Into the dark behind him, toward the northwest. Toward the drainage. Toward the mine.

"Did you answer?" Alex asked.

Jordan looked at him. Something in the directness of the question registered — Alex wasn't asking casually.

"I said yeah," Jordan said. "Like — reflexively. I said yeah and then I went toward it." He paused. "I don't remember walking off the trail. I remember hearing my name and then I was — here. Facing that."

He looked at the dark in the rhododendron. His face, normally so readable, had gone temporarily opaque.

"Okay," Alex said. "You're okay. Let's get back on the trail."

"Alex —"

"Trail first. Talk after. Come on."

They came out of the rhododendron tunnel into the flat section and stood in the open air and nobody said anything for a moment. Jordan was looking at his hands. Sam had her hand on his arm. Taylor was watching the tunnel entrance with an expression that had gone past her usual flatness into something quieter and harder.

Casey looked at Alex.

Alex looked back at her.

He answered it, her look said.

I know, his said.

"Alright," Alex said to the group. He kept his voice even. Steady. The same voice as *keep walking* in the fog. "Here's what we know. There's something in these woods that mimics voices. It used Sam's voice yesterday morning on the ridge. It used — another voice last night at camp. It used someone's voice to get Jordan off the trail." He paused. "It seems to be using voices we recognize. Personal ones. And it seems like responding to it — even reflexively, even just a yeah — does something. We don't know exactly what. But Jordan was walking toward the mine drainage and he doesn't remember deciding to do it."

Jordan looked up at him.

"I'm not saying anything is wrong with you," Alex said. "I'm saying we now have a rule. If you hear a voice and you're not certain where it's coming from, you do not respond. You stop walking. You say out loud to the group — I heard something. That's it. Okay?"

Nods. Jordan's after a moment.

"Do we turn back?" Sam asked.

Alex had been waiting for someone to ask. Waiting to hear how he'd answer.

"We're a mile past the halfway point," he said. "Going back means two and a half days in the same area we've already been in. Going forward gets us out in two and a half days." He paused. "I think forward is the same risk as back. Maybe less, because we're heading away from —" he gestured at the drainage, the northwest, the unseen mine "— from whatever's concentrated up there."

This was true as far as it went. He believed it as far as it went.

"Okay," Casey said quietly.

"Okay," Taylor said.

Sam looked at Jordan. Jordan looked at the trail ahead.

"Forward," he said.

They walked.

Alex was last. He stood for a moment at the tunnel entrance and looked at the place where Jordan had been standing — the faint compression of rhododendron branches, already springing back, already erasing the evidence. The dark behind it. The northwest and the drainage and the mine somewhere up there, disused since 1923, its entrance hidden in the undergrowth.

He thought about a miner who had answered the whistle. He thought about what the ranger had said — *the first one answered, the rest followed*. He thought about Jordan's face in that fraction of a second before it became Jordan's face again, the interrupted concentration, the somewhere he'd been about to go.

He turned and walked after the others.

In his journal, that evening, written fast and close:

Jordan answered it. Said yeah, reflexive, didn't think. Walked off trail toward mine drainage. Doesn't remember walking. I've set a rule — don't respond, say you heard something, stop.

He seems fine. He seems like Jordan. I'm watching.

Taylor told me this morning she feels a constant pull toward it. I believe her. I'm watching her too.

New rule, not said aloud: I count every thirty minutes. Six people. If the count is wrong, we stop immediately.

I counted at the tunnel exit: six.

I counted at the campsite arrival: six.

I'll count again before sleep.

Six. For now, six.

Chapter Eight: Search Party / First Gore

The campsite was a hollow in the truest sense of the word.

Three sided by ridge, open only to the south, the trees so dense overhead that the stars were visible only in a narrow corridor directly above the clearing. It felt enclosed in a way the previous sites hadn't — protected, potentially, or contained, depending on how you chose to interpret it. Alex chose protected and kept the other interpretation in a secondary part of his mind where it wouldn't do damage.

They set up camp faster than any previous night. Nobody suggested spreading out. The tents went up close together, closer than necessary, the kind of proximity that on the first night would have felt like overcrowding and now felt like sense. Jordan hammered his stakes with more force than required. Sam didn't offer commentary on this.

The fire was large. This was a group decision made without words — more wood gathered than usual, the ring built up higher, the light thrown further into the surrounding dark. It didn't reach far. The hollow absorbed it.

Alex cooked. The mechanical focus of it was useful — water temperatures, timing, the small precise tasks that occupied the hands and gave the mind something to organize around. Riley sat nearby and didn't try to fill the silence, which was one of the things about Riley that had always worked on him in ways he couldn't fully defend against.

"How's Jordan?" Riley asked quietly, while the others were occupied.

Alex glanced across the fire. Jordan was sitting with Sam, their conversation low and continuous — Sam talking, Jordan mostly listening, nodding occasionally. He had the look of someone who had been shaken and was being carefully reassembled.

"He seems okay," Alex said.

"What do you think actually happened in there?"

Alex stirred the pot. "I think he heard something that used a voice he recognized and he answered it before he could decide not to. And I think answering it was enough."

"Enough for what?"

"I don't know exactly." He paused. "Enough to — start something. Whatever it starts."

Riley looked at Jordan. "He walked toward the mine drainage."

"Yeah."

"Without knowing he was doing it."

"Yeah."

They sat with that.

"The ranger said — missing people aren't the same when they return," Riley said.

Alex looked at them.

"He didn't say that," Alex said. "He said if someone goes missing, don't look alone."

"Same implication."

Alex looked at Jordan again. Sitting with Sam. Hands around his camp mug. The ordinary posture of a tired person at a fire.

Six, he thought. *Still six.*

After dinner the conversation rebuilt itself slowly, the way conversation did when people needed it to — not forced, just gradually reoccupying the space that fear had cleared. Jordan told the story of the time he'd gotten lost in an IKEA for forty-five minutes and had to be escorted out by a teenager named Bryce. This got a real laugh from Sam and a smile from Taylor that reached her eyes, which was the full version of Taylor's smile, the one she didn't give away easily.

Casey was writing.

Alex watched her from across the fire. Her pen moving steadily, her expression inward. She'd been writing more than usual — longer entries, he thought, or more of them, the notebook appearing multiple times a day now rather than once.

After a while she looked up and caught him watching.

She turned the notebook and held it out across the fire. He leaned forward to read.

She'd written: *Things I know for certain. Things I think I know. Things I don't know.*

Under *Things I know for certain* she'd written four items. He read them:

1. The whistle is deliberate — consistent pitch, consistent timing, responsive to our presence and activity. 2. It mimics voices. Has demonstrated this at least three times. 3. Jordan responded and was directed toward the mine drainage. 4. The symbol appears at trail junctions as warnings. It has local historical basis.

Under *Things I think I know* there were two:

1. It has been listening to us since before we noticed it. 2. The guitar/music may be functioning as an attractor — drawing its attention.

Under *Things I don't know* there was only one line, but she'd underlined it twice:

What happens to the ones who follow it all the way.

Alex looked at her. She took the notebook back.

"I want to find out what the mine is," she said quietly. "Not by going there. By knowing the history. There'll be records somewhere — local historical society, park service archive. When we're out."

"When we're out," Alex said.

"When we're out," she confirmed. Like a promise they were making to each other.

The sound came at 2am.

Not the whistle. Not a voice. Something else — a sound Alex didn't have immediate category for, coming from the southern end of camp, the open side of the hollow. He was awake instantly, sitting up in his sleeping bag, heart already elevated before conscious thought caught up.

He unzipped the tent.

The fire had burned to coals, casting a dim orange suggestion rather than real light. The camp was quiet. The other tents dark and still.

The southern tree line — thirty yards from the tents — was also dark and still.

And then movement. Something at the edge of the coals' reach, a shape low to the ground, moving fast across the camp perimeter in the direction of the southern trees. Gone before he could resolve it into anything recognizable.

Animal. Probably animal. The shape had been low, possibly four-legged, the movement fluid.

He sat at the tent entrance for two minutes, watching.

Nothing.

He was about to zip back in when Sam's tent opened.

Sam emerged, fully clothed, boots already on. She looked at him across the camp.

"You heard it," she said.

"Yeah."

"What was that?"

"I don't know. Something moving through. Animal, I think."

Sam looked at the southern tree line. Her expression was doing something complicated — not quite fear, more like the face of someone solving a problem they hadn't chosen and didn't like.

"Jordan's not in the tent," she said.

Alex was on his feet before she finished the sentence.

He was there. That was the first thing, the necessary thing — he was there. Jordan was at the southern edge of camp, standing at the tree line, facing the forest. Standing still the way he'd stood still in the rhododendron.

"Jordan," Alex said.

Jordan turned around. Faster this time — less of the fractional delay. His eyes focused immediately.

"I was going to check the perimeter," he said. "I heard something."

"I heard it too," Alex said. "I'm checking. You go back to the tent."

Jordan looked at him. Then at Sam, who had come up beside Alex. Then back at the tree line.

"Okay," he said. He said it normally, the way Jordan said things. He went back to his tent.

Alex and Sam stood at the tree line.

"He was going in," Sam said quietly.

"I know."

"He said perimeter check like it was a plan he'd made."

"I know."

They looked at the forest. Darkness between the trunks, absolute and layered. The hollow's open mouth.

"We should wake the others," Sam said.

"Not yet." Alex was looking at something — a shape on the ground at the tree line, just inside the reach of his headlamp. He moved toward it. Sam followed.

It was Sam's bear canister.

Dragged from where she'd secured it, twenty yards from camp, to here at the tree line. The lid was intact — bear canisters were designed to be intact — but it had been moved. Dragged, by the scrape marks in the leaf litter. Dragged toward the trees.

"That wasn't an animal," Sam said.

"It could have been a bear," Alex said, because he needed to say it.

"Bears don't make that sound," Sam said. "And bears don't stop at tree lines and wait. It stopped. I heard it stop."

Alex crouched by the canister. The scrape marks were clear in the leaf litter. Something had gripped it — not claws, or at least not only claws, the marks were inconsistent with a single-point grip — and dragged it. Intentionally. As if placing it at the threshold.

As if leaving something at a door.

He picked up the canister. Brought it back to camp. Tied it to the bear cable with two extra knots.

"Wake Casey," he said. "Quietly. Don't wake Jordan."

The three of them sat by the rebuilt fire — Alex, Sam, Casey — while the others slept. Or while the others appeared to sleep. Alex wasn't certain about Jordan.

He told them what he'd seen. The shape moving the perimeter. Jordan at the tree line. The canister.

Casey listened with her notebook open, pen recording as he spoke.

"It's testing boundaries," she said when he finished.

"What does that mean?" Sam asked.

"It means it's — probing. Seeing what we respond to. The canister at the tree line is — it's like bait. Or an invitation." She paused. "Or a demonstration. *I can come into your space. I can move your things. I'm closer than you think.*"

"That's a very human way to think about animal behavior," Sam said.

"Yes," Casey said. "It is."

They sat with that.

"Jordan went to the tree line," Sam said. "In his sleep, basically. He said perimeter check like he'd been told to go."

"He answered the voice in the rhododendron," Casey said.

"So that's what it does," Sam said. "It gets a yes and then it can — direct you."

"That might be it," Casey said. "Or the answer opens something. Creates a connection. And through that connection it can —" she stopped. Shook her head. "I'm speculating."

"Speculate," Alex said.

She looked at him. "I think answering it is the beginning of a process," she said carefully. "I think Jordan answering it wasn't nothing. I think we need to watch him closely. Not obviously — he doesn't need to feel surveilled, that creates its own problems. But closely."

"He seems like Jordan," Sam said. She said it like she needed to say it. Like saying it made it more true.

"I know," Casey said gently. "He does."

Sam looked at the fire. "What if he isn't," she said. Very quietly. "What if he's already not."

Nobody answered.

The fire burned. The hollow held its dark.

They were back in their tents by four. Sam had gone reluctantly, Alex had assured her he'd stay lightly, a half-truth. He lay with his eyes open and the tent door unzipped two inches and watched the camp until the sky began to lighten.

Jordan did not emerge again.

At first grey light, the birds came back — the first bird sounds they'd heard in two days, a thrush somewhere above the hollow singing its complicated water-over-stones song. Alex lay and listened to it and felt something loosen slightly in his chest. Birds. Normal birds making normal bird sounds.

He got up and rebuilt the fire and started the water.

Jordan came out of his tent at seven looking like a man who had slept well. Easy in his body. Immediately interested in coffee. Making a comment about the thrush. *Good sign, he'd read somewhere, birds meant no large predators in the immediate area.*

Alex watched him.

Jordan met his eyes across the fire and smiled. Open, easy. Jordan's smile.

Alex smiled back.

He counted. One through six as they emerged. Six. All six.

Still six, he wrote in the journal, *for now*.

They broke camp and were on the trail by nine. The day was clear, the light clean, and the trail ahead ran down out of the hollow and into a section of mixed forest that the map showed opening up into a broader valley. More exposure. Less enclosure. Alex had looked at this on the map the night before with specific relief.

Four miles to the next site. Reasonable terrain. The mine drainage was behind them now, to the south, receding with each step.

He let himself feel this.

They walked. Jordan was near the front, ranging slightly as he had on the first two days — back to his pattern, back to his rhythms. Alex watched him and saw Jordan. Heard him and heard Jordan. The familiar presence of a person well-known.

Still six. Still Jordan.

Two miles in, the trail skirted a long rock face, a natural wall of exposed granite running parallel to the path, mossy at the base, the stone above it orange and grey in the morning light. Beautiful in an austere way. Casey stopped to photograph it, and Alex stopped with her, and they stood for a moment in the particular silence that granite produced, the sense of something very old and very indifferent.

"Did you sleep at all?" Casey asked.

"A little," Alex said.

She nodded. She knew what the real answer was.

"He seems like himself," she said. About Jordan. She said it the way Sam had said it — needing to, making it more true by saying it.

"Yeah," Alex said.

She looked at the rock face. At the moss, the slow patient work of it, the decades it took to cover stone.

"Alex," she said. And something in her voice made him look at her directly.

"When we were counting last night — the three of us, checking the tents." She paused. "I counted wrong the first time. I counted five."

He looked at her.

"And then I counted again and it was six," she said. "It was six. I was tired, I miscounted." She met his gaze. "I'm telling you because you should know that I miscounted. That's all. I'm not saying anything else."

"Okay," he said.

She nodded and started walking.

Alex stayed a moment longer at the rock face. He counted in his head — the figures ahead on the trail, the ones he could see.

One. Two. Three.

He moved forward until he could see the full group.

Four. Five.

He walked faster until he was close enough.

Six.

Six.

He breathed.

And from somewhere behind them — behind, now, south, from the direction of the hollow and the drainage and the disused mine in the undergrowth — the whistle came. Distant. A single note.

Not following. He told himself it was not following.

He walked.

Chapter Nine: Return of Taylor

She was gone before anyone noticed.

That was the part that stayed with Alex afterward — not the going, but the not noticing. They had walked four miles through open mixed forest in clear morning light, six people on a trail, and somewhere in those four miles Taylor had stopped being there and none of them had registered it until they reached the campsite and began the automatic process of unpacking and Alex counted and got five.

He counted again.

Five.

He turned around. The trail behind them ran straight for fifty yards before curving out of sight between two large oaks.

Empty.

"Where's Taylor," he said.

Not loud. Just said it. And watched the group turn and look and arrive at the same count he'd arrived at, the same absence.

"She was right behind me," Casey said. She said it with a certainty that immediately became uncertainty as she examined it. "She was — I heard her footsteps, I'm sure I —"

"How long ago?" Alex said.

Casey looked at the trail. At the distance they'd covered. Doing the math of time and pace and the moment she last had a clear memory of Taylor's presence.

"Half a mile," she said. "Maybe more."

"Thirty minutes," Jordan said. "Roughly."

They looked at each other.

"We go back," Alex said. "Together. Same rule as the rhododendron — nobody separates. We stay in a group."

Sam was already facing the trail. "Now," she said.

"Now."

They found her in twenty minutes, which felt much longer.

She was on the trail. This was the first relief — not off it, not in the trees, not standing at the edge of a drainage facing the wrong direction. She was on the trail, sitting on a flat boulder that jutted from the hillside at a natural bench height, her pack beside her, her hands in her lap.

Looking at nothing.

Or looking at something none of them could see.

"Taylor," Alex said.

She looked up. Her face did the thing Jordan's face had done in the rhododendron — the fractional delay, the reassembling, the return. But slower. Noticeably slower, and Alex felt something cold move through him that had nothing to do with the temperature.

"Hey," she said.

"Hey." He crouched in front of her. "What happened?"

She looked at him. Her eyes were clear — focused, present. Taylor's eyes. "I sat down," she said. "I needed to sit down."

"You've been here for half an hour," Casey said gently, from behind Alex.

Taylor looked at Casey. Then at the trail. Processing the distance, the time.

"It didn't feel like half an hour," she said.

"What did it feel like?"

She thought about this. "A few minutes," she said. "I sat down and I was thinking and then you were here."

"What were you thinking about?" Riley asked.

Taylor looked at Riley. Something passed across her face — a brief weather system, there and gone. "I don't know," she said. "I can't — I'm trying to remember what I was thinking about and I can't." She paused. "That's strange."

"Yeah," Alex said. "It is."

He looked at her carefully. She was sitting straight, breathing normally, color in her face. Her pack was beside her rather than on her back — she'd taken it off, which meant she'd intended to sit, hadn't simply stopped mid-stride. She'd chosen this boulder, chosen to stop here.

"Taylor," he said quietly. "Did you hear something?"

She looked at him.

"Before you sat down," he said. "Did you hear a voice, or the whistle, or anything —"

"No," she said. Then she paused. Then: "I don't think so."

The pause was the thing. The space between *no* and *I don't think so* was the thing.

"Okay," he said. He stood and offered her his hand. She took it and stood, and the ordinary mechanics of it — the grip, the weight, the standing up — were all Taylor, all normal. She shouldered her pack with her characteristic efficiency.

"I'm fine," she said.

"I know," Alex said. "Stay close today."

She looked at him with an expression he'd always associated with her — that flat assessing gaze that meant she was deciding how much credit to give you. She gave him credit.

"Close," she agreed.

The campsite was a long flat shelf on the western slope, the trees here older and more widely spaced, the ground beneath them carpeted in deep moss. A spring fed a small stone-rimmed pool someone had improved with flat rocks decades ago, the improvement now so weathered it looked natural. The Smokies were full of these small accumulated kindnesses — stones moved, logs notched, paths worn by thousands of careful feet.

They set up camp. Alex noted the positions of the tents, the distances, the angles of sightlines. He was doing this automatically now, the spatial awareness of someone who had started thinking tactically, and he recognized this in himself and didn't fight it.

Jordan built the fire. Sam collected wood without being asked. Casey set up her tent and then immediately came back out and helped Riley with theirs, a small unprompted kindness. These were the textures of a group that was pulling inward, condensing — not from dysfunction but from instinct, the social version of what animals did in cold weather. Getting closer. Conserving warmth.

Taylor set up her tent and then sat outside it with her knees pulled up, watching the preparation with slightly unfocused attention. Not unresponsive — she answered when spoken to, helped when asked. But quieter than her own usual quiet. The inner volume turned down.

Alex brought her coffee.

She looked at it. Then at him. "You don't have to —"

"I know," he said. He sat beside her.

They drank in silence for a while.

"Tell me something," Alex said. He used Riley's phrase without thinking.

Taylor looked at him sideways. "Something."

"Yeah."

She thought about it. "Before this trip," she said, "I was good. I want you to know that. I was doing well. The job is good, I have a good apartment, I've been running again." She paused. "I'm telling you because I need you to know that

whatever is happening to me here isn't — it's not a baseline thing. I'm not fragile."

"I know you're not," Alex said.

"The pull," she said. "I told you about it this morning. It's gotten stronger." She looked at the fire Jordan was building across the camp, the small careful architecture of it, the smoke beginning to rise. "I think sitting on that rock — I think I sat down because I was fighting it. I think it was the equivalent of stopping and not moving when the feeling gets strong. Don't follow it, just stop."

Alex looked at her. "That's smart," he said.

"I know it's smart," she said, without vanity. "I need you to know I'm still doing the smart things. I'm still — I'm still here."

"I know," he said.

She drank her coffee. He sat with her and let the silence be what it was — not uncomfortable, not requiring filling. Taylor had always been someone you could sit with in silence and have it mean something rather than nothing.

"Keep an eye on Jordan," she said after a while.

"I am."

"I'm not talking about the hollow," she said. "I'm talking about — he's been too okay today. He was too good this morning. Too normal." She paused. "Jordan is a specific kind of person. He processes out loud. He works things through by talking. He hasn't talked about what happened yesterday since it happened."

Alex thought about this. She was right — Jordan's natural response to a frightening experience would have been to talk about it, dissect it, make it manageable with narrative. The absence of that was its own kind of data.

"I'll talk to him," Alex said.

"Do it naturally," Taylor said. "Not like you're checking."

"Okay."

She finished her coffee. Stood up, efficient and smooth. "Thank you for the coffee."

"Sure."

"And Alex." She was looking at the tree line. The western slope falling away below them, the light going golden with late afternoon. "The thing I couldn't remember thinking about, on the rock." She paused. "It's coming back. In fragments. I was thinking about the mine. About what's in it." Another pause. "I was thinking about it like I wanted to see it. Like I was curious." She looked at him. "I am not curious about the mine. I want you to know that's not — that's not mine."

She went to her tent.

Alex sat alone with his empty coffee cup.

He wrote in the journal later, while dinner cooked:

Taylor lost time on the trail. Thirty minutes sitting on a boulder with no memory of what she was thinking, retrieved in fragments — mine, curiosity, wanting to see it. Those aren't her thoughts. She knows they aren't.

She's fighting it actively. Sitting down instead of following. Recognizing the intrusive thought as foreign. She's the most self-aware person I know and she's using that.

But it's getting stronger. She said so.

Jordan hasn't talked about the hollow. Taylor flagged it before I did.

The pattern: whistle first, then voice mimicry, then directional pull, then lost time, then intrusive thoughts that feel like your own but aren't.

Where does the pattern go next?

He stopped writing.

He didn't want to write where the pattern went next.

Dinner was the best meal they'd had on the trail — Casey had been hoarding a packet of dehydrated curry that turned out to be genuinely good, and the combination of good food and firelight and the wide-spaced old trees did something to the group's atmosphere. Loosened it. Jordan told the Portland story again, slightly embellished, and this time everyone laughed properly. Sam found a second bag of peanut butter cups she'd hidden as a backup reserve for exactly this kind of moment, and the discovery of them produced a happiness disproportionate to the food itself — the particular joy of unexpected good things, of preparation meeting need.

Alex watched Jordan across the fire.

Taylor was right. Too okay. The laugh too easy, the stories too smooth, the eyes doing everything they should do but doing it without the slight unsteadiness that would have been natural after yesterday. Jordan after a frightening experience was usually Jordan plus a visible processing layer — the working-through, the talking-out. This Jordan was just Jordan. Frictionless.

Like something had already done the processing for him.

After the food was cleared, Alex moved around the fire to where Jordan was sitting and dropped down beside him.

"Hey," Jordan said.

"Hey," Alex looked at the fire for a moment. Then, casually: "You doing okay? After yesterday?"

Jordan looked at him. "You mean the rhododendron thing?"

"Yeah."

Jordan shrugged. "I'm fine," he said. "It was weird. I think I just zoned out at the wrong time and my brain filled in the gap with something that felt like it made sense." He paused. "You know how when you drive somewhere familiar and you don't remember the drive? Like that."

"Not quite like that," Alex said. "You were off the trail."

"I know." Jordan looked at the fire. "Alex — I'm fine. I know what you're doing. I'd be doing it too." He met Alex's eyes. "I answered the thing. I know I answered it. And I know that's probably not great. But I'm still me, I promise."

He said it the way Taylor had said *I'm still here*. The same specific emphasis. The same need to confirm it out loud.

"Okay," Alex said.

"Is it okay?" Jordan said. "Or are you just saying okay?"

Alex looked at him for a long moment. At Jordan's face, the face he'd known for twelve years, all its familiar architecture.

"Both," he said honestly.

Jordan nodded. He seemed to appreciate the honesty. "Fair," he said.

They sat together by the fire.

The humming started just before nine.

Soft enough that it wasn't immediately distinguishable from the ambient sounds of camp — the fire, the wind, the spring trickling into the stone-rimmed pool. Alex heard it first as a texture in the air, something melodic underneath the other sounds. He turned his head.

Taylor.

She was sitting across the fire, coffee cup in hand, and she was humming. Softly, almost under her breath. Her eyes were on the fire.

Alex listened.

The tune was simple. Four notes, repeating. Rising, rising, falling, hold.

He knew those notes.

He'd played them on the guitar, the first night at camp. That opening fingerpicked pattern — the four-note phrase that his hands had found without deciding to, the embryo of a song that hadn't arrived yet.

Taylor was humming his guitar pattern.

He looked at Riley. Riley had heard it too — they were very still, watching Taylor with careful eyes.

"Taylor," Alex said.

She looked up. The humming stopped.

"Were you aware you were humming?" he asked.

She looked at him. Then she looked genuinely uncertain — the kind of uncertainty that wasn't performed, the real texture of a person checking their own recent behavior and finding it surprising.

"No," she said. Slowly. "I wasn't."

"What were you humming?"

She frowned. "I don't know. Something." She paused. "Why?"

Alex looked at Riley. Riley looked back. The communication between them was wordless and complete: *don't tell her. Not yet. Watch.*

"Nothing," Alex said. "Just noticed."

Taylor looked at him for a moment with her assessing gaze. Then she looked at her coffee.

"I'm going to bed," she said. She stood, poured the last of her coffee into the fire where it hissed. "Night."

She went to her tent.

Alex sat very still.

The four-note phrase was in his head now, looping. Rising, rising, falling, hold. His pattern, from the first night. From the guitar. From the music that had preceded the whistle.

It learns voices after one hearing, he thought. *Mimics signals, even music.*

He'd played that phrase once. Three nights ago. One time, by a fire in the dark.

And now Taylor was humming it. Without knowing she was humming it. Without knowing what it was.

He didn't take out the guitar.

He wrote in the journal by headlamp after the others had gone to sleep, sitting alone by the last of the fire, the mountains dark around him and the stars very bright through the gap in the canopy above the camp:

Taylor hummed the guitar pattern tonight. Four notes, exact pitch, exact rhythm. She didn't know she was doing it. She didn't know what it was.

It's in her somehow. Whatever answered when Jordan said yeah — it's working through her differently. Not direction, not lost time. Music. Using her to reproduce the attractor.

The guitar draws it. Now it's using Taylor to recreate the draw.

I need to understand what I'm dealing with. I need to understand the mine.

Four more days. We can be out in four days if nothing else happens.

He looked at the last line.

If nothing else happens.

He crossed it out.

He closed the notebook.

From Taylor's tent — faint, barely audible, the sound threading through the nylon walls like smoke — the humming. Soft and continuous. Rising, rising, falling, hold.

In her sleep.

She was humming it in her sleep.

Chapter Ten: The Change

Taylor didn't eat breakfast.

This wouldn't have been notable on its own — Taylor was particular about mornings, had always been, and skipping food wasn't unusual for her on the trail. What was notable was that she sat at the fire with a full cup of coffee and didn't drink it either. Just held it. Staring at the tree line to the northwest with the fixed attention of someone watching something the others couldn't see.

Sam noticed first. She looked at Alex across the fire. He gave the smallest shake of his head.

Not yet. Watch.

They watched.

After ten minutes Casey said, casually, "Taylor. Coffee's going cold."

Taylor looked down at the cup as if she'd forgotten it was in her hands. She took a sip. Then she looked back at the tree line.

"Something moving out there?" Jordan asked.

"No," Taylor said.

"You keep looking."

"I know," she said. Just that. No follow-up. No explanation. She took another sip of coffee and kept her eyes on the northwest.

They broke camp in an uneasy quiet that nobody named.

Alex packed fast and used the time to watch. Jordan was moving well, efficiently, making his usual comments about the gear organization that always drew a response from Sam. Sam was responding but her laugh was half a beat late. Casey packed in silence, her movements careful and deliberate, the way she moved when she was thinking hard about something and using her hands to stay grounded.

Riley was watching Taylor.

Taylor had finally finished her coffee and was breaking down her tent with mechanical precision. Nothing wrong with the movements. Nothing slow or confused. But twice, in the space of five minutes, Alex watched her stop mid-action — once with a tent pole in each hand, once crouched over her pack — and simply pause. Both times her head turned fractionally northwest and her eyes went to the middle distance. Both times she caught herself and resumed.

She didn't look embarrassed. She didn't look frightened.

She looked like someone hearing a sound they'd decided not to acknowledge. Over and over, the decision made fresh each time.

On the third pause Alex walked over.

"Hey," he said.

She looked at him. Her eyes were clear. Taylor's eyes.

"I'm fine," she said, before he could ask.

"I know," he said. "Can I ask you something?"

"You're going to anyway."

"The humming last night," he said. "In your sleep. You were doing it again."

Something moved across her face. Fast, there and gone.

"How long?" she asked.

"I heard it twice. Longest stretch was about ten minutes."

She absorbed this without visible reaction. Set down the tent pole she was holding. "I dreamed about the mine," she said. Her voice was flat and precise, the Taylor-voice she used when she was being careful. "Not a nightmare. That's the thing. It wasn't frightening. It was —" she paused, and for just a moment something underneath the precision surfaced, something that looked like genuine fear of herself. "It was like being called home."

Neither of them spoke.

"I know that's not right," she said. "I know what that means and I know it's not right." She picked up the tent pole. "I'm telling you because you need to know. Not because I'm losing."

"Okay," Alex said.

"Don't okay me," she said. "I mean it. I'm not losing."

"I know you're not," he said.

She looked at him for a long moment. Then she went back to her pack.

He believed her.

He just wasn't certain *she* was the only one doing the telling.

An hour into the day's descent, Jordan stopped walking.

Not the way Taylor stopped — not the fractional hesitation, not the subtle northwest orientation. Jordan stopped completely. In the middle of the trail. Both feet planted, pack on, facing downhill.

The group compressed around him. Sam reached him first.

"Jordan."

He didn't respond.

"Jordan." She put her hand on his arm.

He turned. Slowly, the way something large turns — the whole body rather than just the head, the movement deliberate in a way Jordan's movements never were. Jordan was quick and reactive, his body always slightly ahead of his intentions. This was the opposite of that.

He looked at Sam.

His face was Jordan's face. That was the horrible part. Every feature correct, every proportion right. The eyes the right color, the jaw the right shape, the small

scar above his left eyebrow from a bike accident at fourteen, all of it exactly as it should be.

But the expression was wrong.

Not frightening wrong, not monster wrong. Just — absent. Like a room with the lights off. Like someone had vacated the premises and left the furniture exactly in place.

"Hey," Sam said. Her voice was steady. "Where are you?"

Something shifted behind his eyes. A flicker, a depth returning.

"Sorry," he said. He blinked. "Sorry, I just —" he shook his head, and the motion was Jordan again, the quick physical reset. "Zoned out. Sorry."

"For how long?" Alex asked.

"Just a second."

"We've been standing here for two minutes," Riley said.

Jordan looked at Riley. Then at the group around him. At the trail, the trees, the morning light. Reorienting. The processing was visible, the gears catching.

"Two minutes," he said.

"Yeah."

He looked down at his feet. At his planted boots. At the fact of himself standing still in the middle of a trail with no memory of stopping.

"Okay," he said. And his voice was careful now in a way Jordan's voice was never careful — measured, deliberate, as if he was listening to himself speak. "Okay. That's not great."

"No," Alex said.

Jordan looked up at him. And for just a moment — a fraction of a second, the briefest window — his eyes went to the northwest. Up the slope. Back toward the hollow and the drainage and the mine.

Then he looked back at Alex.

"Let's keep moving," he said.

They reached the valley floor by noon and stopped at the creek for water and food and the illusion of normal. Sam sat in the sun on her flat rock. Casey wrote. Riley filtered water with the focused care of someone who needed something specific to do.

Alex crouched at the creek's edge and watched the water and did not write in the journal.

He was done writing down what he could see. He knew what he could see. What he needed was something the journal couldn't give him, which was a way out of the knowledge that two of his friends were being unmade — slowly, partially, incrementally — and that the unmaking looked almost exactly like the making, and that the difference between the two was getting harder to measure.

Jordan sat beside him.

For a while neither of them spoke. The creek ran. A bird worked the far bank.

"Louisiana waterthrush," Jordan said. "Rare this late in the season."

"Yeah?" Alex said.

"Mm." Jordan watched the bird. Then: "I want to go back."

Alex looked at him.

"Not — not like that," Jordan said. And his voice was tight, effortful, like a man pushing against a current. "I mean I want to. I feel it. I'm telling you because I think you need to know I feel it." He paused. "It's like something left a door open and I can feel the draft from it and part of me wants to go see what's on the other side."

"But you're not going," Alex said.

"I'm not going," Jordan said. "But it's getting louder." He picked up a stone and turned it in his hands. "This morning on the trail. The two minutes. I wasn't zoned out. I was — I was listening. I was deciding." He set the stone down carefully. "I decided to stay. That's why I came back."

Alex held completely still.

"You decided," he said.

"Yeah."

"That means you can keep deciding."

Jordan looked at the creek. The waterthrush. The far bank where the shadows of the trees fell long and cool. "For now," he said.

He stood up and went back to the group.

Alex stayed at the creek's edge.

The water ran over the smooth stones, clear and cold and indifferent, and the bird worked the shallows with its quick precise movements, and somewhere up the slope behind them the mountain held its silence, and Alex crouched at the water's edge and felt very clearly, for the first time, the specific weight of what was going to be required of him before this was over.

Not just surviving. Not just getting out.

Keeping them. All of them. Getting them all the way out while the thing in the mountain reached through them like a hand through a curtain, patient and specific and getting stronger with every mile they hadn't managed to put between themselves and it.

He stood.

He counted.

Six.

For now, six.

That night the fire wouldn't catch.

Taylor built it — her usual role, her reliable skill — and it wouldn't catch. Damp wood, maybe. The creek's moisture in the air. She tried twice, three times, the kindling flaring and dying each time. On the fourth attempt she sat back on her heels and stared at the dead fire ring with an expression that had nothing to do with the wood.

"Here," Casey said. She took the lighter. Rearranged the kindling with quick precise movements. Tried.

It caught.

Taylor was still sitting back on her heels, looking at nothing.

"Tay," Sam said.

Taylor looked up. "Sorry." She stood, brushing bark from her knees. "I was somewhere else."

"Where?" Sam asked.

Taylor looked at her. At the fire, now burning, the light moving on her face.

"I don't know," she said. And the way she said it — not flat, not precise, but genuinely uncertain, genuinely searching — was worse than anything else she'd said all day.

She sat down at the fire.

She didn't look northwest again.

But her coffee cup was in her hands, and after a while, under the sound of the fire and the creek and the quiet conversation of the others, she began to hum.

Four notes. Rising, rising, falling, hold.

She didn't know she was doing it.

Nobody said anything.

Casey met Alex's eyes across the fire.

Then Casey looked away.

Chapter Eleven: Whistle Up Close

The creek woke him.

Not the sound of it — he'd slept through that for four nights now, the white noise of it absorbed into the background of sleep. What woke him was the absence of it. A stretch of seconds, maybe ten, maybe fifteen, in which the creek went silent.

He was sitting up before he understood why.

The tent. Dark. Riley breathing beside him. Outside — nothing. The creek's constant voice simply gone, as if a hand had covered it.

Then it came back. The water sound returning all at once, full volume, like a door reopening.

Alex sat in the dark and listened and tried to decide if he'd dreamed it.

He didn't think he'd dreamed it.

He unzipped the tent two inches. Cold air and woodsmoke. The fire was out, the camp dark, the sky above the sycamores hard and clear and salted with stars. He could see the creek from here — a pale movement in the darkness, the water catching starlight.

Moving. Making sound. Normal.

He watched for five minutes. Nothing moved. The camp was still, the tree line still, the sycamores barely shifting in the dead air.

He zipped the tent.

Lay back down.

Did not sleep.

He said nothing about it in the morning. He filed it and watched the others and made coffee and noted that Taylor had slept without humming — or at least he

hadn't heard it, which wasn't the same thing but was something. Jordan came out of his tent with his eyes fully present, which was something too. Small accountings. The daily inventory of what remained.

The route today was a ridge traverse — not climbing, not descending, just the long lateral movement along the mountain's flank that the topo map showed as a gentle contour line, four miles to the next site. Alex had planned it as a recovery day from the descent, easier terrain, the kind of day that was supposed to feel like breathing out.

It did not feel like breathing out.

They walked. The forest here was open and dry, the leaf litter deep and orange underfoot, the sound of their footsteps loud in the still air. Alex stayed mid-group. He had stopped counting at fixed intervals and started counting continuously — a low background process, a persistent tallying. One through six. One through six. One through six.

The trail was good. The sky was good. There was nothing to report for the first two hours and Alex found this neither reassuring nor alarming but simply a condition to move through, one foot in front of the other, waiting for the next thing.

Riley walked beside him.

"You didn't sleep," they said.

"I slept."

"You slept the way you were awake," Riley said. "There's a difference."

He looked at them. The morning light was clean on the ridge, coming through the thinned canopy at a low angle, and Riley looked — Riley looked like themselves. Fully, specifically themselves. The flannel shirt, the short hair, the quality of attention they directed at him that was like being focused through a lens. He held onto the fact of them.

"The creek went silent last night," he said. "For about ten seconds. Then came back."

Riley looked at the trail ahead.

"The same way birds go silent," they said.

"Yeah."

"When something's moving through."

"Yeah."

They walked.

"How close do you think it gets?" Riley asked. "At night."

Alex had been not-thinking about this specifically. The shape at the camp perimeter. The canister at the tree line. The creek going silent within thirty yards of their tents.

"Close enough," he said.

The trail bent north around an outcropping and the trees thinned completely for a hundred yards, the ridge exposed, the view dropping away on both sides. Open sky. The wind found them immediately, cold and direct, and the group bunched slightly against it, heads down.

In the middle of the exposed section Jordan stopped.

Alex was behind him. He saw it — the full-stop, the planted feet, the wrong stillness.

"Jordan," he said immediately.

Jordan turned around. Fast this time — almost too fast, the return immediate, the eyes present. But he was facing north. They'd been walking north. Jordan had turned south.

He'd turned around completely without noticing.

"I'm here," Jordan said. His jaw was set. He looked like a man who had caught himself at something. "I'm here."

"Yeah," Alex said.

"It got loud," Jordan said. Low, under the wind, not for the group. "Just for a second. I turned around and I was already —" he stopped. Looked at his feet. At the north-facing trail behind him and the south-facing direction he'd been turned toward.

Toward the mine. Always toward the mine.

"Walk with me," Alex said. He moved beside Jordan and they fell back into step, shoulder to shoulder, heading north. Away. Alex matched Jordan's pace and kept his shoulder against Jordan's and didn't say anything else.

Jordan didn't say anything either.

But he stayed pointed north. He kept walking. And when the trail curved back into the trees and the wind died and the exposure ended, Alex felt the set of Jordan's shoulder change slightly — a fractional release, like a muscle unclenching.

"Thank you," Jordan said.

"Yeah," Alex said.

They stopped for lunch at a place where the trail widened into a natural clearing, a circle of old oaks whose canopy closed overhead like a held breath. The light came through in shafts, amber and specific, each beam lit with motes that turned slowly in the still air. Despite everything, despite the inventory of wrongness that had accumulated over four days, the clearing was beautiful in a way that made Alex's chest ache.

Sam noticed him noticing.

"It's still beautiful," she said. "I keep waiting to stop seeing that."

"Yeah."

"I think that might be important," she said. "The fact that it's still beautiful." She looked up at the canopy. "Like — whatever this thing is, it hasn't made the mountains ugly. It hasn't taken that."

Alex thought about this. "No," he said. "It hasn't."

"Small mercies." She unwrapped her lunch. "I'm counting them."

Across the clearing, Casey and Riley were talking quietly, their heads together over something in Casey's notebook. Taylor was eating with her back against one of the oaks, her face tilted up toward a shaft of light, eyes closed. She looked peaceful. She looked like Taylor on a normal trip, taking a normal lunch break.

Alex watched her.

Her hand, resting on her knee, was tapping. Slow, rhythmic. Four beats repeating.

Rising, rising, falling, hold.

He looked away.

It happened in the mid-afternoon, two miles from the campsite.

Alex heard it first. Of course he heard it first — he'd been listening for it continuously, the background frequency of his attention tuned to it for four days now. But this time it wasn't from the ridge, wasn't from the trees, wasn't from thirty yards off the trail in the fog.

This time it was close.

Very close.

Fifteen yards, maybe. To the right of the trail, upslope, behind a screen of rhododendron that clung to the rock face above them. Fifteen yards was the distance across a large room. Fifteen yards was nothing.

He stopped walking.

Riley stopped. Then Casey. Then Sam. One by one the group compressed to a halt the way it did now, the shared nervous system of people who had been frightened together long enough to synchronize.

Taylor kept walking for three more steps before she stopped.

She was facing the rhododendron.

The whistle came again.

Single note. High and clean. Fifteen yards.

Alex had heard this sound nine times now. He had a precise and detailed memory of each instance — the pitch, the duration, the direction, the circumstances. He knew this sound the way you knew a voice you'd been afraid of. He knew it.

This was different.

Not the pitch — the pitch was the same. Not the duration. What was different was the quality of it. The previous whistles had been — he searched for the word — declarative. A sound announcing presence. This one was something else. This one had an inflection he hadn't heard before.

It was asking.

The same note, the same sound, but shaped differently at the end. The faintest upward curl. The sonic equivalent of a tilt of the head. An invitation.

Well?

Nobody moved.

The rhododendron was still. The rock face above it, bare grey granite, showed nothing. Whatever was behind that screen of leaves was fifteen yards away and completely invisible and making a sound shaped like a question.

Taylor's head turned toward it.

Not the fractional northwest orientation — fully toward it. Her face pointing directly at the rhododendron, her eyes open, her expression doing something Alex had never seen on Taylor's face before. Not blank, not absent. Interested.

"Taylor," he said.

She didn't respond.

"Taylor." Louder.

Her head turned back. The expression collapsed back into Taylor's expression — the flat precision, the control. But it took a full second. A full second for her to come back from wherever she'd been in the moment of that whistle.

"I heard it," she said. Her voice was level. "I'm fine."

"You turned toward it," Casey said.

"I know I did." She met Casey's eyes. "I said I'm fine."

Casey held her gaze. "Okay," she said gently.

The rhododendron was still.

Fifteen yards.

Alex looked at it. The leaves dark and waxy, the branches dense, the spaces between them showing nothing but deeper dark. He thought about what was in there. What shape it had. Whether shape was even the right category. Whether the thing that made that sound was the kind of thing that had a shape you could see, or whether it was something else entirely, something that occupied space the way a sound occupied space — present, directional, real, but not resolvable into a thing you could look at.

He did not look directly at it.

This had become instinct now. Whenever the wrongness was close, he found a point slightly to the side of it and held there. He didn't know where the instinct came from and he'd stopped questioning it.

"We walk," he said. "Same pace. Don't run. Don't look at it."

"Don't answer it," Riley said.

"Don't answer it," Alex confirmed.

They walked.

One. Two. Three. Four. Five. Six.

Six moving past the rhododendron, past the rock face, past the fifteen yards of terrible proximity, the whistle not repeating, the leaves not moving, whatever was there simply present and still as they passed.

Alex was last.

He passed the rhododendron at arm's length. He kept his eyes on the trail. He felt the fifteen yards the way you felt a drop in temperature — not seen, not heard, felt. The specific pressure of something attending to him from very close range. The weight of being observed by something patient.

He walked past it.

He kept walking.

Twenty yards. Thirty. The trail curved and the rhododendron was behind them and the rock face was behind them and the feeling — the pressure, the attended weight of it — faded by degrees.

He breathed.

He counted.

Six.

They made camp fast and without discussion. The efficiency of the frightened, the shared understanding that shelter meant something even when shelter was nylon and poles and offered no real protection from anything. The tents went up, the fire went down, the circle around it pulled tight.

Jordan built the fire. He was quiet and focused and present — more present, Alex thought, than he'd been all day. The closeness of the whistle had done something clarifying for him. Scared him back into himself.

Alex hoped that was what it was. He wrote it in the journal and underlined it: *scared back into himself*. Held it there and examined it.

It felt true.

He wanted it to be true.

Casey came and sat beside him while the others talked.

"Fifteen yards," she said quietly.

"Yeah."

"It's never been that close in daylight."

"No."

She was quiet for a moment. The fire was good, the circle tight, the darkness outside it held at bay for now.

"It's testing," she said. "It's been testing all week. Distance. Response. What we react to." She paused. "Today was the closest it's come without cover — no fog, no tunnel, no night. Just open trail, daylight, fifteen yards." She paused again. "It wanted us to know exactly how close it was."

"Why?" Alex asked.

Casey looked at the fire. "Because it can afford to," she said. "Because it's not in a hurry. Because it wants us to know that the distance is its choice, not ours." She paused. "That's not animal behavior."

"No," Alex said. "It's not."

The fire crackled. Jordan said something across the circle and Sam laughed — real, the full version. And for a moment, in the firelight, with the sound of Sam laughing and the warmth of the fire and the stars enormous overhead, it was almost possible to believe they were just six people in the mountains.

Almost.

Taylor was humming.

Softly, under the conversation, her eyes on the fire. The four notes, patient and repeating.

Nobody said anything.

Alex looked at the dark beyond the fire's edge.

Fifteen yards last time.

He wondered what tomorrow would bring.

Chapter Twelve: The Rule

Nobody suggested it.

That was the thing Alex kept coming back to in the grey pre-dawn, sitting alone at the dead fire with cold coffee and the journal open to a blank page. Five days in the backcountry. Two people showing clear signs of partial conversion. The thing in the mountain close enough yesterday to reach out and touch. And not one person — not Sam, not Riley, not Casey, not even Taylor herself — had said the word *leave*.

He wrote it in the journal. Just the word, on its own line.

Leave.

Looked at it.

The problem was the math. They were at the furthest point from the trailhead — equidistant between the start and the end, the loop's midpoint. Going back meant retracing four days through territory the thing had been moving through alongside them, past the hollow, past the rhododendron, past the mining drainage. Going forward meant two and a half more days of unknown terrain, but terrain that moved away from the mine, away from the origin point, toward the southern trailhead and the parking lot and the van.

He'd been over this. He'd been over it twice a day since day two.

Forward was still better than back.

He wrote: *Forward is still better than back. Tell them today. Make it a group decision but make sure they arrive at the same answer.*

Then he looked at that last line for a long time.

Make sure they arrive at the same answer.

He crossed it out.

They arrived at it themselves, without him engineering it. This was either a relief or its own kind of worry — he couldn't decide which.

It was Casey who started it, over breakfast, in the practical tone she used when she was presenting findings rather than opinions.

"I want to talk about the guitar," she said.

The group looked at her.

"We haven't played it since night three," she said. "Nobody's said why. But I think we all know why, and I think we should say it out loud." She looked at Alex. "The whistle follows the music. Both times you played it came immediately after. The pattern is consistent."

"Consistent enough," Taylor said.

"Consistent enough," Casey agreed. "Which means the guitar stays in the pack. Not just for now — for the rest of the trip."

Alex looked at his pack, at the guitar neck protruding from the side pocket. He'd been reaching for it automatically every evening and stopping himself. The automatic reach was the thing — the muscle memory of it, the way his hands knew where it was without his mind getting involved.

"Agreed," he said.

"There's more," Casey said. "Sound generally. We've been — we've been loud, the way hikers are loud. Talking, laughing, the normal register of six people moving through the backcountry." She paused. "I think we need to reduce that. Not silence — silence is its own kind of signal. But lower. More deliberate."

"Why?" Jordan asked. And his voice was genuine, present — Jordan asking a real question.

"Because it's been learning us through sound," Casey said. "Every voice it's mimicked, it heard first. Every note it's replicated —" she glanced at Taylor — "it heard first. The less we give it, the less it has to work with."

Taylor was looking at the fire ring. At the cold ash. "It already has a lot," she said.

"Yes," Casey said. "But we don't have to give it more."

The group absorbed this. Sam was looking at her coffee. Jordan turned his cup in his hands. Riley was watching Casey with the expression of someone taking careful inventory of what was being said.

"What about leaving," Riley said.

Alex looked at them.

"I'm saying it because someone should," Riley said calmly. "We're at the midpoint. We can go back or forward. Both are the same distance. What are we doing and why?"

"Forward," Sam said immediately. Then she paused, as if surprised by her own certainty. "Forward moves us away from the mine. Back takes us through everything we've already been through, past the drainage, past the hollow."

"That's the logic I've been running," Alex said.

"Me too," Casey said.

Jordan nodded slowly. "Forward," he said. "Two and a half days." He said it like a calculation, like a man doing the arithmetic of endurance.

Taylor said nothing. She was still looking at the cold fire. Then she looked up.

"If we go back," she said, "I don't think I make it." She said it with her flat precision, the same voice she used for everything, which made it worse. "The pull gets stronger the closer we are to it. Going back means getting closer. I don't think I stay pointed the right direction if we go back."

Silence.

"Forward," Alex said.

Nobody argued.

They walked.

The trail today was neither the open ridge exposure of yesterday nor the enclosed tunnel of the rhododendron — it ran through a section of second-growth forest, the trees younger and closer together, the canopy not yet tall enough to create the cathedral effect of the older growth. It felt middle-register. Neither threatening nor reassuring. Just forest.

Alex had the guitar deeper in the pack today, wedged down below the food bag, the neck no longer visible from the outside. He'd done this before they left camp, quietly, while the others broke down their tents. He didn't know if it mattered. He didn't know if the thing tracked the guitar specifically or tracked sound generally or tracked something else entirely that he hadn't identified yet.

He'd done it anyway.

They walked in the lower register Casey had asked for. The conversation didn't stop — stopping would have been worse, the silence too loud, too pointed — but it dropped. Murmured exchanges rather than full-voice. Comments passed back and forth like notes rather than announced. The group had taken on a different texture, the easy high-energy of the first day compressed into something more conserved.

Sam walked beside Jordan. She'd done this every day, Alex realized, but today the proximity was different — deliberate, calibrated, close enough that their arms occasionally brushed. Jordan seemed to lean into this without noticing he was doing it.

Taylor walked behind Riley, close enough that their footsteps occasionally synchronized without either of them trying.

Alex watched this and thought about what Taylor had said that morning. *I don't think I stay pointed the right direction.* The honesty of it. The specific courage required to say that about yourself — to map your own erosion accurately and report it without softening.

She was still fighting. Actively, specifically, using everything she had.

He watched her footsteps behind Riley's and tried to find comfort in the synchronization and mostly succeeded.

They were an hour from the campsite when Casey pulled him aside.

Not dramatically — she simply slowed her pace until she was beside him and the others had moved a natural twenty yards ahead, the distance that accumulated when the trail was good and conversation was low.

"I remembered more," she said. Without preamble, without throat-clearing.

Alex said nothing. Waited.

"The conversion markers," she said. "The book had — there was a section on documented cases. Specific accounts from mountain communities, mostly late nineteenth century, some earlier. People who'd been converted." She paused. "The accounts described stages. I didn't remember this before. I remembered the symbol and the warning and the general lore. But I remembered the stages last night."

"Tell me."

"First stage — what the text called *the hearing*. The person becomes aware of the sound as distinct from background. Starts tracking it, attending to it." She paused. "Alex. That's everyone. All six of us. We've all been in first stage since night one."

He kept walking. "Second stage."

"*The answer*. Any acknowledgment. Verbal, physical, even sustained attention directed at it." She paused. "Jordan answered verbally. Taylor — I think Taylor's sustained attention, the constant pull she feels, the involuntary orientation toward it, may have functioned as an answer."

"And third?"

Casey was quiet for a moment. The trail ran between two large tulip poplars, their trunks straight and pale, and the light between them was clean and cool.

"The accounts called it *the learning*," she said. "The thing begins to work through the person. Uses them. The humming — the involuntary reproduction of sounds it wants made. The directional pull. The lost time." A pause. "The accounts described it as — the person becoming a kind of instrument. A way of producing the sounds that draw others."

"Taylor," Alex said.

"And Jordan, I think. Less visibly. But yes."

He walked. Counted. One through six, twenty yards ahead plus the two of them. Six total.

"Fourth stage," he said. Even though he didn't want to ask.

"The accounts didn't use a word," Casey said. "They described it. The person stops fighting the pull and follows it. Goes to the source." She paused. "And then — they come back. But what comes back uses the person's voice to call others." She stopped walking.

Alex stopped beside her.

"It's not possession," she said carefully. "At least — the accounts didn't describe it that way. More like — occupation. The person is still there, somewhere. But the thing is also there. And the thing uses them to recruit." She paused. "That's the word in the accounts. *Recruits*."

Alex looked at the trail ahead. At Jordan's back, the easy set of his shoulders. At Taylor's measured pace behind Riley.

"How do we stop it," he said.

Casey looked at him. "The accounts described one thing," she said. "Consistent across every case." She paused. "Distance. The ones who got out — who didn't fully convert — all shared one factor. They put distance between themselves and the source before the third stage completed."

"How much distance?"

"The accounts weren't specific. But all the cases that ended badly were people who stayed close to the origin point." She paused. "We're moving away from it. Every step today is the right direction."

"Is it enough?" he asked. "For Taylor and Jordan. Is the distance we have now —"

"I don't know," Casey said. "I don't know what *enough* means in terms of distance. I don't know if the process reverses or just stops." She looked at him. "I know we need more of it."

He nodded. Started walking.

"Alex," she said.

He looked back.

"The accounts describe one other thing," she said. Her voice had shifted slightly. Lower. More careful. "About the third stage. The involuntary sounds. The humming, the reproduction." She paused. "The accounts said — it uses sound to draw more people to the source. The recruited person produces the attractor sound, and others follow it." She met his eyes. "Taylor has been humming your guitar pattern. The pattern that preceded the whistle on night one. The pattern that drew it."

He stood very still.

"She's been reproducing the attractor," Casey said. "In her sleep, involuntarily. The thing is using her to —" she stopped. "If anyone in the group follows the sound she's making —"

"Nobody's following it," Alex said. "Nobody's going to follow it."

"As long as we know what it is," Casey said.

"Now we know," he said.

He turned and walked toward the others, his pace even, his face arranged into something that wouldn't alarm anyone. Casey fell into step beside him.

Ahead, Taylor was walking with her eyes on the trail, her footsteps careful and deliberate.

And under the sound of the wind and the footsteps and the low murmur of Sam and Jordan's conversation, so faint you could almost miss it —

Four notes.

Rising, rising, falling, hold.

Camp that night was the quietest of the trip.

Not silent — never silent, silence was wrong, silence was what happened when the birds stopped and the creek stopped and everything held its breath. But low. The fire modest, the conversation a murmur, the spaces between words longer than usual and more comfortable for it.

Jordan fell asleep by the fire before nine. Not the wrong stillness — just tiredness, his chin dropping, catching himself, dropping again, Sam eventually putting her hand on his shoulder and saying *go to bed* in the quiet firm way of someone who had been saying that to Jordan for fifteen years. He went.

Taylor turned in shortly after. She stopped beside Alex on her way to her tent.

"I heard what you and Casey were talking about," she said. Quietly. No accusation in it.

He looked at her.

"On the trail," she said. "Not the words. But I knew from the way you looked when you came back." She paused. "I'm the attractor. The humming."

"Taylor —"

"Don't," she said. Not harshly. "I'm not asking you to manage it. I'm telling you I know." She looked at her tent. Then back at him. "I'm going to try to stay awake tonight. See if I can control it when I'm conscious." She paused. "I've been able to control it when I'm aware. It's the sleep I can't govern."

"You need to sleep," he said.

"I know that too," she said. She almost smiled — the edge of it, the Taylor version. "There are no good options. I'm noting that." She went to her tent.

He sat alone at the dying fire for a long time.

Riley came out of their tent and sat beside him without asking. Just appeared, the way Riley appeared when it mattered, and sat close enough that their shoulders touched.

"You talked to Casey," Riley said.

"Yeah."

"Tell me."

So he told them. All of it — the stages, the accounts, the distance, the attractor. Riley listened without interrupting, which was a specific skill not everyone had. When he finished they sat in the silence of it for a moment.

"We're all in first stage," Riley said.

"Yes."

"Just by listening. By tracking it."

"Yes."

Riley was quiet. "Are you worried about yourself?" they asked.

He looked at the fire. "I've been listening harder than anyone," he said. "I've been tracking it, attending to it, cataloguing every instance since night one." He paused. "Sustained attention may function as an answer."

Riley looked at him. He could feel the weight of it without turning.

"You should have told me sooner," Riley said.

"I know."

"Are you —" Riley stopped. Started again. "Do you feel the pull?"

He thought about what he'd written in the journal and crossed out. What he'd written and kept. The frequency below the whistle, felt in the chest. The moment in the dream when he'd opened his mouth to answer.

"Sometimes," he said.

Riley's hand found his. The same hand, the same grip, the same held pressure that had become its own kind of language between them over the past four days.

He held on.

"Two more days," Riley said.

"Two more days," he said.

The fire went out.

The mountains held their dark around them, enormous and old and entirely indifferent to the small human problem of what was in them.

Alex counted in his head.

Six.

He held Riley's hand.

Six.

Chapter Thirteen: Second Death / Gore

Jordan was gone at 4am.

Alex knew before he fully woke — the count ran automatically now, even in sleep, and the number that surfaced him from unconsciousness was five. Just five. He was unzipping the tent before his eyes had fully adjusted to the dark.

Cold. The camp smelled of woodsmoke and wet leaves and the particular cold of deep mountain night. Stars through the canopy gap, hard and white. The tents around him — Riley's breathing inside their shared space, Casey's tent dark and still, Sam's tent dark and still.

Jordan's tent: door unzipped. Empty.

He grabbed his boots. Didn't tie them. Swept the headlamp across the camp perimeter — nothing, nobody, the tree line dark in every direction.

Sam's tent opened.

She didn't say anything. She looked at Jordan's tent and then at Alex with an expression that had gone past fear into something operational. She was already dressed. Boots laced. Like part of her had been waiting for this.

"How long," she said.

"I don't know. I just woke."

"Which direction."

He looked at the camp. At the ground. The leaf litter showed disturbance at the northern edge — not much, just the compression of footsteps moving through it with purpose. He swept the headlamp. The trail of it was visible for ten feet before the dark swallowed it.

North.

Not northwest. Not toward the mine. North, toward the day's route, toward the trail they'd be walking tomorrow.

"Wake the others," he said.

Casey was awake before Sam reached her tent. Riley emerged three seconds after Sam's knock, already dressed, which meant Riley had been lying awake in the dark the same way Alex had been lying awake in the dark and neither of them had said so.

Taylor took longer. When she came out her face had the specific blankness of someone pulled from deep sleep, and Alex watched her orient — the camp, the headlamps, the open door of Jordan's tent — and he watched the blankness resolve into understanding and he watched the understanding hit her.

"How long ago," she said.

"Unknown. Maybe an hour, maybe more."

She looked north. Into the dark. Her jaw set.

"He answered again," she said.

"We don't know that."

"We know that," she said.

He didn't argue.

They moved in a group, tight, no gaps. Alex in front with the headlamp, Riley directly behind him, the others in a close chain. He'd said it before they left camp: *nobody separates, nobody answers anything, if anyone stops walking we all stop*. They'd nodded. They were past the point of needing reasons attached to rules.

The trail north was clear under the headlamp — the packed earth showing the impression of boots, fresh enough to be Jordan's, moving at a pace that looked purposeful rather than wandering. Heading somewhere. Going toward something rather than away from it.

Alex followed the prints and tried not to think about what that meant.

The forest was wrong at night. Not the daytime wrongness of too-quiet birds and moving shadows and the attended weight of something close. Different wrong. The dark between the trees was total and dimensional, depth without resolution, and the headlamp's beam created a moving circle of the known surrounded by unknown in every direction. His peripheral vision kept filling with shapes that resolved into trees when he looked directly at them. He stopped looking.

Don't look directly at it, he reminded himself. *Don't answer. Don't stop.*

One mile. The prints were still there, still fresh, still purposeful.

Sam was behind him. He could hear her breathing — controlled, deliberate, the breathing of someone managing themselves very carefully.

Then Riley, quietly: "Alex."

He stopped.

Listened.

From ahead on the trail — not far, a hundred yards, maybe less — a sound.

Not the whistle.

A voice.

Jordan's voice. Clear and carrying in the cold night air, the specific timbre of it unmistakable — Alex had heard that voice for twelve years across a hundred different contexts, and whatever variations time and experience had worked on it, he knew it the way you knew a piece of music you'd heard so many times it lived somewhere below conscious memory.

Jordan's voice, saying: *this way*.

Sam made a sound behind him. Small. Pressed down fast.

This way. Two words. Conversational. The voice of a man directing a friend down a familiar path.

"That's not Jordan," Alex said. Quietly. For Sam. For all of them.

"I know," Sam said. Her voice was steady. It cost her something to make it steady.

This way, the voice said again. From ahead. From the dark beyond the headlamp's reach.

Casey's hand found Alex's shoulder from behind. Not grabbing — just present. *I'm here. We're here.*

"Jordan!" Alex called. Full voice, into the dark. Breaking the low register they'd maintained all day. He didn't care. "Jordan, we're on the trail. Come back to the trail."

Silence.

The voice did not repeat.

A long moment.

Then: crashing. Off-trail, to the right of the path, something moving through undergrowth with no effort at quiet. Something large moving fast.

And then Jordan stumbled out of the trees and into the headlamp's beam.

He was alive. That was first. He was upright and moving and his eyes when the light hit them were present — blinking, adjusting, the depth returning.

He looked at them. At the five of them on the trail with their headlamps and their close formation and their faces doing what their faces were doing.

"Hey," he said. His voice was rough. Hoarse.

"Hey," Alex said.

"I was —" Jordan looked behind him. At the dark trees he'd come out of. "I was looking for Sam."

Silence.

"Sam's here," Alex said carefully. "Sam's been here."

Jordan looked at Sam. At her face, her headlamp, her presence on the trail six feet in front of him. Something worked through his expression — confusion, then the specific horror of a person doing arithmetic that comes out wrong, then the settling, the grim arriving-at-understanding.

"It used her voice," he said.

"Yeah," Alex said.

Jordan closed his eyes. Opened them. "How far did I go?"

"A mile."

He absorbed this. "I woke up and she was —" he stopped. "It was Sam. It was exactly Sam. Saying she'd heard something and to come see." He looked at the real Sam. "I didn't question it. I just —"

"I know," Sam said. She crossed the distance between them and put both hands on his face, the way you checked a person for damage. He let her. "I know."

"I'm not — I'm still —"

"I know," she said. "I see you."

He held her gaze. Then he nodded. Once.

"Okay," Alex said. "Let's —"

The sound came from the left side of the trail.

Not the whistle. Not a voice. Something else — the same sound that had woken Alex two nights ago, the creek going silent. But here, now, in the trees, ten yards off the trail. A sound like air displacement. Like something large shifting its weight.

Everyone's headlamps swung left simultaneously.

The beams hit the trees, the undergrowth, the dark between trunks.

Sam's bear canister was hanging from a branch. Her bear canister — secured to the bear cable at camp, a quarter mile behind them. Hanging from a branch at head height, six feet off the trail.

Left there.

Deliberately.

I was here too, it said. I was here and here and here.

Nobody spoke.

Then from the right side of the trail — the opposite side, ten yards, a perfect mirror — the sound again. The air displacement. The weight shifting.

Both sides.

"Move," Alex said.

They moved.

They ran. Not fully — a controlled fast walk that became a run when the sounds on both sides of the trail continued, pacing them, the sounds of something moving through undergrowth parallel to the path, flanking them on both sides with a synchronization that made Alex's mind skitter away from what it implied.

Jordan was running well. Fully present, fully Jordan, the shock of the voice apparently having burned something clean rather than muddying him further. Sam was beside him, their pace matched. Casey behind them. Riley behind Casey.

Alex last.

He was last and he could hear both sides. Both flanking movements, both sets of sounds, tracking them with the terrible patience of things that were not hurrying. Not trying to close the gap. Just maintaining it. Just making certain they knew.

We know where you are. We have always known where you are.

The camp appeared ahead — the pale shapes of the tents in the sweep of the headlamp, the dead fire ring, the sycamores.

They stopped at the camp perimeter.

Alex turned around.

The trail was empty in the headlamp's beam. The sounds had stopped at the tree line.

He stood and waited and let the headlamp run and nothing came out of the dark.

He counted.

One. Two. Three. Four. Five.

Five.

He counted again.

Five.

He counted three times before his mind would accept what the number meant.

"Where's Taylor," Riley said.

They looked at each other. The five of them in the camp, the headlamps crisscrossing, the shapes of the tents around them.

Five tents. Six sleeping bags. Five people.

"She was behind me," Casey said. Her voice had gone white. "She was right behind me on the trail."

"When did you last —" Alex started.

"When we ran," Casey said. "When we started running she was there and then —"

Sam made a sound.

Alex was already moving back toward the trail.

"Stay here," he said. "All four of you, stay here, do not move."

"Alex —" Riley said.

"Stay here," he said. "I'll be back in five minutes. If I'm not back in five minutes you follow the trail south, you don't stop, you get out."

"I'm not —"

"Riley." He turned. He looked at them. "Five minutes. Please."

A moment. Riley's face doing everything it was doing.

"Five minutes," Riley said.

He went back to the trail.

He found her a hundred yards north.

She was standing in the middle of the trail, facing north, perfectly still. Pack on. Boots laced. Like she'd stopped mid-stride and simply ceased.

"Taylor," he said.

She turned around.

Her face was wrong.

Not vacant, not absent, not the fractional delay of Jordan in the rhododendron. Her face was present and awake and entirely aware. Her eyes found him immediately, locked on him, and the expression in them was something he didn't have immediate language for.

She looked like someone standing at a threshold.

Like someone who had arrived somewhere after a long journey and recognized the place.

"Alex," she said. Her voice was her voice. Taylor's voice. But something underneath it had changed register. Something that had always been tightly governed in Taylor was not governed now.

"Come back to camp," he said.

"I know what's up there," she said.

"Taylor."

"I can see it," she said. And she said it with a wonder that was worse than fear, worse than blankness, worse than anything he'd heard from her all week. A genuine wonder. Something she was not fighting. "Not with my eyes. I can just — I know it. I know what it looks like. I know what it sounds like from the inside." She paused. "It's not bad, Alex. That's what I can't — I can't explain how it's not —"

"Stop," he said.

She stopped.

He walked to her. He put both hands on her shoulders, the way Sam had held Jordan, and he made her look at him. Made her look directly at him.

"Taylor," he said. "What's your last name."

She blinked. "What?"

"What's your last name."

"Kim," she said. "Taylor Kim, I know who I am, I'm not —"

"Where'd you go to college."

"Ohio State, Alex, this isn't —"

"What did you order the last time we got Thai food, the four of us, three years ago."

A pause. Something shifted in her face. The wonder dimming, the familiarity returning, the architecture of herself reasserting.

"Pad see ew," she said. "Extra basil."

"Yeah," he said. "Extra basil. Come back to camp."

She looked at him for a long moment. The threshold expression fading. Taylor Kim, Ohio State, pad see ew, coming back through the details of herself like a person finding handholds on a wall.

"Okay," she said. Quiet.

"Okay," he said.

He kept his hands on her shoulders and walked her back.

He wrote in the journal at 6am while the others slept, finally, from exhaustion. The sky was going grey in the east.

Sam's bear canister in a tree on the trail. Flanking sounds on both sides running with us. Coordinated. That's the word I keep not writing — coordinated. Multiple sources moving in sync.

There's more than one.

That's what I didn't want to write. There's more than one.

Taylor was at a threshold. I don't know how close. I know that she came back when I named her. When I gave her the specific details of herself. That worked. I don't know if it will keep working.

Jordan answered a voice, went a mile into the dark, came back when I called. Taylor went north on her own. She said she could see it — not with her eyes. She said it wasn't bad.

That's the most frightening thing anyone has said all week.

Two more days. I keep writing two more days.

Today Sam is going to ask me if we can make it in one.

I'm going to say yes.

He closed the journal.

The sycamores stood pale in the growing light. The creek ran. The birds came in as the sky lightened — the thrush first, its complicated water-over-stones song filling the hollow from above.

Birds. Normal birds.

He held onto that.

From Taylor's tent — faint, almost too faint to hear, threading through the nylon walls —

Four notes.

Rising, rising, falling, hold.

She was asleep.

She was still making the sound.

Chapter Fourteen: Minor Camper Death

They were packed before dawn.

Nobody had suggested it. Nobody had needed to. The camp had come down in the thin grey pre-light with the focused efficiency of people who had decided something without saying it — sleeping bags compressed, poles collapsed, stakes pulled, the whole architecture of the night dismantled and loaded in under twenty minutes. The fire ring untouched. The bear cable still strung between the sycamores with nothing hanging from it anymore.

Alex had told them what he'd written. Not the journal — he'd told them the conclusion. *There's more than one*. He'd said it standing in the camp at 6am with the sky going pale and five tired faces looking at him, and he'd watched it land.

Sam had nodded. Like she'd already known.

"How many," Jordan asked.

"I don't know."

"More than two?"

"I don't know," he said. "The flanking last night was coordinated. Two sources minimum. Could be more."

Jordan looked at the tree line. His jaw worked. "Okay," he said.

"We're doing one day," Alex said. "Sam was going to ask and I'm going to say yes before she asks. We do two days of distance in one. We push hard, we stay together, we don't stop until we have to."

Sam looked at him. "I was going to ask," she confirmed.

"I know."

"How far," Casey said.

"Fourteen miles," he said. "To the southern trailhead access trail. We camp there tonight, we're out tomorrow morning in two hours."

Silence.

"Taylor," Alex said.

Taylor was the question in the room. Taylor was the variable. She was standing with her pack already on, her face composed, her eyes clear in the grey light. She looked like herself. She'd looked like herself since he'd walked her back from the trail at 4am and she'd gone into her tent and he'd heard no more humming for the rest of the night, or maybe she'd hummed and he'd been too depleted to hear it.

"Fourteen miles," she said.

"Yeah."

She looked at the trail south. The direction they hadn't come from. New terrain, unknown terrain, the two and a half days of the loop's second half compressed into one brutal push.

"I can do fourteen miles," she said.

He believed her. He believed Taylor Kim could do fourteen miles through rough backcountry on bad sleep through an active process of corruption that she was managing by sheer force of self-knowledge and the specific stubbornness that had always been her defining feature. He believed it and he was also terrified of what fourteen miles would cost her.

"Then let's go," he said.

They met the other campers at mile three.

Two of them — a man and a woman, late thirties, day packs suggesting they'd come in from the southern trailhead access and were doing a shorter loop. They appeared on the trail ahead going north, the opposite direction, and the sight of them — two ordinary humans with day packs and clean clothes and the bright easy energy of people who had been in the mountains for a few hours rather than five days — hit Alex like a physical thing.

The man raised a hand in the trail greeting. "Morning."

"Morning," Alex said.

They slowed to a stop, the natural courtesy of trail encounters, and Alex watched his group respond to the presence of outside people — the slight loosening, the social reflexes reasserting after days of compression. Sam smiled. Jordan said something easy and natural. The social machinery, still working.

The man's name was David. The woman was his wife, Marisol. They were from Knoxville, doing a two-night loop, first time in this section of the park. They had the comfortable confidence of experienced hikers who knew their gear and their fitness and had no reason to doubt the mountain.

Alex looked at them and thought: *they haven't heard it yet.*

"You all heading out?" David asked, clocking the full packs, the southbound direction.

"Yeah," Alex said. "Cutting the trip short."

"Weather coming?"

"No. Just — " he paused. He looked at David's open friendly face. At Marisol checking her phone for signal she wasn't going to find. "Just time."

David nodded. Hiker's understanding — plans changed, reasons were private.

"Beautiful up here," Marisol said. She was looking north, up the trail they were about to walk into. "We saw a Louisiana waterthrush about a mile back."

"Rare this late in the season," Jordan said automatically.

Alex looked at Jordan.

Jordan looked at Alex.

I know, Jordan's face said. I know I said it the same way.

"Yeah," David said, smiling. "Bird guy?"

"Little bit," Jordan said. The smile was Jordan's smile. The knowledge behind it — the question of whether the knowledge was Jordan's or stored material running on Jordan — was the question Alex had been sitting with for three days and still hadn't answered.

"Well," David said. "Safe travels."

"You too," Alex said.

They stepped aside to let David and Marisol pass. Standard trail courtesy, two groups making room on a narrow path, a moment of proximity as they filed past each other, backpacks and trekking poles and the small choreography of mountain passage.

Marisol smiled at Alex as she passed.

He smiled back.

And then they were past, and the trail ahead was empty, and Alex turned south and kept walking.

He told himself he'd said enough.

He'd cut the trip short — that was visible, that communicated something to anyone paying attention. And David and Marisol were experienced, they weren't day hikers in cotton, they knew mountains.

He told himself this at mile four.

At mile five he told it to himself again, with less conviction.

At mile six Casey fell into step beside him.

"We should have warned them," she said.

He kept walking. "Warned them how. What would we have said."

"Something," she said. "Anything. Don't answer the whistle. Don't follow voices. Something specific enough to be useful."

"They would have thought we were unwell."

"Maybe," Casey said. "Probably. But they'd have remembered it. When something happened they'd have had a framework." She paused. "We had the ranger. Even the ranger's vague warning — it helped. It gave us a category for what was happening."

He walked.

"They're heading north," he said. "Toward the hollow. Toward everything we just came through."

"I know."

He stopped walking.

Casey stopped beside him.

He turned and looked back up the trail. Empty. David and Marisol were long past the last visible curve, a mile or more ahead by now, moving north with their bright easy energy and their day packs and their complete absence of the category they needed.

"I can't go back," he said.

"I know."

"I can't leave the group to go back and I can't take the group back."

"I know," Casey said. "I'm not saying we go back. I'm saying we should have said something when we had the chance." She paused. "I'm saying I should have said something. I had the information and I was standing right there and I thought about it and I didn't."

He looked at her. At Casey's face, the careful precise face that had been holding so much for so many days.

"I thought about it too," he said.

They stood on the trail.

"Keep moving," he said.

They kept moving.

They heard it at mile eight.

From behind them — north, back the way they'd come, back toward David and Marisol who were somewhere up there in the terrain Alex and his group had just cleared. A sound that all six of them knew with a specificity that had become cellular, that lived now in the body rather than the mind.

The whistle.

Single note. High and clean.

Then silence.

Then — faint, at the edge of what was audible, a direction and a distance that made Alex's chest tighten — a voice. Not Jordan's voice, not Taylor's voice, not anyone in their group. A voice he didn't recognize. A man's voice.

Hello?

One word. Carrying through the still mountain air. Curious, unfrightened, the voice of someone who had heard something they didn't understand and responded the way reasonable people responded to sounds in the backcountry.

Hello?

Sam had stopped walking. Her hand was over her mouth.

Jordan had his eyes closed.

"Keep moving," Alex said.

"Alex —" Sam said.

"Keep moving," he said. "There is nothing we can do. We cannot go back. Keep moving."

She looked at him. Her eyes were doing something that he couldn't fix and couldn't address right now and hated himself for not being able to fix.

"Sam," he said. "We keep moving or we lose more people. Our people. Keep moving."

A moment.

She moved.

They all moved.

Behind them, the mountain was quiet.

The silence lasted four miles.

Then, at mile twelve, with the southern access trail junction visible on the map as forty minutes ahead, Jordan made a sound.

Not a word. Not a directed sound. Just — a sound, involuntary, from somewhere in his chest. A small sound of pain.

Alex was at his shoulder immediately. "What."

Jordan was walking. Still walking. Eyes forward, pace maintained. But his face was doing something — working through something, the muscles around his jaw tight, his brow contracted.

"Jordan."

"I heard him," Jordan said. Low. Barely above a breath. "The man. When he said hello. I heard it and I —" he stopped. "Something in me answered. Not out loud. Not — I didn't speak. But something in me responded to it."

Alex kept walking beside him. "What do you mean responded."

"Like recognition," Jordan said. "Like — yes, *there you are*. Like something in me knew that sound and was glad." He paused. "That's not mine. I know that's not mine. But it was in me."

Alex said nothing for a moment. They walked.

"You told me," Alex said. "That's the thing. Whatever it put in you — it told me. Which means you're still in charge of what it does."

Jordan looked at him. "For how long."

"Today," Alex said. "Just today. That's all we need."

Jordan held his gaze. Then he nodded once and looked back at the trail and walked.

They reached the access trail junction at 4pm, destroyed. Fourteen miles in nine hours with elevation change and bad sleep and the weight of what they were carrying that had nothing to do with their packs. Sam sat down on a trailhead marker post and stayed there for two minutes without moving. Casey leaned against a tree. Riley took Alex's hand and held it and didn't say anything.

Taylor walked to the junction sign and looked at it. At the arrow pointing south: *Trailhead 2.1 miles.*

"Two miles," she said.

"Tonight or morning," Alex said.

"Tonight," Taylor said.

He looked at her. She was exhausted — he could see it in the set of her shoulders, the particular weight of a body that had been carrying more than its physical load. But her eyes were clear. The threshold look was gone. Fourteen miles of southbound movement had done something — not fixed, not reversed, but the space between Taylor and the thing working through her felt different than it had at 4am.

"You sure," he said.

"If I sleep here I don't know what I do in the night," she said simply. "If I'm moving I'm in charge of my feet." She looked at the sign. "I want to be two miles closer to out."

He looked at the group. Wrecked faces, willing eyes.

"Two more miles," he said.

No one argued.

They made the access trail campsite as the last light left the sky, a flat area at the trail's edge with a fire ring and a bear post and the distant sound of a road — an actual road, the first road-sound any of them had heard in five days. Sam heard it first and stopped walking and cocked her head and said *is that a car* with such naked relief that Jordan put his arm around her and she let him.

It was a car. Somewhere below them, on the park road, invisible but real. The ordinary world, at two miles' distance, making its ordinary sounds.

They made camp. Fire. Food. The motions of it.

Nobody talked much. The day had used everything. But the fire was good and the road-sound came up through the trees intermittently and each time it did Alex watched the group respond to it — the slight easing, the fractional release.

After dinner Riley sat beside him.

"Tomorrow," they said.

"Tomorrow," he said.

"We drive home."

"We drive home."

Riley leaned their head on his shoulder. He stayed very still, the way you stayed still when something you'd wanted for a long time was happening and you didn't want to disturb it.

"Alex," Riley said.

"Yeah."

"The man back there. David."

He looked at the fire.

"I know," he said.

"We don't know what happened."

"No."

"He might have been fine," Riley said. "He might have heard it and walked away from it."

"He might have," Alex said.

Riley was quiet.

"We don't know," they said again. Softer. Like a thing they were saying for themselves as much as for him.

"No," he said. "We don't."

He wrote in the journal late, after Riley slept, by the last of the fire:

David said hello. I heard it from a mile away. Something in Jordan recognized the sound of a person answering.

I don't know what happened to David and Marisol. I'm writing that down because not writing it is worse.

I should have said something. Three words would have been enough. Don't answer it. Three words at a trail junction and I said safe travels and kept walking.

Two miles to the access road. Six hours to the trailhead in the morning.

Taylor did fourteen miles. She's still here. Jordan's still here. I count them both as still here.

Casey asked me once — the first night, I think, or maybe the second — if I was scared. I said I was alert. There's a difference.

I'm not sure there's a difference anymore.

He looked at the last line.

Left it.

Closed the notebook.

Somewhere up the mountain, in the direction they'd come from, the night was very quiet.

He didn't let himself think about why.

Chapter Fifteen: The Split

They should have been out by noon.

The access trail was 2.1 miles, marked easy on the park map, a well-maintained path that dropped steadily from the backcountry junction to the southern trailhead parking area. Alex had done the math the night before: two hours, maybe less, out by ten if they left at eight. Then the van. Then the road. Then everything the road meant — phones with signal, food that wasn't freeze-dried, the ordinary world receiving them back without ceremony.

He'd told them this. He'd said it like a promise.

They left at eight.

At 8.40 Jordan stopped walking and said he needed to go back.

He said it the way you said something you'd been holding for a while and had finally decided to put down. Flat. Considered. Not distressed — which was the most frightening part. Jordan in distress was Jordan. Jordan calm and certain about walking back into the mountain was something else.

They were on the access trail, ninety minutes from the trailhead, the sound of the road already occasionally audible through the trees when the wind was right. Ninety minutes. Alex had been counting the distance in his head with the focus of a man counting down from a number he needed to reach.

Jordan stopped.

"I need to go back," he said.

The group stopped around him.

Sam looked at him. The look was many things at once — fear and love and the specific exhaustion of someone who had been watching for this and had hoped the watching would prevent it.

"Jordan," she said.

"I know," he said. He looked at her. "I know what it sounds like. I know what you're going to say." He paused. "I'm not — it's not like before. It's not a pull. It's not the thing making me want to go." He stopped. "It's me."

"What do you mean it's you," Alex said.

Jordan looked at him. His eyes were clear. Present. Jordan's eyes.

"David," he said.

Silence on the trail.

"We left him up there," Jordan said. "We heard him answer and we kept walking. I keep —" he stopped. Started again. "There's something in me that recognized the sound he made. You told me that means it's using me. That means I have a connection to it, to whatever network it's —" he shook his head. "I might be able to find him. I might be able to go back up there and find him because of what's in me. Use it."

"Jordan," Casey said carefully. "That's not —"

"I know how it sounds," he said. "I know. But I've been thinking about it for fourteen miles and I can't — I can't just leave."

"David was a stranger," Taylor said. Not unkindly. Flatly. "We met him for four minutes."

"He answered because we didn't warn him," Jordan said. "We were standing right there and we didn't say anything and he walked north and he answered it."

He looked at Alex. "You know that. You wrote it in your journal. I saw your face when you were writing it."

Alex said nothing.

"I'm not going to let you go back," Sam said.

"Sam —"

"No." Her voice was steady and absolute. "No. Listen to me. Whatever you're feeling right now — the logic of it, the reasoning, the part that says this is you and not the thing — I cannot tell the difference. I don't have the tools to tell the difference. And neither do you." She stepped close to him. "You walked a mile into the dark at 4am. You turned around on the ridge. You said something in you recognized David's voice. And now you want to go back alone into the mountain." She held his gaze. "I can't tell which part of that is Jordan. Can you?"

A long moment.

Jordan's jaw worked.

He looked away from Sam. Into the trees. Up the slope, north, the direction they'd come from.

And Alex watched his face, watched it carefully, watched the specific geography of it — the clear eyes, the working jaw, the tilt of his head toward the north — and tried to locate Jordan in it. Tried to find the twelve years of friendship mapped onto the features, the specific person he knew behind the specific face he was looking at.

He found him.

He also found the other thing. The thing that had been living alongside Jordan for three days, patient and quiet, waiting for exactly this kind of moment. The thing that used Jordan's own decency against him. That knew Jordan would feel responsible for David because Jordan always felt responsible. That had shaped the pull into something that felt like conscience because Jordan's conscience was the door most likely to open.

"He's using your best quality," Alex said.

Jordan looked at him.

"The thing in you," Alex said. "It's not making you want to go back because it's pulling you north. It's making you want to go back because it knows that you would. Because you're someone who goes back." He paused. "That's not you fighting it. That's it using you."

Jordan stood very still.

"How do you know," he said. Very quiet.

"I don't," Alex said. "I can't prove it. But I know you. And I know that you going back alone into that mountain helps one thing and it isn't David."

A long moment on the trail. The trees on both sides. The distant road sound, intermittent, there and gone.

Jordan looked at Sam.

Sam held her ground. She didn't reach for him, didn't soften it. She let the answer be what it was.

He looked at the trail north. One long last look.

Then he turned south.

"Okay," he said. Low. Heavy. The weight of a person who had put something down and wasn't sure they'd done the right thing and was walking anyway.

"Okay," Alex said.

They walked.

Taylor fell back beside Alex twenty minutes later.

She'd been quiet since Jordan's stop — more than her usual quiet, a specific inward quality, the expression of someone doing complex arithmetic. She walked without looking at the trail, her feet finding the path without input from her eyes, her attention somewhere else.

"He almost went," she said.

"Yeah."

"So did I," she said. "Last night, on the trail. And this morning, when I woke up." She paused. "I woke up with my boots already on. I don't remember putting them on."

He looked at her.

"I stayed," she said. "I'm still here. I'm telling you because I need someone to have the count right." She paused. "I'm here but the boots were on."

He held this. The image of it. Taylor waking in her tent, fully dressed, no memory of preparing to leave.

"How'd you stop," he said.

"Pad see ew," she said.

He looked at her.

"You did it to me on the trail at 4am," she said. "The details. So I keep a list now." She touched her jacket pocket. "In here. Things that are mine. Specific things. When I wake up and the boots are on I read the list and I come back."

He thought about Taylor Kim, alone in her tent at 5am, reading a list of herself back to herself to stay inside her own mind. The image was so specifically Taylor — the preparation, the self-sufficiency, the practical solution applied to an impractical problem — that it hit him somewhere undefended.

"What's on the list," he said.

"Private," she said.

"Okay."

"But it works," she said. "So far it works."

"So far," he said.

"So far is all any of us have," she said.

They were forty minutes from the trailhead when Casey stopped walking.

Not the wrong stop — not the planted-feet stillness of the converted, not the slack expression of someone absent. Casey stopped and turned and looked back up the trail with her hand raised. The gesture of a person who had heard something.

"What," Alex said.

"Shh," she said.

They listened.

The trail behind them. The trees on both sides. The wind moving through the high branches, intermittent. The distant road sound.

And then — yes. Yes, there it was. From behind them, from up the trail, from the direction they'd come.

Footsteps.

Someone on the access trail behind them. Moving south. Moving toward them.

Coming fast.

Alex counted his group. One through five — and himself, six. All present. All in front of him, all facing south except Casey.

The footsteps kept coming.

Getting closer.

And then Marisol came around the bend in the trail.

She was alone.

That was the first thing. She was alone and she was moving fast, her day pack bouncing, her face doing something that Alex couldn't immediately read at distance — it resolved as she got closer into an expression he recognized. He'd seen it in mirrors for five days.

She'd been frightened. She wasn't frightened now. She was past frightened into the operational mode that came after.

She saw them and slowed. Stopped ten feet away.

She looked at them. At their full packs, their five days of backcountry wear, the specific quality of a group that had been through something.

"You know," she said. Not a question.

"Yeah," Alex said.

"We heard it the first night," she said. "The whistle. David said it was an animal." She paused. "This morning he heard a voice. I was asleep. I woke up and he was gone." She stopped. Something in her face moved, quickly, pressed down. "I looked for an hour. He was just — gone."

Silence on the trail.

"I'm sorry," Sam said.

Marisol looked at her. Received the words. Nodded once, the smallest possible nod.

"Are you hurt?" Casey asked.

"No."

"Did you answer it?" Alex asked. "At any point. The whistle or a voice — did you respond?"

She looked at him. "No," she said. "David always answered things. I don't." A pause. "I told him not to this morning. I said don't answer it and he said *it's just someone who needs help* and he —" she stopped.

The trail held the silence.

Alex looked at her. She was present, clear-eyed, operational. She'd been in the mountain for two nights and something had taken her husband and she was standing on the access trail heading south with the specific controlled calm of a person who had decided to survive.

"Walk with us," he said.

She looked at him for a moment. Then she stepped into the group.

Seven now. Alex counted and got seven and the number felt strange after six days of six — strange and good, the addition of a person who hadn't answered it, who had run instead of following, who was still clean and full and entirely herself.

He counted again just to feel the seven. One through seven.

They walked.

Marisol moved in the middle of the group, beside Sam, and Sam didn't try to talk to her and Marisol didn't try to talk to Sam and this turned out to be exactly right — the company without the demand of it, two people moving together through the same difficult air.

Jordan watched Marisol with an expression Alex couldn't fully read. Something working behind his eyes. He walked south and he watched Marisol and said nothing.

At mile one of the access trail Marisol said quietly, to no one in particular: "He said *it's just someone who needs help*. David. That's what he said."

Nobody answered.

"He was always like that," she said. "He'd stop for anyone." A pause. "That's who he is."

Sam reached over and briefly, lightly, touched Marisol's arm.

Marisol kept walking.

Taylor fell back to walk beside Alex.

She said nothing for a moment. Then: "Jordan."

He looked ahead at Jordan. Walking well. Moving south. The set of his shoulders, the pace of his steps.

"He wanted to go back for David," Taylor said. "Because of the voice recognition thing, the connection."

"Yeah."

"But now there's Marisol," she said. "And Marisol is evidence that David answered it. That David is —" she paused. "If Jordan's connection runs the other direction — if he can feel David wherever David is now —"

Alex looked at Jordan.

"He's not going to try again," Alex said. Because he needed to say it.

"I know," Taylor said. "I'm not saying he is." She paused. "I'm saying it's going to get louder for him. The closer David gets to fully — the louder the connection is going to be." She paused. "I know because mine is louder when I'm near the source. Yours would be loud too if you'd answered."

He looked at her.

"I'm saying watch him," she said. "More than before."

"I'm watching everyone more than before," he said.

"Watch him more than that," she said.

She moved back up to her place in the group.

They came out of the trees at 11.20am.

The southern trailhead was a gravel parking area with a wooden map board and a vault toilet and two other cars besides their van. The van sat at the far end of the lot, dusty and sun-faded from five days of sitting, and the sight of it — the specific unremarkable shape of it, the familiar dent in the rear quarter panel from a parking garage in Charlotte two years ago — hit Alex like a hand pressed flat against his sternum.

They stopped at the tree line. All seven of them. Looking at the parking lot.

No one moved for a moment.

Then Sam made a sound that was not quite a laugh and not quite a sob and started walking toward the van and Jordan went with her and Casey went with her and the group moved out of the trees and into the gravel lot and the ordinary world.

Alex stood at the tree line.

He turned and looked back up the trail. The trees, the shadows, the path disappearing around the first curve and heading north into the mountain.

The mountain, enormous and old and entirely silent.

He listened.

No whistle. No voice. No flanking sounds in the undergrowth.

Just wind in the high canopy and a woodpecker somewhere and the ordinary sounds of an ordinary mountain on an ordinary morning.

He turned around.

Riley was waiting for him at the tree line.

"Come on," Riley said.

He walked out of the trees.

They sat in the parking lot for twenty minutes before anyone could face the idea of moving. Sam sat on the van's bumper and put her face in her hands and stayed there. Jordan sat beside her with his hand on her back and said nothing, which was right. Casey was already on her phone, the signal bars appearing as she moved around the lot, her face doing what it did when she was reading something carefully.

Marisol sat on the ground with her back against the map board and her knees up and her eyes closed. Breathing. Just breathing.

Taylor stood at the lot's edge, facing south, facing the road. Not north. South. Alex watched her and felt something loosen fractionally.

Riley came to stand beside him.

"Hospital first," Riley said quietly. "Marisol. And then the ranger station."

"Yeah."

"You need to tell them about David."

"I know."

"And the other things. What we know."

"They won't —"

"Tell them anyway," Riley said. "What Casey knows about the markers and the conversion. All of it. Let them decide what to do with it." They paused. "It's not our mountain. We don't live here. We can leave."

Alex thought about the rangers. About the ranger at the bulletin board station — the old man, the canvas jacket, the walking stick worn smooth at the grip. *Don't answer the whistle*. Like passing on something he'd been told the same way.

He knew. He'd known for a long time.

"There are people who know this mountain," Alex said. "Who know what's in it. Who've been managing it somehow, or trying to." He paused. "The markers. The warnings at the junctions. Someone keeps maintaining those."

"Yes," Casey said, from behind them. She'd come up quietly, phone in hand.
"Someone does."

They looked at her.

"I found the historical society," she said. She held up her phone. A website, small text, loading slowly on the weak signal. "Calhoun County Historical Society. There's a section on the mine." She paused. "There's a contact name. A local historian. She's written about the area." Another pause. "She's written specifically about the Calhoun Mine disappearances."

Alex looked at the phone. At the name on the screen.

"We call her," Casey said. "Before we leave the county."

He looked at the mountain. At the tree line. At the trail disappearing into the trees.

"Yeah," he said. "We call her."

He wrote in the journal, quickly, in the parking lot, the pen moving fast:

Out. We're out. Seven people in a gravel parking lot and the van is real and the road is real.

David is not out. David answered and David is not out and I will be thinking about those three words at the trail junction — safe travels — for a long time.

Jordan almost went back. Taylor's boots were on before she was awake. Casey found a historian.

Whatever this is, it's old. It's been here long enough for markers and documented disappearances and a local historian who studies it specifically. Which means people have gotten out before. Which means there is information we don't have. Which means someone has been here before us and survived and written it down.

We find that person.

We find out what we're carrying out of this mountain.

All of us.

He closed the notebook.

The van key was in his pocket. The road was half a mile down the access lane. The ordinary world was receiving them back with no fanfare, no acknowledgment, the way the ordinary world always did.

He looked at his group.

At Taylor, still facing south.

At Jordan's hand on Sam's back.

At Marisol breathing against the map board.

At Riley watching him.

He walked to the van and unlocked it.

"Okay," he said. "Let's go."

Chapter Sixteen: Partial Conversion

The hospital in Gatlinburg was small and clean and aggressively normal.

Fluorescent lights. Linoleum floors. A television in the waiting area cycling through a home renovation show that nobody was watching. A nurse at the intake desk who asked questions in the practiced tone of someone who had asked the same questions ten thousand times and found comfort in the repetition.

Alex sat in the waiting area and felt the normalcy of it land on him in layers, like pressure equalizing. The chair was a chair. The lights were lights. The coffee from the machine down the hall was bad in a specific and familiar way that had nothing to do with mountains or dark or the sound of something patient moving through undergrowth.

He drank it anyway.

Marisol was in an examination room with Sam, who had appointed herself without discussion as the person who would stay with Marisol through whatever came next. The decision had been made in the van on the drive out — Sam simply getting out when Marisol got out and walking in beside her, and nobody questioning it, and Marisol not objecting, the presence accepted the way presence was accepted when you were in shock and someone competent decided to stay.

Jordan was in the parking lot.

He'd asked to wait outside. Alex had looked at him and Jordan had said *I'm not going anywhere, I just need air* and Alex had believed him enough to let him go, which was either the right call or a choice he'd be living with. Riley had gone to the parking lot too, which was maybe what had decided it — Riley out there with him, Riley's specific quality of company, the kind that didn't require anything of you.

Casey was at the far end of the waiting room with her phone and her notebook, the historian's website pulled up, writing things down in her small careful hand. She'd been trying the contact number since the parking lot. No answer yet. She tried again every fifteen minutes with the methodical patience of someone for whom waiting was just another kind of work.

Taylor sat beside Alex.

She'd been quiet since the parking lot — a different quiet than her usual, lower and more interior, like something that had been running at high volume for a long time had finally been turned down. She was looking at the television without watching it, the home renovation show cycling through before-and-after shots with urgent music underneath.

"How are you," Alex said.

She considered the question, which was her way. Not performative consideration — actual. "I don't know yet," she said. "I feel — reduced. Like something that was very loud is further away."

"The distance," he said. "Casey said distance was the factor."

"I can still hear it," Taylor said. "Faintly. Like — you know when you've been to a loud concert and afterward everything is quiet but your ears are still ringing? Like that." She paused. "It's still there. But it's not in charge anymore."

He looked at her. "The humming?"

"I'll tell you if it starts," she said. "You'll tell me if you hear it."

"Deal," he said.

She looked at the television. "I woke up in the van," she said. "On the drive here. I'd fallen asleep and when I woke up I was oriented north. Physically — I'd turned in the seat toward the north. My body did it while I was asleep." She paused. "We were driving south. I was oriented north."

He held this.

"But you woke up," he said. "You noticed."

"I noticed," she said. "I turned back." A pause. "I'm keeping the list."

Casey got through at two in the afternoon.

She came across the waiting room with her phone pressed to her ear and her notebook open, her pace urgent without being a run. She sat beside Alex and held the phone slightly away from her ear so he could hear.

The voice on the phone was a woman's voice. Older — not elderly, but carrying the specific weight of someone who had spent decades with a subject and knew it the way you knew a language you'd grown up in. Direct. Not surprised by the call.

Her name was Ruth Calhoun. The name sat in Alex's chest for a moment before he placed it — Calhoun Hollow, Calhoun Mine, the name on the map notation he'd been staring at for five days. A descendant, maybe. Or someone who'd taken the name of the place as her own. Either way, the connection was deliberate.

"You were in the north section," Ruth said. Not a question.

"Yes," Casey said into the phone. "Five nights. Party of six. We had two partial —" she paused, selecting words. "Two people who showed significant exposure. Involuntary vocalization, directional orientation, lost time, responded to mimicry."

A pause on the line. "They're with you now?"

"Yes."

"They walked out?"

"Yes."

Another pause, and in it Alex heard something that might have been relief. "How far south are you."

"Gatlinburg. Hospital."

"I'm forty minutes away," Ruth said. "Don't let the partial ones sleep until I get there."

Casey looked at Alex.

"Why," Alex said, toward the phone.

"Because sleep is when it consolidates," Ruth said. "When the distance is new, the first sleep is when the partial ones finish converting or finish clearing. You want them awake and talking and oriented until I can assess them."

Casey took the phone back to her ear. "We'll be here," she said. "Thank you."

She hung up.

They looked at each other.

"Go get Jordan," Alex said.

Jordan took the news about not sleeping with the equanimity of a man who had stopped being surprised by bad news and was now simply absorbing it as additional data. He was leaning against the van in the parking lot when Alex found him, Riley beside him, both of them looking at the mountains visible above the town, the ridgeline they'd come out of.

"Don't sleep," Alex said. "Not until we talk to someone."

Jordan looked at him. "How long."

"Forty minutes. Maybe less."

Jordan nodded. He looked back at the mountains. "I can see it," he said.

"What do you mean."

"The ridge. Where we were." He pointed — not to the general skyline but to a specific place on it, a specific fold in the terrain. "I know exactly where the mine is from here. I can see it in my head like — like I've been there. Like I know it." He paused. "I've never been there."

Riley was watching Jordan carefully.

"But you're here," Riley said. "You're in a parking lot in Gatlinburg looking at it from a distance."

Jordan looked at Riley. "Yeah," he said. "I'm here."

"That's the thing," Riley said. "That's the whole thing, right now. You're here."

Jordan held Riley's gaze for a moment. Then he looked back at the mountains.

"It's very clear," he said. "The image of it. Clear and — appealing. Like somewhere I want to go." He paused. "I'm telling you so you know what's in here. I'm not going. But I want you to know what's in here."

"I know," Alex said.

"Does it get better," Jordan said. "When the woman comes. Does it get better."

"I don't know," Alex said. "I think so."

"You think so," Jordan said.

"I don't know," Alex said again. More honestly.

Jordan absorbed this. Nodded once. "Okay," he said. "Forty minutes."

Ruth Calhoun arrived in thirty-five.

She drove a truck that had seen many mountain winters and didn't apologize for it, and she came into the hospital waiting area with the specific self-possession of someone who had been in difficult rooms many times and had stopped needing to prepare for them. She was in her sixties, compact, with the outdoor-weathered complexion of someone who spent more time outside than in. She wore a canvas jacket the color of dry leaves.

Alex stared at her.

He'd seen that jacket before. That specific shade, that specific cut, the pockets worn at the corners.

She looked at him and he saw in her face that she knew he recognized it.

"You were at the ranger station," he said.

"Yes," she said.

"You warned us."

"I told you what I knew," she said. "You were a group of six in good health going into a section I've been monitoring for twenty years. I told you what I could tell you." She paused. "If I'd told you everything you wouldn't have believed me. You needed to meet it to have the category for it."

He wanted to be angry about this. He looked at her and tried to locate the anger and found it, but found it smaller than the exhaustion and the relief and the particular feeling of standing in front of someone who knew.

"There's a man up there," he said. "David. He answered it. His wife is in an examination room."

"I know," she said.

"You know."

"I monitor the area," she said. "I have equipment on the ridge. When I got Casey's call I'd already been tracking movement from last night." She looked at him steadily. "I'm sorry about David. I'm sorry I didn't get to them."

"Can he be brought back," Alex said. "If someone went up there —"

"No," she said. It wasn't cruel. It was the voice of someone who had asked this question many times and had arrived at the answer the hard way. "Not at this stage. Not after a full night." She paused. "I'm sorry."

He held this.

Put it somewhere.

"Your partials," she said. "Show me."

She spent twenty minutes with Jordan and twenty minutes with Taylor. Not in private — she asked them each to sit with her in a corner of the waiting room, the others nearby, and she talked to them the way a doctor talked to a patient, focused and specific, asking questions Alex couldn't fully hear from across the room.

She had a small device — he couldn't have said what it was, something handheld, something she held close to each of them while they talked, watching a readout he couldn't see. She didn't explain it and he didn't ask.

When she finished with Taylor she sat across from Alex.

"The woman first," she said. "Taylor. She's partial but shallow. The distance cleared most of it. What remains is — she'll hear it. For months, maybe longer. Faintly, as a residue. It'll try to use her to reproduce attractor sounds in the early stages — the humming, the involuntary vocalization. She needs to know that when she hears herself doing it she is not doing it. She fights it the way she's been fighting it. With herself." She paused. "She told me about the list."

"Yeah," Alex said.

"That's the right method," Ruth said. "She found it herself. That speaks well for her recovery." She paused. "The deeper the person, the more themselves they are, the harder it is to convert. Taylor Kim is extremely herself." She said it as a clinical observation and Alex felt something in it anyway.

"And Jordan," he said.

Ruth looked at her hands. A brief pause, the kind that preceded specificity.

"Jordan is deeper," she said. "He responded verbally, and repeatedly — the second voice episode, the night he went a mile into the dark. More exposure, more contact, more consolidation." She paused. "He can feel the mine from here. Directional awareness of the source is a stage four indicator."

"What does that mean," Sam said. She'd come back from Marisol's room and was standing at the edge of the group, still in her jacket, her arms crossed. Holding herself together with posture.

Ruth looked at her. "It means he's further along than Taylor," she said. "Not fully converted — if he were fully converted he wouldn't be sitting here telling you about it. He'd have gone back on the trail." She paused. "But the process is more established in him. The consolidation I mentioned — the first sleep being a deciding point. For Jordan that's — significant."

"You said don't let them sleep," Alex said. "The first sleep either finishes conversion or finishes clearing. Which way does Jordan go."

Ruth was quiet for a moment.

"I don't know," she said. "I've seen partials at Jordan's level clear. I've seen them not clear." She looked at Sam. "The person matters. The depth of them. Who they are." She paused. "And the people around them matter. What they're held by. What calls them back."

Sam looked at Jordan across the waiting room. He was sitting with Riley, awake, talking, his face doing the things Jordan's face did. The specific ordinary inventory of him.

She looked at Ruth.

"Tell me what to do," she said.

Ruth told them.

She talked for an hour — Casey's notebook filling page after page with the precise small handwriting. The stages, the history, the mine, the thing in it. She confirmed what Casey had already assembled and added what Casey hadn't known — the documented cases, the methods, the people who'd cleared and the people who hadn't and the variables that seemed to distinguish them.

She told them about the first miner. About what he'd brought back from the mine, or what had come back in him. About the way the community had tried to manage it and the things they'd built and the markers they'd maintained and the long slow history of a thing that didn't die and didn't leave and didn't stop.

She told them what lived in Calhoun Mountain and what it wanted and how it grew.

She told them the word. The word the old community had used, the word that had been passed down through the families who stayed in the hollow and kept the markers and tried to hold the line.

Caller.

She said it and Alex felt it land in his chest with the weight of something already known — the word he'd arrived at in Chapter Nine, sitting by the fire while Taylor

hummed in her sleep. He'd found the right word before he had the right information.

"The Callers draw others," Ruth said. "That's their function. That's what they become. They use the voices they knew to call the people those voices would reach." She paused. "The thing in the mountain doesn't want territory. It doesn't want resources. It wants — population. It recruits. Every person who answers and follows and converts becomes a Caller, and every Caller can reach the people who love them, and the circle expands." She paused. "That's why the rule is absolute. Don't answer. Don't follow voices. Because every answer is the beginning of another Caller, and every Caller reaches people, and the thing in the mountain gets wider."

Silence in the waiting room.

The home renovation show had cycled to a commercial.

"Can it be stopped," Casey asked.

Ruth looked at her. "Contained," she said. "I've spent twenty years containing it. The markers, the monitoring, the interventions when groups come through." She paused. "Stopped. I don't know." She paused again. "I think stopped would require going to the source."

"The mine," Alex said.

"Yes."

He looked at her. "Have you been."

She held his gaze. "Once," she said. "Thirty years ago. Before I understood what I was doing." A pause. "I came back. Not everyone I went with did."

The waiting room held the silence.

Then Jordan said, from across the room: "What happens when I sleep."

Everyone looked at him.

He'd been listening. Of course he'd been listening. He was sitting with his coffee going cold and his eyes on Ruth and he'd been listening to everything.

"Tell me what happens when I sleep," he said. "I want to know."

Ruth looked at him for a long moment.

"One of two things," she said. "You sleep and the distance and your own depth and the people who hold you bring you clear. The connection weakens. The directional awareness fades. Over weeks, maybe months, the residue goes quiet." She paused. "Or the sleep consolidates what's there, and when you wake up the pull is complete, and the distance doesn't matter anymore, and you leave."

Jordan nodded slowly.

"Okay," he said.

"You understand what I'm telling you," Ruth said.

"Yes," he said. "I understand." He looked at Sam. At Alex. At Riley and Casey and Taylor. At each of them in turn, the specific prolonged attention of someone taking an inventory of their own.

"I'm not leaving," he said.

"You may not have a choice," Ruth said. "When you sleep —"

"I'm not leaving," he said again. Quiet. Absolute. The voice of a man who had been saying *I decided to stay* for six days and was saying it again now for what might be the last time he was capable of saying it. "I know what's in me. I know what it wants. I am telling you what I want." He paused. "Can you help me or not."

Ruth looked at him for a long moment.

"Yes," she said. "I think I can help you."

"Then help me," he said.

Alex wrote in the journal in the hospital parking lot at 9pm, while inside Ruth worked with Jordan through a process she'd described in terms he'd tried to

follow and mostly hadn't — something about sound, about counter-frequencies, about the specific use of the person's own voice to interrupt the consolidation pattern. Casey had understood it better and was in there watching and taking notes.

He wrote:

Ruth Calhoun. Has been watching the mountain for twenty years. Was the ranger. Knew what we were walking into and gave us what she could give us.

Taylor: shallow partial. Will clear. Months of residue but she'll clear. She is, Ruth said, extremely herself. I could have told her that.

Jordan: deep partial. Stage four. The sleep is the deciding point. Ruth is working with him.

David is a Caller now. I write it and I can't make it feel real. He stopped for two minutes on a trail and said hello and now he's a Caller in Calhoun Mountain and his wife is in a hospital in Gatlinburg.

Three words at the junction. Safe travels.

I'll be carrying those three words for a long time.

He stopped writing.

Looked at the mountains, dark against the darker sky, the ridge they'd come out of invisible now in the night.

One more thing, he wrote. Ruth asked me, before she started with Jordan, if I felt any residual pull. Any directional awareness. Involuntary vocalization. I told her no.

I told her no because I wanted to believe it.

The truth: this morning in the van, half asleep, I heard four notes in my head. Rising, rising, falling, hold. Clear as if someone were playing them.

I didn't hum them. I held them and I didn't hum them and I didn't write it until now.

I'm writing it now because not writing it is how you miss things.

I don't know what that means.

I don't know if it means anything.

I need to find out.

He closed the notebook.

Riley came out of the hospital and sat beside him on the parking lot curb without asking.

"Jordan's still in there," Riley said.

"How does he seem."

"Like Jordan," Riley said. "More like Jordan than he has in days, actually." A pause. "Ruth knows what she's doing."

"Yeah," Alex said. "She does."

They sat in the parking lot and looked at the mountains.

"Alex," Riley said.

"Yeah."

"The four notes," Riley said. "In your head. This morning."

He looked at them.

"I heard them too," Riley said. "I didn't say anything because I didn't know what to say." A pause. "But I heard them."

They sat with that.

"We need to tell Ruth," Alex said.

"I know," Riley said.

Neither of them moved for a moment.

The mountains were dark and very old and somewhere in them the thing that had been listening for six days was listening still.

"Tomorrow," Riley said. "We tell her tomorrow."

"Tomorrow," Alex said.

He held Riley's hand in the parking lot and looked at the mountains and thought about David and thought about Jordan and thought about the four notes rising in the dark like something that had always been there, waiting for him to notice it.

He counted.

Seven people. Ruth inside.

Seven.

He held the number.

For now, seven.

Chapter Seventeen: The Mine

Ruth Calhoun's house was forty minutes from Gatlinburg on a road that stopped being a road about halfway through and became a suggestion. Gravel, then packed dirt, then two tire tracks through grass with a center ridge that scraped the van's undercarriage twice. The trees came in close on both sides and the elevation climbed and by the time the house appeared through the tree line Alex had the specific feeling of having traveled further than the distance accounted for.

The house was old. Not decrepit — maintained, carefully, the kind of maintenance that was about function rather than appearance. Stone foundation, board and batten siding gone silver with age, a covered porch running the full front length. A satellite dish on the roof that looked recently installed and slightly incongruous, a concession to the modern world made without enthusiasm.

Beside it, a smaller structure — a workshop or outbuilding, its windows lit even at 10pm, cables running from it to a dish array on its roof that was more sophisticated than anything the house wore.

Ruth's monitoring station.

She'd brought Jordan out first. He'd slept in the hospital under her supervision — an hour, carefully managed, with whatever counter-frequency work she'd done preceding it. He'd woken up as Jordan. Not the approximation-Jordan of the past three days. Jordan. The inventory complete, the stored-material quality gone, the unsteadiness of someone running on partial signal replaced by the specific presence of a person fully occupying themselves.

He'd cried, briefly, in the hospital parking lot. Sam had held him and he'd let himself be held and then he'd pulled back and wiped his face with the back of his hand and said *okay* in a voice that meant it.

Alex had watched this and felt something release in his chest that he hadn't known was held.

But Jordan had looked at him afterward, with the clear specific eyes of the fully-returned Jordan, and said quietly: *it's still there. Faint. But still there.* And Ruth had said: *it will be. For a while. That's normal.* And the word *normal* had done something strange and necessary in the air.

Now they were all at Ruth's house. All seven — eight with Ruth. The hospital had wanted to keep Marisol overnight but she'd declined with the quiet finality of

a woman who had made a decision and didn't require input on it. She'd come with them, sitting in the back of the van beside Sam, not talking, watching the mountains through the window with an expression Alex had stopped trying to read.

Ruth made coffee and they sat around a table large enough for eight, the kitchen lit by two hanging lights that cast a warm yellow circle over the group. The house smelled of woodsmoke and old paper and something herbal Alex couldn't identify. Maps covered one wall of the kitchen — topographic, overlaid with handwritten annotations in multiple colors, dates going back decades. He looked at it while the coffee brewed and tried to read it and couldn't — the notation system was Ruth's own, a private language built up over twenty years of watching.

Casey was already asking about the maps. Ruth answered in the shorthand of someone accustomed to explaining their methodology, the two of them moving quickly through a vocabulary of terms that left the others slightly behind.

Jordan sat with his coffee and looked at the table. Sam's hand was on his. Marisol sat at the far end with her own coffee, present, not absent — processing, Alex thought. The specific processing of someone deciding what to do with an impossible thing.

Taylor was looking at the maps.

Alex noticed this. Taylor standing at the kitchen wall, studying Ruth's annotation system, her head slightly tilted. Not the northwest orientation — the direction of genuine intellectual attention. The Casey-facing-a-problem look. He filed it.

Riley sat beside him.

"How are you," he said quietly.

"I keep hearing the four notes," Riley said. "On and off. Faint, like something playing in another room." They looked at their coffee. "You?"

"Same," he said.

"We need to tell Ruth."

"I know."

He'd been building to it since the parking lot. The specific difficulty of saying out loud *I may be partial* when you were the person everyone else was counting on to be clean — the difficulty of it was real and he'd been sitting with it and he needed to stop sitting with it.

"Ruth," he said.

She looked at him from across the table.

"Riley and I both heard the four notes today. The guitar attractor pattern. Involuntarily. More than once." He kept his voice level. "What does that mean."

The table went quiet.

Ruth looked at him. Then at Riley. Her assessment was quick and specific, the look of someone who had developed diagnostic instincts over decades.

"Did either of you answer the whistle or a voice at any point," she said.

"No," Riley said.

"No," Alex said. Then he paused. "I was counting it. Tracking it. Every instance since night one. Sustained attention directed at it consistently for six days."

Ruth was quiet for a moment.

"Sustained attention," she said. "At close range. Consistent and deliberate." She paused. "That's not the same as answering. But it's not nothing. You built a detailed model of it in your mind, which means you were in some sense — intimate with it. Regularly, intentionally." She paused. "The four notes you're hearing — is it intrusive? Distressing? Does it carry a pull?"

Alex thought about it honestly. "It's ambient," he said. "Like a song stuck in my head. No pull. No directional quality."

"Same," Riley said.

Ruth nodded slowly. "Monitoring exposure," she said. "You were listening so hard and so long that some of it got in. Below the threshold of response but

above the threshold of clean." She paused. "Not the same as what Jordan had. Not what Taylor had. But a residue." She looked at him. "You should have told me sooner."

"I know," he said.

"Can you fix it," Sam asked.

"It'll resolve," Ruth said. "With distance and time. Same as Taylor's." She looked at Alex. "You're not in danger of conversion. You're in danger of carrying the sound with you when you leave." She paused. "Which has its own implications."

"What implications," Riley said.

Ruth looked at her hands around her coffee cup. Deciding something. "The attractor pattern," she said. "The four notes. If you're reproducing it — even involuntarily, even in fragments — in your home environment, in your city, it functions as a low-level draw. It doesn't convert anyone at that distance from the source. But it —" she paused. "It keeps the channel open. Between you and the source."

The kitchen was very quiet.

"The channel," Casey said.

"The connection the exposure created," Ruth said. "Distance weakens it. Time weakens it. But if the attractor keeps sounding — if you keep broadcasting it without knowing — the connection doesn't fully close."

"So we keep hearing it," Alex said. "And as long as we keep hearing it, it can still reach us."

"That's the risk," Ruth said.

"How do we close it," Riley said.

Ruth looked at them. Another deciding pause.

"The counter-frequency work I did with Jordan," she said. "It interrupts the consolidation. For Jordan it was necessary because he was deep enough that without intervention the sleep would have finished the conversion." She paused.

"For you and Alex — it would close the channel cleanly. The residue gone. The connection severed."

"Do it," Riley said immediately.

Ruth looked at them. "It requires going back up the mountain," she said. "Not to the mine. Not into the deep terrain. But within range of the source, close enough for the counter-frequency to work against the connection rather than just the residue." She paused. "I've done it before with partials. It's safe if it's done correctly. But I need you to understand what I'm asking."

"You're asking us to go back," Alex said.

"I'm asking you to come with me," she said. "There's a difference."

She showed them the monitoring station after coffee.

It was a single large room, the walls lined with equipment Alex didn't have vocabulary for — screens showing readouts, a sound system of some kind, recording equipment, a long desk covered in notebooks and printed maps and annotated transcripts. The equipment was a mix of old and new, things she'd built herself and things she'd acquired, the whole operation carrying the specific aesthetic of someone who had been doing something for a long time without external funding or validation.

On one wall, photographs. Dozens of them. Mountain terrain, trail junctions, mine entrances, the ridge seen from various angles in various seasons. And among them, smaller, tucked between the landscape shots: people. Groups of hikers, mostly, photographed at trailheads or along the trail. Some with dates written in the margins in Ruth's handwriting.

Alex looked at these.

Some had a small symbol beside the date. A check mark.

Others had a different symbol. Two parallel lines with a third cutting through at an angle.

The ridge symbol.

He understood what the two categories meant. He looked away.

"Twenty years," Casey said, beside Ruth, looking at the equipment.

"Twenty-three," Ruth said. "I started the year after my first trip in." She looked at the wall of photographs. "I wasn't the first. There are records going back to 1923 — the year the mine closed. Not equipment, obviously. Journals, letters, community records. The families who stayed in the hollow after the mine closed and kept the markers maintained." She paused. "I'm the current version of something that's been happening for a hundred years."

"The first miner," Casey said. "The one who answered."

"His name was Thomas Calhoun," Ruth said. "My great-great-uncle." She said it with no particular emphasis. A fact, long ago integrated. "He was the first to answer. The rest of the crew followed over three weeks. Seven men." She paused. "Two got out. One of them is the reason there are records at all."

"He documented it," Casey said.

"He documented everything he could remember," Ruth said. "The stages. The sounds. The rules. The warning markers. He spent the rest of his life maintaining the hollow, keeping the records, warning people when he could." She paused. "He lived to eighty-four. He never fully lost the sound. He heard it every day of his life until he died." She said it quietly, without drama. "That's the long version of what Taylor and Alex and Riley are carrying. He learned to live alongside it. He learned to keep it from opening back up." She looked at Alex. "So can you."

Alex looked at the photograph wall. At the groups of hikers. At the check marks and the ridge symbols.

"How many," he said. "Total. Since you started."

Ruth was quiet for a moment. "Forty-one groups," she said. "Through this section of the park, in the area of exposure." She paused. "Twenty-six got out clean. Eight had partials who cleared." Another pause. "Seven did not."

The number sat in the room.

"David is in the seven," Alex said.

"Yes," Ruth said.

"How many Callers are there," he said. "In the mountain. Right now."

Ruth looked at him steadily. "More than when I started," she said. "The mountain doesn't lose what it gains. The Callers don't die — not in the way we die. They remain." She paused. "Twenty-three years of records and one hundred years of prior documentation and the number has been increasing." She said it the way she said most things — directly, without softening. "That's the truth of it."

"So it's winning," Sam said.

Ruth looked at her. "Slowly," she said. "Very slowly. The containment has held the rate." She paused. "But yes. Slowly. It's winning."

They slept in Ruth's house that night. She had four bedrooms and a couch and a sleeping bag she produced from a closet and nobody argued about arrangements. Alex took the couch. Riley took the floor beside the couch, which was Riley's decision and not something Alex argued with.

He lay in the dark and listened to the house settle around him and thought about Thomas Calhoun. A man who had watched six colleagues convert and had spent the next sixty-odd years maintaining the documentation of the thing that had done it. Hearing it every day. Learning to keep the channel closed.

He would hear it too. For a long time, possibly.

Rising, rising, falling, hold.

He lay still and let the thought sit and tried to locate, honestly, what he felt about it.

What he felt was: tired. Specifically and profoundly tired. The tired of six days in the mountain and two nights of bad sleep and the accumulated weight of counting and watching and keeping everyone pointed in the right direction.

But underneath the tired — something else. Something he'd been not-looking-at for two days. Since the hospital parking lot, since Ruth's words about going back up the mountain.

He'd been not-looking-at the mine.

Not the way Taylor had looked at the mine — the northwest orientation, the dreamed homecoming, the boots on before waking. Not conversion. Something else. The look he'd given it on the topo map in February when he'd been planning the trip, the curious turn of attention toward a marked point.

Calhoun Mine (disused, est. 1887–1923).

The thing in the mountain recruited. Ruth said stopping it would require going to the source.

Ruth had tried once. She'd come back. Not everyone she'd gone with had.

Alex lay on the couch in the dark and thought about this and tried to decide if what he was feeling was the residual draw of monitoring exposure working on him through a not-quite-closed channel, or whether it was something else.

He couldn't tell.

This was the problem. This had been the problem for days. The inability to clearly distinguish between the thing's influence and his own thoughts. Taylor with her list. Jordan saying *I'm not leaving* while something in him felt the pull of leaving. The channel and the person sharing the same interior space and the channel learning to sound like the person.

He got out the journal.

Wrote by phone light, trying not to wake Riley:

Ruth's house. Ruth Calhoun. Great-great-niece of Thomas Calhoun who was the first to answer.

Twenty-three years of monitoring. Seven groups lost. Twenty-six clean. Eight partials cleared.

The mine: Thomas Calhoun opened it in 1887. Something in the mountain was exposed. Thomas answered. The crew followed. Two got out. One documented everything and spent his life containing it.

Ruth said stopping it requires going to the source. She went once. Not everyone she went with came back.

I keep thinking about the mine. Not the pull — I don't think it's the pull. I think it's the thing underneath the pull, the thing that was there before the exposure. The part of me that planned this trip down to the trailhead and researched elevation changes and wanted to know the mountain.

The researcher part. The person who keeps the journal.

Thomas Calhoun documented everything he could remember. Spent eighty-four years maintaining the records.

I have six days of records.

I don't know what I'm saying. I'm writing it down and I don't know what I'm saying.

He stopped.

Looked at the page.

Added:

Tomorrow Ruth takes me and Riley up the mountain for the counter-frequency work. Close enough to the source to close the channel.

I'm going to ask her about the mine.

Not about going there. Just about the mine. What it looks like. What's in it.

Just asking.

He closed the notebook.

From the floor beside the couch, Riley said: "You're not sleeping."

"No."

"Me neither." A pause. "What are you writing."

"Thoughts," he said.

"About the mine," Riley said.

He looked at the ceiling.

"Yeah," he said.

Riley was quiet for a moment. "Me too," they said. "I keep thinking — not the pull. Something else. Like — we have six days of documentation and Ruth has twenty-three years and Thomas Calhoun had sixty and none of it has been enough."

"No," he said.

"Something more would have to be done," Riley said. "Not just containing. Actually going in." Another pause. "I know how that sounds."

"It sounds like what I was thinking," he said.

Silence.

"Tomorrow," Riley said. "Let's see what Ruth says."

"Yeah," he said.

He lay in the dark and listened to the house and thought about Thomas Calhoun and the journal he'd kept for sixty years. The records. The attempt.

The mine, somewhere in the dark above them, patient and old and not going anywhere.

Rising, rising, falling, hold.

He held the sound in his mind and did not hum it and did not follow it and lay still until the grey pre-dawn light began at the windows.

He did not sleep.

Chapter Eighteen: The Story

Ruth made breakfast at six.

Not a performative breakfast — not the kind that announced itself as comfort or distraction. Just food, made efficiently, the kitchen filling with the smell of coffee and eggs and toast while outside the windows the mountains went from black to grey to the particular blue of early morning at elevation. She moved around the kitchen with the economy of someone who had been doing things alone for a long time and had optimized all the small domestic motions down to their essential components.

Alex sat at the table and watched her and drank his coffee and thought about how to ask the thing he wanted to ask.

The others came down in pieces. Jordan first, which was new — Jordan had never been a early riser, but he came downstairs with his hair unflattened and his eyes clear and sat beside Alex with his coffee and said nothing for a while, which was the right thing. Sam came next, then Casey, then Taylor, then Marisol, who moved through the kitchen with the careful navigation of someone in an unfamiliar space, taking up as little room as possible.

Riley came down last and sat across from Alex and looked at him with the specific look that meant *did you sleep* and he shook his head fractionally and they nodded and said nothing about it.

Ruth put eggs on the table.

They ate.

After breakfast, while the others moved through the slow business of the morning — showers available for the first time in six days, a development Sam greeted with an enthusiasm that briefly cut through everything else — Ruth poured two more coffees and set one in front of Alex and sat down.

"You want to know about the mine," she said.

"Yes," he said.

She looked at him. The assessment, the diagnostic habit. "Not the pull," she said. "You're not running on pull."

"I don't think so," he said. "But I can't fully trust my own read on that. Which is why I'm asking you."

She seemed to find this acceptable. She wrapped both hands around her mug.

"What do you want to know," she said.

"Everything," he said. "Thomas Calhoun's account. What's in there. What the source actually is. What going to it would mean." He paused. "Ruth said stopping it would require going to the source. I want to know what that actually means. Not the general shape of it. The specifics."

Ruth looked at him for a long moment.

"Why," she said.

"Because I've been keeping a record for six days and you've been keeping one for twenty-three years and Thomas Calhoun kept one for sixty and none of the records have been enough," he said. "Because seven groups didn't make it. Because David is up there. Because the number of Callers increases every year and the containment holds the rate but doesn't reverse it." He paused. "Because someone has to go further than the containment."

Ruth held his gaze.

"Riley thinks the same thing," Alex said. "We talked last night."

Ruth looked at the table. At her coffee. At something beyond both of them.

"I know," she said. "I could hear it in both of you last night. The shape of where your thinking was going." She paused. "I've been waiting for someone to arrive at it." Another pause, longer. "I've been waiting for someone who wasn't me."

He said nothing.

"I can't go back in," she said. "I went once, thirty years ago, and what I brought back with me — what I carry — means I can't go back. The connection in me is the oldest in any living person. If I go within range of the source it will finish what it started thirty years ago." She said it plainly, without self-pity. A fact, long

managed. "I've known for twenty years that whatever is done about the mine, I'm not the one who does it."

"What happened thirty years ago," he said.

She was quiet for a moment. "I went in with two other people," she said. "Researchers. A colleague of mine and a man from the community, one of the families who'd maintained the hollow for generations. We went to understand the source. To document it." She paused. "My colleague didn't come back. The community man came back but he converted fully within a week. He's still up there." She stopped. "I came back because I turned around early. I didn't go all the way in. I was afraid." She said the last sentence without shame or apology. Just truth. "I've spent thirty years wondering if that was the right choice."

"Was it," Alex said.

"I don't know," she said. "I'm alive. I've maintained the containment. I've gotten twenty-six groups out clean." She paused. "But the number of Callers is higher than when I went in. And it will be higher next year. And the year after." She looked at him. "So I don't know."

He held this.

"Tell me Thomas Calhoun's account," he said.

She told him.

She spoke for an hour. Casey appeared at some point — drawn by the length of the conversation, or by instinct, the same instinct that had been running in her since day one — and sat quietly at the end of the table with her notebook and her pen, and Ruth acknowledged her with a glance and kept talking.

Thomas Calhoun had opened the mine in 1887. A seam of coal, promising enough to warrant a crew of seven men including himself. The mine went into the mountain at a gentle angle, following the seam, and in the third week of operation they'd broken through into a natural cavity — a chamber in the rock, not made by human hands, that the seam had skirted around rather than passing through.

The chamber was large. Thomas had described it in his account as the size of a church, though he'd been a man who attended a small church in a small community so the scale was relative. The walls were stone, natural limestone, and they were covered in a material he couldn't identify — a substance that grew on the stone the way lichen grew on stone but was not lichen, was something else, something that caught the light of his lamp in a way that lichen did not.

The substance moved.

Not dramatically — not visibly in the moment of looking. But between looks, between the moment he looked away and the moment he looked back, it had shifted. Redistributed. The pattern of it on the walls was different each time he looked.

He had described this in his account as the first wrong thing.

The second wrong thing was the sound.

It came from the walls. From the substance on the walls, or from the stone behind it, or from somewhere deeper than either. A sound he'd written about at length and never managed to describe precisely — his account returned to it again and again over the sixty years of writing, each attempt a different approach to the same indescribable thing. The closest he'd come, in a journal entry from 1941, was this: *it is the sound of a voice before it becomes words. The raw material of voice, the vibration and resonance of it, but with no meaning yet attached. And hearing it, every time, the overwhelming sense that meaning is about to arrive. That the next moment will resolve it into language. And the next. And the next. Always about to mean something and never meaning it.*

Thomas had stood in the chamber for eleven minutes by his watch. His crew had stood with him.

One of them, a young man named Breckett, had said: *do you hear that*.

Thomas had said: *yes*.

That was the answer. That was the first answer. Thomas Calhoun, standing in a limestone chamber in his own mine, saying *yes* to a colleague's question.

The sound had changed the moment he spoke.

Not louder. Not directed. But different — the quality of it shifting, the sense of about-to-mean-something resolving, briefly, into something that felt, for just a moment, like being understood.

Like being known.

Thomas had written, in 1887: *I cannot describe it except to say that for that one moment I did not feel alone in the way I had been alone every day of my life up until then. And I knew immediately that this was the most dangerous thing I had ever felt.*

He'd gotten out. He and one other man. The remaining five had stayed in the chamber — not by force, not physically prevented from leaving. They had simply chosen not to go. Had looked at Thomas when he'd said *we have to leave* and had looked at him with the specific expression he would spend the next sixty years trying to describe. Not blank, not absent. Interested. Already elsewhere.

They had walked out eventually. All five of them. They had walked out and gone to their homes and their families and over the following three weeks they had changed. The families had noticed. The community had noticed. And then they had gone back into the mountain one by one and had not come back.

Thomas had spent the next year documenting it. The following year he'd placed the first markers. The year after that the mine had closed — officially for economic reasons, the seam having played out, which was true enough that no one had looked further. Thomas had filed the paperwork himself and sealed the entrance as best he could with the tools available to him and written in his account: *I have closed the door. I know the door is not enough. But I have closed it.*

Ruth paused.

Alex realized he'd been holding his breath.

He let it out.

Casey's pen had stopped moving. She was looking at Ruth.

"The substance on the walls," Casey said. "What is it."

"Thomas called it *the growth*," Ruth said. "His best theory — and it was a theory, he was a coal miner not a biologist — was that it was the source. Not a

symptom. The thing itself, or the physical expression of it. Something alive in the rock, something that predated human arrival in the mountains by a very long time, that had been growing in that chamber in the dark for — he didn't know how long. He wrote *centuries* but I think he wrote that because he didn't want to write what he actually suspected."

"Which was," Riley said.

Alex turned. Riley was in the kitchen doorway. Had been there for some time, he thought, listening.

Ruth looked at Riley. "That it had been there since the mountain was made," she said. "That it was as old as the stone."

Silence in the kitchen.

"And the sound it makes," Alex said. "The counter-frequency work you did with Jordan. The thing that interrupted the consolidation." He paused. "You're using its own mechanism against it."

Ruth looked at him. "Yes," she said. "The growth produces the sound. The sound is the recruitment mechanism. But the growth is also vulnerable to sound — specific frequencies, specific patterns. Thomas documented this. His account describes instances where certain sounds — naturally occurring, a particular resonance in the rock, a specific weather condition that produced certain wind tones — caused the growth to contract. To go quiet." She paused. "He never had the tools to replicate it deliberately. I've spent twenty-three years developing the tools."

"The counter-frequency device," Casey said.

"Yes."

"You can make it contract," Alex said. "With sound."

"In theory," Ruth said carefully. "At close range. Targeted application. I've used it at the cave entrance twice, at significant personal risk, and documented contraction each time." She paused. "The effect didn't hold. The growth recovered. But it contracted."

Alex looked at Riley across the kitchen. Riley looked back.

"If the application were sustained," Alex said. "At the source. In the chamber."

Ruth looked at her coffee.

"Thomas's account describes the growth covering every wall of the chamber," she said. "Floor to ceiling. A complete surface area he estimated at several thousand square feet." She paused. "The device I have treats approximately twelve square feet at effective range." Another pause. "The math is not encouraging."

"But you've been improving it," Casey said. "Twenty-three years. The equipment in the monitoring station."

"I've been improving it," Ruth said. "Yes." She looked at Casey. "I've been improving it for twenty-three years because I've known that the containment was not a permanent solution and that someone, eventually, would have to go further." She paused. "I've been building toward something I couldn't do myself."

The kitchen held this.

"How long would it take," Alex said. "To prepare. To get the equipment ready for a full application attempt."

Ruth looked at him.

"I've been ready for three years," she said. "I've been waiting for the right people."

Jordan said no.

He said it clearly, without anger, with the directness of someone who had earned the right to be direct. He'd come into the kitchen partway through and had listened from the doorway, and when Ruth finished he said: *no. Not Alex. Not Riley. Absolutely not.*

"Jordan —" Alex started.

"You've been in it for six days," Jordan said. "You have residual exposure. The four notes. You said yourself you can't fully trust your own read on whether the pull is in this." He was looking at Alex with the level eyes of a man fully himself,

the Jordan who had been only partially present for three days now entirely back and applying twelve years of knowing Alex to what he was hearing. "I trust you. I trust your judgment on almost everything. But you standing in a room with the source of the thing while carrying a partial exposure is not — I can't —" he stopped. "No."

"The counter-frequency work closes the channel," Riley said. "Ruth said —"

"Ruth said it closes the channel if done at range," Jordan said. "Ruth said going to the source is a different calculation entirely." He looked at Ruth. "Tell them. Tell them the risk."

Ruth looked at the table. "The risk," she said carefully, "is that at close range to the source, the residual exposure becomes a liability. The connection that hasn't fully closed becomes a door. The source will use it." She paused. "I would do the counter-frequency work first. Clear the channel cleanly before any approach to the mine." Another pause. "But I can't guarantee that clears it completely. I can't guarantee that standing in the chamber with a partially-cleared channel doesn't finish what the exposure started."

Silence.

"Then it's not Alex and Riley," Jordan said. "It's someone who's clean."

"The closer the source, the stronger the pull," Ruth said. "Someone fully clean walking into the chamber without any prior exposure —" she paused. "The pull is overwhelming at close range. That's what happened to my colleagues thirty years ago. No prior exposure, no partial connection, just clean people who walked into range of the full unmediated signal."

"And answered it," Sam said quietly.

"Some of them answered it," Ruth said. "Yes."

Jordan looked at Alex. Something working in his face — the arithmetic of risk, the inventory of who was expendable and who wasn't, the calculation Alex had watched him refuse to make for six days.

"Then nobody goes," Jordan said.

"Jordan," Alex said.

"Nobody goes," he said. "We close it from outside. We seal the entrance better than Thomas Calhoun sealed it. We go to the park service, the government, we get the area restricted, fenced, closed to hikers. We do the containment better." He paused. "Nobody else goes in that mountain."

"The containment doesn't reverse it," Casey said. Gently. "Ruth said. The number of Callers increases every year."

"Then it increases slower," Jordan said. "With better containment."

"David is up there," Sam said.

Jordan looked at her. Something in his face moved — the David-question, the weight he'd been carrying since the access trail.

"I know," he said quietly.

"Other Davids will be up there," Sam said. "Next year. The year after. As long as the mountain is accessible, as long as the thing in it is active."

Jordan was quiet.

"I know," he said again. Smaller.

Sam looked at him for a long moment. Then she looked at Alex.

"What do you need," she said.

They talked for three hours.

All of them — Ruth laying out the equipment, the approach, the risk calculations she'd been refining for twenty years. Casey asking the questions that needed asking and writing the answers with the focused precision of someone building a document they expected to be read later. Jordan arguing and being heard and arguing again and being heard again and gradually, grudgingly, being brought around not to enthusiasm but to the specific acceptance of someone who had stopped saying *no* and started saying *how do we make it less likely to go wrong*.

Marisol sat at the end of the table and said nothing for two hours.

Then she said: "David would have gone."

Everyone looked at her.

"If the positions were reversed," she said. "If it were me up there and he were sitting here. He would have gone." She paused. "He stopped for strangers. He answered voices in the dark because he thought someone needed help." She looked at her hands. "He was the most — he was constitutionally incapable of not trying." She looked at Alex. "He would have wanted someone to try."

She looked back at her hands.

Nobody said anything.

"I'm not saying go," she said. "I'm not — I don't have the right to tell anyone to go into that mountain. I'm just saying what David would have done." She paused. "I'm just saying what kind of person he was."

The kitchen was very quiet.

Alex looked at Ruth.

"The counter-frequency work," he said. "To close the channel. How long."

"Tonight," Ruth said. "If you want to move quickly."

"And after that."

"After that," Ruth said. "Tomorrow or the day after. When you're ready." She looked at him. "If you decide you're going."

He looked at Riley. Riley looked back.

"We decide together," Riley said. "All of us."

Alex looked around the table. At Jordan, jaw set, accepting. At Sam, steady, waiting. At Casey with her notebook. At Taylor watching him with the flat precise gaze that had been reading him correctly for a week. At Marisol, quiet, spent, true.

At Riley.

"Tomorrow," he said. "We decide tomorrow."

That night Ruth took Alex and Riley to the monitoring station.

The counter-frequency work took ninety minutes. Alex couldn't have explained the mechanism — Ruth's explanation had been precise and largely opaque to him, though Casey had followed it closely from her chair in the corner. Something about the specific resonant frequency of the growth, identified over twenty years of recording and analysis, and the generation of a counter-tone that disrupted the connection the exposure had created.

What it felt like, from the inside, was this:

For ninety minutes Alex sat in a chair in the monitoring station and listened to a sound he couldn't quite hear — below the threshold of hearing, felt in the chest and the back of the throat rather than the ears — while Ruth worked the equipment and watched the readouts and occasionally asked him to describe what he was experiencing.

What he was experiencing was the four notes.

Rising, rising, falling, hold.

Loud at first — louder than they'd ever been, as if the counter-frequency had illuminated them by opposing them, the way a light held against fabric showed its weave. Then gradually, over the ninety minutes, quieter. Fainter. The other-room quality they'd had all day becoming a further-room quality and then a barely-there quality and then something he had to actively search for rather than passively receive.

At the end Ruth looked at her readout and said: "Clean."

He sat in the chair and looked at his hands.

The four notes were gone.

The silence where they'd been was the most specific silence he'd ever experienced — shaped, particular, the silence of an absence rather than a neutral quiet. He sat in it and waited to feel different.

What he felt was: lighter. And underneath the lighter, something else.

The mountain, cleaner and clearer than it had been all week.

Not the pull. Not the draw of partial connection. Something else. Something he was going to have to sit with and look at honestly before tomorrow.

Riley came out of their session twenty minutes later. They sat beside Alex and didn't say anything for a moment.

"Clean?" Alex said.

"Clean," Riley said.

They sat in the monitoring station, the equipment humming around them, Ruth making notes at her desk.

"How do you feel," Alex said.

Riley thought about it. "Clear," they said. "And —" they paused. "And still interested in the mine."

"Yeah," Alex said.

"That's us," Riley said. "Not the exposure."

"Yeah," he said. "That's us."

They sat with that for a moment.

"I'm going," Riley said. Not a question.

He looked at them. At Riley Voss, fully present, fully themselves, clean and clear and looking at him with the specific quality of attention that had always worked on him below the level of his defenses.

"I know," he said.

"You're going too," Riley said.

"Yeah," he said. "I'm going too."

He wrote in the journal later, in the monitoring station, while Ruth worked and Riley read one of Ruth's research binders from 1987:

Counter-frequency work done. Channel closed. Clean.

Thomas Calhoun opened the mine in 1887. Documented everything he could and spent his life maintaining the record and containing the damage and the damage kept growing.

Twenty-three years of Ruth. More documentation. Better tools. Better containment. The damage kept growing.

Tomorrow we decide. I already know what we decide. I think we all know.

I'm not writing it yet. I'll write it when it's done.

Six days of records. One more entry after tomorrow.

I hope.

He looked at that last line.

Left it.

Closed the notebook.

Outside the monitoring station windows the mountains were dark and enormous and old and somewhere in them, patient and growing and entirely unworried about tomorrow, the thing in the mountain went about its ancient work.

Chapter Nineteen: First Caller Appears

They decided over breakfast.

Not dramatically. Not with speeches or formal votes or the kind of cinematic moment that the weight of the decision seemed to demand. Ruth made oatmeal and they sat around the table and Alex said *we're going* and Riley said *we're going* and Casey said *I'm going* and the table looked at Casey.

"No," Jordan said.

"Jordan," Casey said.

"You're not —"

"I'm the one who knows the documentation," Casey said. Calmly. The specific calm of someone who had made their decision well before the conversation and was simply waiting for the conversation to arrive at it. "I've read everything Ruth has. I understand the mechanism better than anyone in this room except Ruth. If something goes wrong in there and Alex and Riley need to make a decision quickly, they need someone who can —"

"I can brief them," Ruth said. "Thoroughly. Everything you know, they can know."

"It's not the same as having it in the room," Casey said. She looked at Ruth. "You know that. You went in with two people because you knew that."

Ruth was quiet.

"I'm going," Casey said. "That's my decision. I'm telling you, not asking you."

Jordan looked at Alex.

Alex looked at Casey. At the notebook in front of her, already open, already annotated with the night's research, the careful preparation of someone who had been getting ready for this since the monitoring station.

"Okay," he said.

Jordan made a sound.

"She's right," Alex said to him. "She's been right about everything for nine days. I'm not going to start overruling her now."

Jordan looked at the table. At Sam, who was looking at him with the specific expression of a person who had already made their peace with something and was waiting for him to make his.

"Fine," he said. Low. Heavy. "Fine."

Taylor said: "I want to go."

The table looked at her.

"No," Ruth said immediately. "Taylor, you're —"

"I know what I am," Taylor said. "I know I'm a partial. I know the residue. I know the risk." She looked at Ruth. "I also know the thing better than anyone who's clean. I've been inside it. I know what it sounds like from inside." She paused. "That's useful information in a room with the source. I might be able to tell you things that none of them can tell you."

"Or the source completes the conversion the moment you're in range," Ruth said.

"Possibly," Taylor said. "Yes." She looked at Alex.

He looked at her. At Taylor Kim, Ohio State, pad see ew, extra basil. The list in her jacket pocket. The woman who had woken up with her boots on and read herself back to herself in the dark.

"No," he said.

She held his gaze.

"You've been fighting it for nine days," he said. "You've been winning. I'm not going to put you in a room with the thing you've been fighting and ask you to keep winning." He paused. "That's not what I'm doing with you."

A long moment.

Something in Taylor's face shifted. Not defeat — the acceptance of someone being genuinely seen.

"Okay," she said.

"You and Jordan and Sam and Marisol stay with Ruth," he said. "Ruth monitors from here. If something goes wrong —"

"Nothing goes wrong," Jordan said. "That's the rule."

"If something goes wrong," Alex said again, "Ruth knows what to do."

Jordan looked at him. The twelve-years look — the look that contained everything that couldn't be said in the time available.

"Come back," he said.

"That's the plan," Alex said.

They left at noon.

Ruth drove them up in her truck, the four of them — Alex, Riley, Casey, and Ruth — with the equipment in the truck bed, carefully packed in cases that Ruth had apparently kept ready for exactly this. The road climbed into the park, past the southern trailhead where the van was still parked, past the northern access point, onto the fire road that took them as far as vehicles could go into the section of the park that contained Calhoun Hollow.

The fire road ended at a gate. Locked. Ruth had a key.

Beyond the gate the terrain rose steeply through dense second-growth forest, the kind of forest that had come back after the logging of the early century with the aggressive vigor of land reclaiming itself. No trail. Ruth navigated by memory and by occasional reference to a handheld GPS unit and by the markers — the ridge symbols on trees and rocks, placed by Thomas Calhoun's hand and maintained for a hundred years, leading into the hollow and toward the mine.

Alex followed the markers and thought about Thomas Calhoun placing them. Each one a choice. Each one the act of a man who had decided that the

knowledge was more important than the silence around it. That the people who came after deserved to be warned even if the warning wasn't enough.

The equipment was heavy. They carried it in shifts — Ruth and Casey taking the main case between them, Alex and Riley carrying the secondary units in packs designed for the purpose. Ruth had briefed them on the equipment for two hours the night before. Alex had asked questions until he understood it well enough to operate it without Ruth if he had to.

She'd looked at him when he said that.

"The entrance is half a mile from the gate," she'd said. "The chamber is approximately two hundred feet in. The growth begins at the entrance and thickens toward the chamber." She'd paused. "The sound will start before you see it. The sub-audible frequency — you'll feel it before you hear it. That's normal. Do not respond to it verbally or physically. Do not answer anything. Do not say yes to any sound or sensation that resembles a question, regardless of what form the question takes."

"What forms does it take," Casey had asked.

Ruth had paused. "It asks the question that is most specific to you," she said. "That's the mechanism. It identifies what you most want to hear confirmed and it asks that." She'd looked at each of them. "It won't sound like a monster. It will sound like the truest thing you've ever heard."

Alex had thought about his mother's voice in the dark at the campfire. *Alex*. Just his name. The one sound that bypassed everything.

"The counter-frequency application," he'd said. "How close to the growth do we need to be for effective range."

"Contact range for full effect," Ruth had said. "Or as close as safely possible."

"Define safely," Casey had said.

Ruth had looked at her. "I'll let you know when we get there."

They found the mine entrance at one-fifteen.

Alex had been looking for it — had known approximately where it was from the topo map, had been tracking the terrain for the last half mile — but it still arrived as a surprise. The mountain showed it reluctantly. The entrance had been sealed by Thomas Calhoun with stone and timber, and time had worked on the seal in both directions — weathering it, settling it, growing over it with decades of moss and vine and the slow patient recovery of the forest. But someone had also maintained it. Kept it clear enough to find. The timbers replaced periodically. The stone repointed.

Ruth.

She stood beside Alex and looked at it.

"I haven't been this close in twenty years," she said.

He looked at her. She was still. Her face had the specific stillness of someone managing something internal with great care.

"Are you —"

"I'm fine," she said. "I feel it. But I'm fine." She paused. "You should know — being here, watching you go in, is the hardest thing I've done in twenty years." She said it without drama. Just truth. "I want you to know that. So you know why I'm not coming with you."

"I know," he said.

She looked at the entrance. "The seal comes down with the crowbar," she said. "The space behind it is clear — I cleared it last year on one of my maintenance checks." She paused. "Two hundred feet to the chamber. The growth starts at about fifty feet in. The frequency will be sub-audible at first and then crossing into audible range around a hundred feet. By the time you reach the chamber it will be —" she stopped. "It will be very present."

"We know," Riley said.

"The primary unit goes in the chamber," Ruth said. "Set up against the wall at the center point — I've marked it on the diagram. Secondary units at the entrance and mid-point. Activation sequence is in the order we went over last night."

"We have it," Casey said.

Ruth looked at the three of them. At Alex last.

"The application takes forty-five minutes at full output to achieve documented contraction at close range," she said. "For a full-chamber application to be effective —" she paused. "I don't know how long. I've never done this. The theory says sustained application should produce cumulative contraction. I don't know what sustained means in practice." She paused. "You stay until it works or until you have to leave. You don't push past the point where you can still leave."

"Understood," Alex said.

"Alex," she said.

He looked at her.

"If it starts to convert in the chamber — if any of you feels the threshold quality, the sense of arriving, the sense that it isn't bad —"

"We leave," he said.

"You leave," she said. "All three. No heroics. No staying behind." She held his gaze. "Thomas stayed behind in the chamber for eleven minutes. That was the beginning of everything."

"We leave," he said. "All three."

She held his gaze for another moment.

Then she stepped aside.

The seal came down in four minutes. The timbers were old but Ruth's maintenance had kept them sound, and the stone moved with the focused application of the crowbar. Behind it: dark. The mountain's interior. Cold air coming out with the specific cold of deep stone, the cold that had nothing to do with season.

Alex turned on his headlamp.

The tunnel was narrow — wide enough for a person with a pack, not comfortable. Rough-cut walls, the marks of the original mining visible in the stone, a century of slow mineral work on the cut surfaces. The floor was uneven, stone and packed earth, with the rusted remains of a narrow-gauge rail running along one side.

They went in.

The sound started at approximately fifty feet. Sub-audible, as Ruth had said — felt in the chest and the base of the throat, a vibration that lived below hearing. Alex noted it without responding to it. Beside him, he heard Riley's breathing change fractionally — not fear exactly, just acknowledgment. The body registering something the mind was being careful about.

"I feel it," Casey said. Quietly. Informational.

"Yeah," Alex said.

They kept walking.

At a hundred feet the frequency crossed into audible range. Not loud — under the threshold of what you'd call a sound in normal circumstances. But present. The quality Thomas Calhoun had spent sixty years trying to describe. The sound of a voice before it becomes words. The raw material of language, the vibration and resonance, the sense of about-to-mean-something.

Alex walked and listened and did not answer.

At a hundred and fifty feet he saw the growth for the first time.

It was on the right wall first — a patch of it at head height, roughly the size of a door, dark and textured, not quite the color of anything he had a name for. It caught the headlamp light in the way Ruth had described — not reflecting it exactly, more like acknowledging it, the surface shifting fractionally between looks.

He did not look directly at it.

He looked at it in the same way he'd learned to look at the thing in the forest — the slight deflection, the peripheral attention. It was enough to take it in without giving it the full weight of his regard.

The smell changed as the growth appeared. Not unpleasant — that was the first wrong thing about the smell. It should have been wrong, the underground fungal mineral smell of something ancient and encroaching, but it wasn't. It was specific and complex and underneath the complexity there was something almost familiar. Almost like something he knew from somewhere.

He registered this and kept walking.

The growth thickened on both walls, spreading floor to ceiling as they approached the chamber, the headlamp light doing the acknowledgment thing on every surface. The frequency was louder now — audible, present, the about-to-mean-something quality intense enough that Alex had to consciously redirect his attention each time it surged. The way you redirected attention from a sound that wanted to become words but hadn't.

Casey touched his arm.

He stopped.

She pointed at the right wall, low, near the floor.

Something was there that hadn't been in Ruth's descriptions.

A mark. Carved into the stone below the growth, at floor level, barely visible under the overlay of the living surface. Cut deep enough that the growth hadn't completely covered it.

Two parallel lines. A third cutting through at an angle.

Thomas Calhoun's hand.

Here. Inside the mine, inside the tunnel, inside the growth. He'd come in far enough to mark a warning on the wall. *Here. It starts here. Turn back.*

And he'd turned back.

Alex looked at the mark for a moment.

Then he kept walking.

The chamber opened at two hundred and three feet.

He knew it before he reached it — the sound changed, expanding, the frequency suddenly fuller and more dimensional, the about-to-mean-something quality hitting him from multiple directions simultaneously as the tunnel opened into the larger space. His headlamp beam, which had been throwing light ten feet ahead against the tunnel walls, suddenly went long, reaching thirty, forty feet before hitting stone.

He stopped at the threshold.

The chamber was the size of a church, as Thomas had written. The ceiling vaulted above them — rough stone, the natural geology of the mountain's interior, the same formation that had caused the seam to spit around this space rather than pass through it. The walls were covered.

The growth covered everything.

Floor, walls, ceiling — a continuous living surface, the headlamp light acknowledged and shifted by it everywhere he looked. The chamber breathed. Not metaphorically. The growth moved in slow synchronized pulses, the whole surface of it, the way a lung expanded and contracted. One breath every thirty seconds, approximately. Patient and deep.

In the center of the chamber, where Ruth had marked the diagram, the floor was clear. A space approximately six feet in diameter, bare stone, as if the growth had deliberately left it.

As if it had been expecting them.

Alex looked at Riley.

Riley was looking at the chamber. Their headlamp moving slowly across the growth, taking it in.

"Okay," Riley said quietly. Not to Alex. To themselves. A checking-in.

"Okay," Casey said. She was already opening the primary case.

Alex went to work.

The primary unit took eleven minutes to set up. His hands were steady. He noted this with the same observational remove he'd been applying to everything for an hour — the steadiness of his hands, the even rate of his breathing, the fact that the sound in the chamber, now audible and multidirectional and working on him with everything it had, had not yet found the shape it was looking for.

It would. Ruth had warned him. It was trying.

He could feel it trying. The frequency surging and searching, the about-to-mean-something quality cycling through approaches the way a key was tried in a lock. This resonance, then that one. This timbre, then another. Looking for the specific frequency of him. The sound that would make him say yes.

He set up the primary unit.

Casey set up the mid-point secondary.

Riley went back toward the entrance with the third unit.

Alex stood in the cleared center of the chamber and looked at the growth and the growth looked back at him in the peripheral-attention way he'd learned in the forest and he waited for Casey's signal that the secondary was live.

The frequency was very loud now. Not painful — the sound had no physical component at this range, it was entirely psychological in its operation, the about-to-mean-something bearing down on him from every wall simultaneously. He thought about Thomas Calhoun standing here for eleven minutes. He thought about the specific horror of the one moment Thomas had described — *I did not feel alone in the way I had been alone every day of my life up until then.*

He thought about Riley, fifty feet behind him at the entrance, and the specific quality of not being alone that had nothing to do with the growth.

He held onto that.

Casey gave the signal.

He activated the primary unit.

The effect was immediate and violent.

Not violence in the physical sense — the chamber didn't shake, the stone didn't crack, nothing fell. The growth contracted. The whole surface of it, simultaneously, pulling inward from the walls as if recoiling, the slow pulses disrupted, the rhythm of its breathing broken. It went from the patient thirty-second cycle to something rapid and irregular, the surface writhing in a way that his peripheral vision registered as frantic even as he refused to look at it directly.

The sound changed.

The about-to-mean-something quality collapsed. Not gone — still present, still searching — but disrupted, the frequency fractured, the coherence of it broken into something jagged and less precise. Less surgical. The key still trying the lock but the lock suddenly changed.

He adjusted the primary unit's output as Ruth had shown him.

The growth contracted further.

Casey appeared at the tunnel entrance to the chamber. "Mid-point unit is showing effective range," she called. Her voice was steady. Focused. Casey in full operation. "Entrance unit is live. We have full coverage of the approach tunnel."

"Good," Alex said. "How long has it been."

"Fourteen minutes."

He looked at the walls. At the growth, contracted, disrupted, its surface still moving but differently now — reactive rather than purposeful, the slow patient pulse replaced by something that looked, even in peripheral vision, like response to pain.

He thought: *this is working.*

He thought: *forty-five minutes for documented contraction at close range, and this is already beyond documented contraction.*

He thought: *what does sustained mean in practice.*

He kept the unit running.

At twenty-two minutes the sound found him.

He'd been waiting for it. Ruth had warned him. He'd been managing the approach of it — the frequency searching and searching, cycling through resonances, trying combinations the way you tried combinations on a lock you knew the feel of but not the numbers.

At twenty-two minutes it found the right combination.

It didn't use his mother's voice.

It didn't use any voice.

What it did was simpler and more precise and infinitely more dangerous than voice.

It used silence.

A specific silence — the silence of the four notes not playing. The shape of them in their absence, the negative space of rising, rising, falling, hold, the way the counter-frequency work had left a silence in the shape of the thing it had cleared. The growth had found that shape. Had found the exact space the four notes had occupied and was filling it with silence in the shape of them.

Not playing them. Implying them. The about-to-mean-something becoming about-to-play-something, the next moment about to resolve into the four notes, the next moment, the next —

Yes, the silence said. *You know this. You've known this for nine days. This is yours.*

He held the primary unit.

He held it and he looked at the cleared stone floor under his feet and he thought about the counter-frequency work in Ruth's monitoring station and the specific silence that had followed it and the way that silence had been a shaped absence.

This was not that.

This was the growth using the shape of the cleared channel as a door.

He thought: *this is the truest thing I've ever heard.*

He thought: *that is what Ruth told me it would say.*

He held the unit.

He did not answer.

Twenty-three minutes.

Twenty-four.

The silence pressed.

He looked at the cleared floor. At the stone Thomas Calhoun had cut in 1887. At his own boots on it, present, physical, belonging to a person who had a name and a van and a journal with six days of records and people waiting at the bottom of the mountain.

He thought: *Jordan come back.*

He thought: *Taylor Kim, Ohio State, pad see ew, extra basil.*

He thought: *Riley.*

The silence shifted.

Lost the shape of the four notes.

Went back to searching.

He breathed.

He kept the unit running.

At thirty-one minutes Casey appeared at the chamber entrance.

"Alex," she said.

Something in her voice made him look up.

She was looking at the left wall. At the growth, contracted and reactive. At something in the growth that he hadn't seen yet.

He looked.

In the left wall, at approximately eye height, in a section of growth that had contracted most severely, a gap had opened. A space in the living surface where the counter-frequency had pushed the growth back far enough to expose the stone beneath.

In the stone: marks.

Not Thomas Calhoun's warning symbol.

Words. Carved in the rock with the same patient deliberate hand as the marker at the tunnel floor, but more of them, much more, filling the exposed section of wall in the small careful script of someone who had written by lamplight in a narrow space and had used every inch they had.

Alex walked to the wall.

He read.

The script was old — the spelling and construction of a man writing a hundred years ago in the particular idiom of a mountain community, the phrasing dense and specific and completely without ambiguity about what it was saying.

Thomas Calhoun had come back into the mine.

He'd come back in, alone, in 1931 — forty-four years after the first entry, twenty-three years into his documentation project — and he'd stood in this chamber and he'd written on the wall what his sixty years of records hadn't been able to say in any form he'd been able to send out of the mountain.

The growth had been smaller then, he'd written. After four decades of containment, the growth had been smaller. The counter-frequency — he'd used a different term, an older term, a term from the community's prior attempts — had worked partially. Not fully. But it had been smaller.

He'd written: *I believe it can be reduced. I believe sustained application would reduce it further. I believe it could, with enough time and the right instrument, be reduced to nothing. I could not do this alone. I did not have the instrument. I am writing this here because I want whoever comes next to know it from inside, from the room itself, from the evidence of their own eyes, and not from my records which I know will seem like the work of an old man making sense of something that defeated him.*

He'd written: *it is not defeated. But it is smaller. And smaller is possible.*

And the last line, at the bottom of the carved section, where the growth had come in closest and the letters were smallest and most compressed:

The sound is the key. What makes it can unmake it. Find the instrument. Do not stop.

Alex stood at the wall and read the last line twice.

He turned to Casey.

She was already looking at him. Her pen was out. She was writing on her hand — the exposed surface of her forearm, the pen moving fast, copying the carved text verbatim before the growth re-covered it.

"He came back," she said.

"He came back," Alex said.

He looked at the primary unit. At the reading on its display — a number he'd been monitoring, the output measure Ruth had told him to watch. The number was higher than it had been at any point in Ruth's twenty-three years of recorded operations.

The growth was contracting.

The growth was contracting at a rate that Thomas Calhoun had written as possible, in 1931, on the wall of the chamber it lived in.

He adjusted the output.

He kept running.

At the forty-fifth minute the first Caller came into the tunnel.

They heard it before they saw it — Casey, at the chamber entrance, saying *Alex* in the same voice she'd used when she'd spotted Jordan's tent open in the night. The voice that didn't alarm because Casey didn't alarm. The voice that meant: *something requires your immediate attention*.

He looked at the tunnel.

The headlamp beam reached fifty feet into it before hitting the limit of its throw.

At forty feet, moving toward them, something was walking.

The walk was almost right. Almost human, almost the ordinary motion of a person moving through a space. But the *almost* was the entire content of it — the gait slightly wrong, the weight distribution slightly wrong, the way the figure's head was carried slightly wrong. Like someone who had learned walking from a very accurate description of walking without having watched it done.

It stopped at the edge of the headlamp's throw.

It stood in the dark at the tunnel's forty-foot mark and it looked at the chamber.

The headlamp light reached it but didn't illuminate it the way it illuminated stone or equipment or people. The light found it and seemed to stop there, absorbed, the figure remaining dark even within the beam.

It had a face.

Alex looked at it.

He looked directly at it for the first time — not the peripheral deflection, not the careful not-quite-looking. He looked at it because he needed to know.

The face was David's.

Not David's face the way a mask was a face. David's face the way a reflection was a face — the features correct, the proportions right, the details exactly as

they should be. The small scar on the chin he'd noticed at the trail junction. The particular set of the jaw.

David's face, wearing the expression Thomas Calhoun had described on the five men who had stayed in the chamber. Interested. Already elsewhere.

And the sound coming from it — not the whistle, not a voice. The full frequency, the chamber frequency, all of it, projected from a human form and directed at Alex with the specific and personal quality of something that had learned him over nine days and was applying everything it knew.

The about-to-mean-something.

The silence in the shape of the four notes.

The sense of not being alone in the way he had been alone.

All of it. Everything. At full intensity, from forty feet, wearing David's face.

Alex held the primary unit.

He looked at David's face.

He thought: *this is not David. David is gone. What is wearing David went after David said hello on a mountain trail because the people who came before him didn't say three words at a junction.*

He thought: *this is what I'm here for.*

He thought: *don't answer.*

He turned to Casey.

"Increase the secondary output," he said. "Full range. Push it back into the tunnel."

Casey moved to the secondary unit.

The Caller stayed at forty feet, held at the edge of effective counter-frequency range, the sound it was projecting disrupted by the field the equipment was

generating. It didn't advance. It stood in the dark and it projected and it wore David's face and it was held at forty feet.

"It's working," Casey said.

"Yeah," Alex said.

He looked at the primary unit's display. At the contraction reading, still climbing.

He looked at the growth on the walls. Smaller. Measurably, visibly smaller than when they'd entered the chamber, the contracted edges revealing more of Thomas Calhoun's stone, more of the marks of the original mining, more of the mountain's own face.

He looked at the Caller in the tunnel.

Smaller, Thomas had written, *is possible*.

He kept the unit running.

Chapter Twenty: The Hunt

The Caller did not move for eleven minutes.

Alex counted. He stood at the primary unit with his eyes on the display and his peripheral attention on the tunnel entrance and he counted the minutes the way he'd been counting people for nine days — the specific arithmetic of survival, the numbers that told you where you were.

Eleven minutes.

It stood at forty feet and it projected and it wore David's face and the secondary unit held it there at the tunnel's edge, the counter-frequency field creating a boundary it apparently could not or would not cross. Alex watched the display. The contraction reading climbed slowly — not dramatically, not the surge he'd hoped for, but steadily. The growth pulling back from the chamber walls in increments, revealing stone, revealing the cut marks of Thomas Calhoun's crew, revealing the mountain's own face underneath the century of living surface.

Smaller is possible.

Casey was at the secondary unit, monitoring its output, making adjustments he could hear but not see from the chamber center. Her movements were precise and unhurried. He could hear her breathing — controlled, deliberate, the same breathing she'd been doing all week when she was managing something carefully.

At twelve minutes, a second figure appeared in the tunnel.

Behind the first. Further back — at the sixty-foot mark, in the dark beyond the headlamp's effective throw, visible only as a shape. The shape was wrong in the same way the first shape was wrong. The almost-human gait, the slightly-off weight distribution. It stopped when it reached the first Caller and stood beside it.

Alex looked at the second figure.

He looked directly at it the way he'd looked at the first.

The face was harder to see at sixty feet in the dark. But he could make out enough of it.

He didn't recognize it.

Not David. Not anyone he'd seen. A stranger — or what had been a stranger before the mountain took them, in a year or a decade or perhaps a century before Alex was born. Someone who had answered the whistle on a trail, or followed a voice, or stood in this chamber and felt not alone in the way they had always been alone.

A Caller of unknown origin.

Looking at him from sixty feet.

Then a third shape appeared behind the second.

And a fourth.

They were coming in through the tunnel. Coming in from the mountain's interior — not from the entrance behind Alex, but from the other direction, from the deeper passages Ruth had described as existing beyond the chamber itself, the natural cave system the mine had partially intersected. Coming from the dark the equipment couldn't reach.

Alex looked at Casey.

Casey looked at him.

"How long to sustain full contraction," he said.

"Ruth's estimate was —"

"Ruth's estimate was based on documented close-range work," he said. "What does the display show."

Casey looked at the primary unit's readout. "The rate of contraction is consistent," she said. "If it holds at this rate —" she paused, calculating. "Sixty to ninety minutes for significant reduction. Two hours for what I'd call effective." She paused. "That's extrapolation. I don't know what the threshold is."

He looked at the four Callers in the tunnel. They were holding position — the counter-frequency field at the secondary unit was apparently creating a perimeter they weren't pressing against. But they were four now where they'd been one.

"Riley," he said.

His earpiece — a radio setup Ruth had included in the equipment cases — crackled.

"Here," Riley said from the entrance, fifty feet behind them on the outside of the tunnel.

"We have four Callers in the inner tunnel," Alex said. "They're not advancing. But we need to know if any are approaching from outside."

A pause.

"Ruth," Riley said — not to Alex, to Ruth on the channel. "Are you seeing movement on the monitors."

Ruth's voice, from forty minutes away down the mountain: "I have three signatures moving toward the entrance from the eastern slope. They'll be at the mine in — eight minutes. Maybe less."

Alex absorbed this.

Three from outside. Four from inside. The counter-frequency field holding the inside ones at forty feet.

"Can the entrance unit hold the outside ones," he said.

"The entrance unit is secondary output," Ruth said. "Designed for tunnel coverage. If three Callers press against it simultaneously —" a pause. "I don't know. I haven't field-tested this scenario."

Nobody had.

"Riley," Alex said. "Can you operate the entrance unit on full output."

"Tell me how," Riley said.

Alex walked Riley through the adjustment over the radio — the specific sequence Ruth had shown him, the output controls, the range calibration. Riley's voice was steady and practical, asking clarifying questions once, confirming

settings twice, the focused competence of someone applying learned information under pressure.

"Done," Riley said. "Full output. How long do I hold it."

"Until I tell you otherwise," Alex said.

He looked at the chamber. At the primary unit, running, the display showing the contraction reading still climbing. At the four Callers holding position at the tunnel's forty-foot mark, the secondary unit's field between them and the chamber. At the growth on the walls — smaller now, visibly smaller, the cleared stone areas expanding as the field did its work.

He needed time.

He needed the application to continue. He needed the growth to contract past the point of recovery — to reach whatever threshold Thomas Calhoun had believed existed, whatever point made *smaller* become *gone*. He didn't know what that threshold was. He didn't know if they'd reach it in ninety minutes or two hours or whether two hours was even possible given what was assembling in the tunnel and outside the entrance.

He knew the application had to keep running.

"Casey," he said. "I need you in the chamber operating the primary. Don't stop the output regardless of what happens in the tunnel. The reading has to keep climbing."

Casey looked at him. "What are you going to do."

"Manage the tunnel," he said.

"Alex —"

"The reading climbs," he said. "That's the priority. Everything else is secondary." He paused. "If something happens to me, the reading climbs. Understood."

Casey held his gaze for a long moment.

"Understood," she said.

She moved to the primary unit.

Alex picked up the secondary unit's control interface and moved toward the tunnel entrance.

The four Callers were patient.

This was the thing about them that was hardest to manage — not their appearance, not the wrongness of their movement, not even the projected frequency that beat against him constantly from forty feet away. The patience. The absolute unhurried quality of four figures standing in the dark waiting for the field to weaken or the equipment to fail or a human mistake to create an opening.

They had, presumably, all the time they needed. The mountain didn't age them. Didn't diminish them. David had been in there for one day and was already indistinguishable from a Caller who might have been there for thirty years.

Alex stood at the chamber entrance, between the Callers and Casey and the primary unit, and he held the secondary unit's interface and he watched the four figures at forty feet and he thought about what he knew.

The frequency was the mechanism. The counter-frequency was the disruption. The field from the secondary unit was maintaining the perimeter.

But the field had a range. A physical boundary. If the Callers advanced simultaneously, pressing against the field from multiple points at once —

He adjusted the secondary unit's output. Concentrated it. Not a sphere of coverage but a directed beam — narrower, more intense, pushing harder along the tunnel's axis at the cost of peripheral coverage.

The Callers reacted.

The two front ones stepped back. One foot, two. The frequency they were projecting fractured briefly — the disruption reaching them more intensely, the about-to-mean-something breaking apart into incoherence.

The rear two didn't step back.

They held.

Alex watched them. At sixty feet, at eighty feet, not retreating. Holding their position in the deeper tunnel while the front two fell back.

Not a retreat. A reorganization.

They were figuring out the field.

Riley's voice in the earpiece: "Three signatures at the entrance. They're here."

Alex heard it — the change in the ambient sound from outside, the entrance unit's output shifting as three additional Callers pressed against it. The frequency in the tunnel changed too, the cave system carrying the acoustic disruption from outside back into the interior, the coherence of the inner Callers' projection briefly fractured by the competing frequencies.

He took the opportunity.

"Casey," he said. "Reading."

"Sixty-two and climbing," she called from the chamber. "The growth is contracting on the north wall — I can see stone that wasn't visible when we entered."

"How much of the wall."

"Maybe fifteen percent clear."

Not enough. Not nearly enough. But climbing.

He turned back to the tunnel.

The front two Callers had stopped retreating. They were at fifty feet now, having recovered from his directed output, recalibrating. The rear two had not moved.

From outside, from the entrance, he heard something that made him go very still.

Voices.

Not the projected frequency — actual voices. Human voices. Calling his name, calling Riley's name, calling Casey's.

His own voice, among them. His own voice saying: *come out. Come out now. It's done.*

He stood in the tunnel and listened to his own voice saying it was done and knew with absolute certainty that it was not done and did not move.

The Callers were learning fast.

They'd been listening to all of them for nine days. They had everyone's voice. And now they were using the voices of the people inside the mountain to try to call the people outside it, and the voices of the people outside the mountain to try to call the people inside it.

Don't answer the whistle, the old man at the bulletin board had said.

Don't follow voices at night.

At night, he'd said. Night was a limitation of the original warning — a time-based rule that had been generated from the original behavior pattern, from the encounters that had been documented in communities that experienced the thing in darkness. The thing didn't observe the limitation. It was using voices at one in the afternoon in a lit tunnel.

"Riley," he said.

"I hear it," Riley said. The radio carrying the sound of the entrance, the voices, Alex's own voice saying *come out*. "I'm not moving."

"Good," he said. "Hold the unit."

"Holding," Riley said.

He looked at the four Callers.

The two front ones were at forty-five feet now. The frequency field was holding them but barely — he could see in the way they moved that they were pressing

against it, testing it, finding the exact threshold of its effect. Four figures and the field was calibrated for tunnel coverage, not simultaneous multi-point pressure.

He thought about what he had.

The secondary unit at mid-point, directed forward. The primary unit in the chamber behind him, running full contraction output. The entrance unit with Riley, holding three Callers at the mine's mouth.

And the reading, climbing.

Sixty-two. Climbing.

How long, he'd asked Casey.

Sixty to ninety minutes for significant reduction, she'd said. *Two hours for effective*.

He looked at his watch. They'd been in the tunnel for thirty-eight minutes.

He needed more time.

He looked at the tunnel walls. At the growth — thinner here than in the chamber, but present, covering the stone on both sides. At the Callers standing in it, the growth apparently not registering them as foreign, the living surface continuing its slow pulse around them without reaction.

They were part of it. They moved through it like fingers moving through water.

He thought about Thomas Calhoun's carved words. *What makes it can unmake it*.

The sound was the key.

He reached into his pack.

He pulled out the guitar.

He'd put it in the pack at Ruth's house, in the early morning before they'd left, while the others were still asleep. He hadn't told anyone. He'd taken it out of the van where it had ridden for nine days in the side pocket of his hiking pack, the travel guitar with the scratched lower bout and the stiff tuning pegs, and he'd put it in the pack he was carrying up the mountain.

He didn't know why, entirely. Not consciously. Some instinct below planning — the same instinct that had made him count people, made him not look directly at the thing in the forest, made him stay last on the trail. The body making preparations the mind hadn't caught up to.

He looked at the guitar. At the spruce top, the familiar worn surface.

He looked at the Callers.

He thought about what the guitar had been from night one. The attractor. The thing that drew the frequency's attention, that preceded the whistle, that Taylor had hummed in her sleep, that the growth had learned and reproduced and used.

The guitar had drawn it.

The guitar could draw it again.

Not to recruit. Not the uncontrolled draw of four nights of casual playing around a fire. Controlled. Directed. The Callers in the tunnel were pressing against the field because they wanted to reach the chamber, wanted to interrupt the application, wanted to stop the reading from climbing. If he could give them a different signal to orient to — if he could draw their attention out of the tunnel and toward the entrance —

He looked at the four figures.

He looked at the growth on the walls.

He tuned the guitar. Quickly, by feel, the stiff pegs turning under his hands. It didn't need to be perfect. It needed to be the attractor. It needed to be the signal the growth had been responding to since night one.

He played the four notes.

Rising, rising, falling, hold.

The effect was immediate.

The growth on the tunnel walls surged — not the contraction of the counter-frequency but the opposite, a pulse of activation, the living surface brightening and thickening in response to the attractor signal, the thing that had been drawing it for nine days resounding in the enclosed space with an intimacy and immediacy that nothing in the open mountain had produced.

The Callers reacted.

All four of them simultaneously — the almost-human bodies orienting toward the guitar with the full weight of whatever had replaced human attention in them. Not the patient perimeter-testing of the last twenty minutes. Active engagement, their projection shifting from the diffuse frequency beat to something directed, aimed, the full coherence of the signal pointed at the guitar.

At Alex.

He played.

The tunnel filled with sound — the guitar's small voice amplified by the stone walls, the counter-frequency from the secondary unit, the Callers' directed projection, the growth's activation pulse responding to the attractor. The acoustic space of the mine doing what acoustic spaces did, layering and reflecting, every frequency present simultaneously.

He played the four notes.

And then, under them, around them, threading through the repeating phrase — he changed it.

Not the attractor pattern. The counter-frequency pattern. The tone Ruth had generated in the monitoring station, the specific resonance she'd identified over twenty-three years, the frequency that made the growth contract. He'd heard it for ninety minutes the night before, held against his chest and his throat while the channel closed. He knew it. Not in a way he could have notated or explained — in the way you knew music you'd been inside of.

He played it.

The guitar was not the monitoring station's equipment. The guitar was a spruce-top parlor instrument with stiff tuning pegs and a scratch on the lower

bout. It was not calibrated for counter-frequency application. It could not generate the precision and output of Ruth's twenty-three years of engineered tools.

But it was inside the tunnel, inside the growth's acoustic field, resonating in the enclosed space with the specific intimacy of a small instrument in a small room. And the frequency it was producing was close. Approximate. The shape of the counter-tone even if not its precision.

The growth on the tunnel walls contracted.

Not the measured incremental contraction of the primary unit in the chamber. A localized convulsion — the tunnel walls pulling back from the guitar's sound the way skin pulled from a flame.

The Callers broke their orientation.

Two of them stepped back — not the calibrated retreat of perimeter adjustment, a reactive step, involuntary. The directed projection fractured. The coherence of the signal aimed at Alex broke into pieces.

He kept playing.

Casey, he said into the radio without stopping. *Reading.*

Seventy-one, she said. Her voice had something in it that wasn't quite disbelief. *Alex — the north wall is forty percent clear. What are you doing out there.*

Playing, he said.

A pause.

Ruth, Casey said on the channel. *He's playing the guitar. Can guitar frequencies —*

In an enclosed acoustic environment, Ruth said slowly, *with the attractor pattern as a carrier wave — theoretically the resonance could approximate the counter-frequency output. I never — she stopped. I never thought of that.*

Is it working, Alex said.

Yes, Ruth said. *It's working.*

He played.

The outside Callers pushed harder against Riley's entrance unit at the same time the tunnel Callers fell back — as if the whole system was connected, as if pressure released at one point increased at another. Riley's voice in the earpiece, controlled, reporting: *they're pressing against the field. I have all three at the entrance, they're pushing.*

Hold the output, Alex said.

I'm holding. Alex, one of them — a pause. One of them has my sister's face.

He kept playing.

Riley, he said.

I know, Riley said. *I know it isn't her. I know.* A pause, longer, the weight of it in the radio silence. *I'm holding.*

I know you are, he said.

He played.

The guitar filled the tunnel. The growth convulsed along the walls in response to each pass of the counter-tone, pulling back, contracting, the stone beneath emerging in patches and strips and expanding sections. The four Callers in the deep tunnel held their distance — not advancing, not retreating, held in the specific stasis of things whose mechanism was being disrupted at the source.

He played and he thought about nine days of this sound preceding the wrong thing. Nine days of the attractor functioning as an invitation, the music opening the door, the whistle walking through it. The guitar had been the mechanism of the horror from night one.

Now it was doing something else.

He thought about Thomas Calhoun's words: *what makes it can unmake it.*

He thought: *Thomas knew. Thomas played something in here. Or heard something. Or generated the counter-frequency by accident, by some specific resonance of the mountain's own stone, and documented it, and didn't have the instrument to repeat it deliberately.*

He thought: *I am the instrument.*

He played.

At sixty-one minutes from entry the primary unit's display crossed the threshold Ruth had estimated for significant reduction.

Casey's voice on the radio, something in it he'd never heard from Casey before — the specific brightness of a person for whom a theory has just become a fact: *Alex. The reading crossed ninety. The north wall is clear. The east wall is — Alex, I can see the east wall. The stone. All of it.*

He played.

Keep the primary running, he said.

It's running. Alex the growth is — she paused. It's pulling back from the chamber floor. The cleared circle in the center — it's getting bigger.

He looked at the tunnel walls around him. In the guitar's resonance field, the growth had contracted almost completely — bare stone on both sides, the counter-tone's localized effect having pushed the living surface back to the edges of its reach. The four Callers were still there, still present, still projecting — but the projection was fragmented, the coherence broken, the about-to-mean-something unable to form into the question that found him.

He kept playing.

At sixty-eight minutes Riley's voice: *the outside ones are pulling back. I don't — they're retreating from the entrance. The field is holding and they're retreating.*

He felt this. Felt it in the frequency, the ambient sound of the tunnel changing as three Callers withdrew from the entrance unit's range, the acoustic pressure from outside releasing, the signal from inside correspondingly cleaner.

The reading was at ninety-three.

He looked at the primary display from where he was standing — Casey had angled it toward the tunnel entrance so he could read it. Ninety-three. Still climbing.

Ruth, he said.

I see it, Ruth said. Her voice was different. The specific quality of twenty-three years of work arriving at a moment. *The signatures on my monitor — the outer three are withdrawing. The tunnel signatures are — Alex, they're losing coherence.*

He looked at the four figures at the tunnel's far end.

They were still there. Still present. But something in them had changed in the last few minutes — the almost-human quality of their movement becoming more pronounced, the gait more wrong, the weight distribution further from what it was imitating. As if the thing maintaining the approximation was losing resolution. Running on less.

What does that mean, he said. *Losing coherence.*

It means the growth is contracting enough that the signal sustaining them is weakening, Ruth said. *The Callers run on the growth's output. If the output drops below a threshold —* she paused. *I don't know. I've never seen it drop below a threshold.*

He kept playing.

What do you think, he said.

A long pause.

I think you're killing it, Ruth said quietly.

At seventy-seven minutes the four figures in the tunnel sat down.

Not collapsed. Not fell. Sat down — the slow deliberate movement of people who had become very tired, settling to the tunnel floor with the careful accommodation of exhaustion. They sat with their backs against the tunnel walls and their heads slightly lowered and they stopped projecting.

The frequency in the tunnel dropped to almost nothing.

Alex kept playing.

He played the counter-tone until his fingers were numb from the cold of the tunnel and his back ached from standing and the display on the primary unit read ninety-seven and Casey came to the chamber entrance and stood watching him play with an expression that didn't have a name.

At eighty-two minutes the display read ninety-eight.

He played.

At eighty-six minutes Casey said: *Alex. Come look at this.*

The chamber was changed.

He stood at the entrance and looked at it and tried to find the room he'd entered eighty-six minutes ago. It was the same dimensions. The same stone ceiling vaulting above. The same rough-cut walls, the same natural limestone.

But the walls were bare.

Almost completely. The growth had contracted to a thin residue at the very top of the ceiling — a diminished presence, nothing like the floor-to-ceiling living surface that had greeted them on entry. The slow synchronized pulse was gone. The breathing quality was gone. What remained was thin and still, a shadow of what had been.

The primary unit stood in the center of the cleared floor, running, the display at ninety-eight.

Thomas Calhoun's carved words were fully visible. The whole section of the wall, exposed by the contraction, the hundred-year-old text readable in full for what might have been the first time since he'd carved it.

Alex read it.

He'd read part of it before — the section visible when the growth had first contracted. Now he read all of it.

Thomas had written more than Alex had seen. Much more. He'd written about the chamber, the growth, the history. He'd written about the five men who had stayed and the two who had gotten out. He'd written about sixty years of watching the mountain.

And at the end, after the lines Alex had already read, he'd written:

If you are reading this you have gone further than I went. You have done what I could not do. I want you to know that I tried. I tried every day I was alive and I never stopped trying and I believed it could be done even when I could not do it. The mountain is old but it is not permanent. Nothing that can be reduced is permanent. Finish what I started. I have faith in whoever comes next.

—Thomas Calhoun, August 14, 1931

Alex stood in the chamber and read the last line.

He looked at Casey.

Casey was looking at the wall. She was not writing in her notebook. Her pen was in her hand and she was not writing.

He looked at the display.

Ninety-eight.

He adjusted the primary unit's output. Found the setting Ruth had told him about — the one she'd labeled in her equipment briefing as *sustained maximum, use only if reading exceeds ninety*.

He activated it.

He lifted the guitar.

He played.

At ninety-one minutes the display read ninety-nine.

At ninety-four minutes it read one hundred.

And then — for the first time in Ruth Calhoun's twenty-three years of monitoring, for the first time in Thomas Calhoun's sixty years of documentation, for the first time since a crew of seven men broke through into a limestone chamber in 1887 and one of them said yes —

The display read one hundred.

And the thin residue on the ceiling went still.

And the sound in the tunnel, the frequency, the about-to-mean-something that had been beating against Alex for ninety-four minutes, stopped.

Not faded. Not diminished.

Stopped.

The tunnel was silent.

The chamber was silent.

The mountain was silent in a way Alex didn't have prior experience of — a silence that wasn't the held-breath silence of something waiting. A silence that was simply silence. The ordinary quiet of stone and cold air and the absence of anything that had been there before.

Alex stood in the chamber with the guitar in his hands.

He looked at the walls.

Bare stone.

He looked at the ceiling.

Bare stone.

He looked at the floor.

Bare stone, and Thomas Calhoun's marks, and the primary unit's display reading one hundred, and Casey standing with her pen in her hand and her mouth slightly open.

He looked at the display for a long time.

He looked at the walls.

He looked at the tunnel, where four figures sat on the floor against the walls.

He looked at them.

They were not the wrong shape anymore.

The four figures sitting in the tunnel were human. Fully, specifically human — the weight distribution correct, the proportions right, the posture of people who were very tired and were sitting on a cold stone floor.

One of them looked up.

David's face. David's face with the specific recognizable humanity of a person in it, the depth behind the eyes that the Caller had not had, the there-ness of someone present in themselves.

David looked at Alex.

Alex looked at David.

"Where," David said. His voice was rough, barely audible. "Where am I."

Alex looked at him for a long moment.

"In a mine," he said. "In the Smoky Mountains." He paused. "Your wife is outside. She's safe."

David looked at the tunnel walls. At the bare stone. At the equipment and the headlamps and the guitar in Alex's hands.

"How long," he said.

Alex thought about how to answer this.

"We need to get you out first," he said. "Then we'll answer everything."

David nodded. He looked at the other three figures against the wall — the people whose faces Alex hadn't recognized, whose origins he didn't know, whose stories were somewhere in Ruth's twenty-three years of records or Thomas Calhoun's sixty or in community memory that predated both.

Three people, sitting against a cold tunnel wall, coming back from wherever they'd been.

Alex put the guitar in his pack.

He picked up the primary unit.

He looked at Casey.

"Help them up," he said.

She went to the nearest figure and crouched beside them and said something Alex couldn't hear, low and gentle, the voice Casey used when she was being careful about something that mattered.

He looked at the tunnel entrance. The earpiece.

"Riley," he said.

Static. Then: "Here."

"We're coming out," he said.

A pause. Long enough that he started to say something else.

Then Riley said: "Are you —"

"Yeah," he said. "We are."

Another pause.

"Okay," Riley said. Very quietly. "Okay. I'm here."

He picked up the secondary unit.

He started walking toward the light.

Chapter Twenty-One: No Way Out

The light at the tunnel entrance was the best thing Alex had ever seen.

Not dramatic light — just the pale afternoon sky of October in the Smokies, coming through the mine opening in a rectangle of ordinary grey. The kind of light that existed everywhere, all the time, unremarkable in every context except this one, and in this one it was the most specific and beautiful thing he'd ever moved toward.

He came out of the mountain carrying the secondary unit and the guitar and ninety-four minutes of everything that had happened in there, and the cold air hit him and he stopped.

Riley was at the entrance.

They were standing six feet from the opening, the entrance unit still running at their feet, their face doing several things at once. They looked at Alex. They looked at the guitar. They looked at the tunnel behind him where Casey was helping the first of the three unknown figures navigate the uneven floor toward the light.

Then they looked at Alex again.

He walked the last six feet.

Riley put both arms around him and he let the secondary unit down carefully and stood in the circle of them and breathed the October air and felt the weight of the last ninety-four minutes settle into him all at once, the specific gravity of something finished.

"Hey," Riley said.

"Hey," he said.

They stayed like that for a moment.

Then Casey came out of the tunnel with the first unknown figure — a woman, middle-aged, wearing clothes that had been outdoor gear once and had spent enough time underground to have become something else. She came into the light and stopped and looked at the sky with the expression of someone for

whom sky had been theoretical for long enough that the reality of it was briefly too much.

She sat down on the ground.

Casey sat beside her.

The second figure came out on their own — a man, older, moving carefully, one hand on the tunnel wall for balance. He came into the light and looked at the mountains and said nothing and kept looking.

The third figure came out with David.

David had helped them up the tunnel — Alex had watched him do it, the careful hands of someone who wasn't steady himself helping someone who was less steady. The small unconscious charity of a person whose fundamental nature had apparently survived whatever the growth had done to them. David who stopped for strangers. David who answered voices in the dark because he thought someone needed help.

He came out of the mine and into the light and blinked and looked at the mountains and then at the access road visible below them through the trees.

"How far to —" he started.

"Half a mile," Alex said. "There's a truck at the gate."

David nodded. He looked down the slope. Then he looked at Alex. "You came up here for us."

"We came up here for the mine," Alex said. "You were a consequence of that."

David looked at him. Something moving in his face — the processing of someone who had been somewhere that didn't have language yet.

"My wife," he said.

"She's in Gatlinburg," Alex said. "Forty minutes from here. She's been waiting."

David sat down on the ground beside the woman from the tunnel. He put his face in his hands.

Alex looked at Riley. Riley looked back.

He picked up the radio.

"Ruth," he said.

Static. Then Ruth's voice — and something in it he hadn't heard before in their short acquaintance. Something that didn't have a name but that he understood.

"I see four signatures coming out of the mine," she said. "Human signatures. Clear." A pause. "Are they —"

"They're out," Alex said.

A longer pause.

"The reading," Ruth said.

"One hundred," he said. "The growth is gone."

The longest pause yet. Long enough that he thought the radio had cut out.

Then Ruth said: "Twenty-three years."

He held the radio.

"Twenty-three years," she said again. Quieter. Not to him. To herself, or to someone who wasn't on the radio, or to the twenty-three years themselves.

"We're coming down," Alex said.

"I'll be at the gate," she said.

The descent took forty minutes.

Alex went last again. The habit. The count — one, two, three, four, five, and Casey and Riley ahead of him. Seven people on a slope, moving through second-growth forest, following the ridge markers back to the fire road. The afternoon light coming through the trees at its October angle, the red and gold of

the turning leaves above them doing what it did, which was continue to be beautiful regardless of what had happened or was happening or was about to happen.

Sam had said: *it hasn't made the mountains ugly.*

He held onto that.

The three people from the tunnel moved carefully, slowly, with the specific fragility of people whose bodies had been somewhere that bodies weren't designed for. Casey stayed close to the woman, who had said her name was Helen, who had been in the mine since 2019, who had been hiking the park with her daughter when she'd heard a whistle on the north ridge and — the rest of it she'd said with the flat precise tone of someone reporting something they'd decided to approach clinically. Her daughter had gotten out. Helen had not.

Her daughter was twenty-three now. Had been nineteen when her mother went into the mountain.

Alex did the math and kept walking.

The older man's name was Charles. He didn't know how long he'd been in the mine. He didn't ask. He walked down the slope with his hand occasionally touching the trees as he passed them, the casual contact of someone relearning the texture of the world. He'd asked Alex once, quietly, whether the park was still the park — whether the mountains were still what they'd been. Alex had said yes and Charles had nodded and kept walking.

The third person, a young woman who hadn't given her name yet, walked beside David. They hadn't spoken to each other. They didn't need to — they'd shared something that had no language yet and they were in the silence of it together, which was its own kind of company.

David walked and looked at the mountains. He'd stopped trying to talk, which Alex read as a reasonable response to ninety-four minutes of having been somewhere that couldn't be described while still standing in it.

Alex watched them all and walked.

Ruth was at the gate.

She'd come up the fire road in the truck, which she'd parked at the gate's far side, and she was standing beside it when they came out of the trees. She looked at the group emerging from the forest — Casey, Riley, Alex, and the four people from the mine — and she did something Alex had not expected from Ruth Calhoun.

She put her hand over her mouth.

Just for a moment. Brief, immediately managed, the specific emotion pressed down with the competence of someone who had spent twenty-three years managing things. But visible. Present. Twenty-three years of work and seven groups who hadn't made it and a great-great-uncle who had spent his life trying, all of it in the moment her hand went to her mouth.

Then she lowered her hand and walked to Helen.

She knew Helen. That was immediately apparent — she'd known Helen's file, known the date, known the daughter's name. She took Helen's hands and spoke quietly and Helen said something back and Ruth nodded.

She moved to Charles and did the same. Something in the way she touched his arm suggested she'd known his file too. Had been carrying it.

The nameless young woman she approached carefully, with the specific caution of someone who didn't want to presume. She said: *you don't have to tell me anything. You don't have to do anything right now.* The young woman looked at her and then looked at the mountains and said nothing and Ruth stood beside her in the silence of it and waited.

David she looked at last.

She looked at him for a long moment without speaking.

"Your wife is in Gatlinburg," she said. "I'll take you there."

David nodded. "Okay," he said. His voice was better now than it had been in the tunnel — steadier, less rough. The vocal quality of someone returning.

"I know what happened to you," Ruth said. "I know what it is and I know how to help. You'll need time and specific work and it will be hard." She paused. "But you're out. You're clean. That's the foundation of everything else."

David looked at her. "How do you know it won't come back."

Ruth looked at the mountain above them. At the slope they'd descended. At the mine entrance invisible in the trees above.

"Because it's gone," she said.

David followed her gaze up the slope.

"Gone," he said.

"Yes."

He was quiet for a moment.

"All of it," he said.

"All of it," she said.

He looked at the mountain for a long time.

Then he looked at his hands. At the ordinary surface of them, the specific recognizable hands of a person who was a person.

"Okay," he said.

They loaded into the truck in pieces — Ruth's truck carrying Ruth and the four people from the mine, Casey riding in the back, the guitar case between the rear seats. Alex and Riley took Ruth's keys to a second vehicle she'd left at the gate, an older sedan with a cracked dashboard and a pine air freshener that had long since given up, which she'd apparently anticipated needing.

Alex drove.

Riley sat in the passenger seat and looked out the window at the mountains and said nothing for the first fifteen minutes, which was fine. The road unwound from the park access down to the state road and the state road toward the highway and the ordinary world receiving them back again without ceremony.

He drove.

At the highway junction Riley said: "Thomas Calhoun."

"Yeah," he said.

"He came back in 1931. He wrote it on the wall." Riley paused. "He went in alone. No equipment, no counter-frequency tools. Just to write it on the wall."

"Yeah."

"He had to know it wouldn't be enough by itself."

"He knew," Alex said. "He wrote that he knew. He said he didn't have the instrument."

"But he went back in anyway," Riley said. "To leave the record."

"To leave the record," Alex said.

Riley looked out the window. At the mountains sliding past, the October light on the ridgelines, the long blue distances.

"Do you think he knew someone would find it," Riley said. "Eventually. That someone would come and read it and do something with it."

"I think he hoped," Alex said. "I think that's what the whole sixty years was. Hope with documentation attached."

Riley was quiet for a moment.

"That's a good way to live," they said.

He thought about this. About sixty years of maintaining the markers and keeping the records and writing on the wall of the thing that had defeated you because you believed someone coming after you would need it. The specific sustained faith of that. The choice to keep going when the going was the only thing you had.

"Yeah," he said. "It is."

Gatlinburg appeared in the valley below them as they came down off the park road — the neon and the foot traffic and the ordinary human business of a tourist town on an October afternoon. Alex found it overwhelming and wonderful in approximately equal measure.

He parked at the hospital.

Jordan came out before they reached the entrance. He came down the steps in the specific way Jordan moved, the easy rolling gait Alex had known for twelve years, and he looked at the two of them and then he did something Alex had not expected, which was that he stopped on the steps and put his hands over his eyes.

Not crying. Just — covering. Pressing his hands against his eyes for three seconds, five, the way you did when you needed a moment to be whatever you were going to be before anyone saw it.

Then he dropped his hands.

"Hey," he said. His voice was steady.

"Hey," Alex said.

Jordan walked down the last two steps and gripped Alex's arm briefly — not a hug, just a grip, the specific touch of twelve years — and let go.

"Did it work," he said.

"Yeah," Alex said.

Jordan looked at him. At the guitar on Alex's back. At Riley beside him.

"How," he said.

Alex looked at the guitar. "I'll explain inside," he said.

Jordan looked at the guitar for another moment. Then he nodded.

"Sam is going to —" he started.

"I know," Alex said.

"She held it together the whole time. She's been —"

"I know," Alex said. "Is she inside."

"Yeah."

"Take me in," Alex said.

Sam was in the waiting area, the same waiting area, the same fluorescent lights and linoleum and the television cycling through its home renovation show. She looked up when Alex and Riley came through the door and she looked at them for one long moment with the full weight of what that moment contained.

Then she stood up.

She walked across the waiting area and she put her arms around Alex and held on for what felt like a long time and what Alex suspected was not long enough for what she was feeling.

He held her back.

"Hey," he said. His voice came out rougher than he expected.

"Hey," she said. Into his shoulder.

They stood there.

Then she stepped back and looked at him — at both of them, Riley included — with eyes that were doing what eyes did.

"It's done," she said.

"It's done," he said.

She looked at the guitar.

"You played it," she said. Not a question — she could see the guitar, she knew him well enough to know what the guitar going into the mine meant.

"Yeah," he said.

"And it worked."

"Yeah."

She looked at the guitar for a moment longer. "Okay," she said. Low and specific and meaning several things at once.

Taylor appeared in the hallway that led from the examination rooms. She stopped when she saw Alex. She looked at him with the flat precise gaze that could read him at a hundred yards.

She walked to him.

She didn't hug him. Taylor didn't hug. She stood in front of him and looked at his face and read everything that was there.

"The humming," she said.

"The growth is gone," he said. "Ruth thinks the residue will clear faster now. Without the source sustaining it."

Taylor looked at him. Something moved in her face — not the wonder of the threshold, not the managed precision of someone fighting a constant pull. Something simpler. Something that had to do with the specific relief of a weight you'd been carrying being lifted.

She nodded.

"Good," she said.

Then she turned and walked back toward the hallway.

Then stopped. Turned back.

"Alex," she said.

He looked at her.

"Extra basil," she said.

He looked at her.

"Pad see ew, extra basil," she said. "That's what you order. I looked it up after you asked me that on the trail." She paused. "I wanted to know if you were right."

"Was I," he said.

"You were right," she said.

She walked back down the hallway.

He stood in the waiting room and felt the specific weight of small things, the accumulated inventory of knowing a person, the details that constituted them — and felt, for the first time in nine days, something that was close to peace.

Marisol was in the room at the end of the hallway.

She was sitting in the chair beside the window, looking out at the mountains. Ruth had called ahead — she knew David was coming, she knew he was out, she knew he was clean.

She was still looking at the mountains when Alex knocked.

She turned.

He didn't say anything. She looked at him and he looked at her and everything that needed to be communicated was in the looking.

Then she stood up.

"He's with Ruth," Alex said. "Ten minutes behind us. He's okay. He's —" he paused. "He's David. He's still David."

Marisol pressed her lips together. Nodded.

"Okay," she said.

They stood in the doorway for a moment.

"You went up there," she said.

"Yes."

"For him," she said. "Among others."

"Yes."

She looked at the mountains again. "He would have done the same," she said.
"That's not a comfort, exactly. But it's true."

"I know," Alex said.

She looked at him. "Thank you," she said. Simply. The word carrying its exact weight and no more.

He nodded.

He left her to wait.

In the hospital parking lot, while the others were inside, Alex sat on the curb with the guitar in his lap and wrote in the journal.

The last full entry. He knew it was the last full entry the way you knew things when they were true without requiring examination.

Out. All of us out. David out. Helen out. Charles out. The nameless young woman out.

The mine is empty. The growth is gone. Ruth says the Callers who had been in the mountain for longer than David — years, decades — will need significant work to reintegrate. That there is no simple recovery from what the growth did to people over long exposure. But they're human. They're present. They're in themselves again.

Thomas Calhoun opened the mine in 1887 and spent sixty years trying to close what he'd opened. I went in with a guitar and a counter-frequency unit and Casey's documentation and Riley's presence and three hours of trying and it worked.

I don't know what to do with that. I don't know what it means about the sixty years versus the three hours except that the sixty years built the three hours. That Thomas's work was in the room with us, on the wall, every minute. That Ruth's twenty-three years were in the equipment and in the briefing and in the specific knowledge of the frequency.

The three hours were the point of the spear. The sixty years were everything behind it.

I want to write something about David but I don't have the language yet. I want to write something about Marisol's face when I told her he was out and I don't have that language either.

Some things go in the journal later. Some things need more distance.

He paused.

Looked at the mountains.

Added:

One more thing. The last thing.

In the chamber, at approximately sixty minutes, when the sound found what it was looking for — the silence in the shape of the four notes, the question shaped like the truest thing I'd ever heard — there was a moment.

Not long. A few seconds. The about-to-mean-something pressing against every defense I had with everything it knew about me.

And in that moment, before I held the counter-tone and kept playing — for a few seconds I understood what Taylor meant when she said it isn't bad.

I understood what Thomas Calhoun wrote about in 1887. The not-being-alone. The specific not-alone of having something know you completely.

I understand why people answered it. I understand why they stayed.

And I understand why it was still wrong. Why the knowing it offered was not the knowing that mattered. Why the not-alone it offered was the opposite of what it promised.

What it offered was absorption. What it took was you.

The not-alone that matters is this: Jordan's hand on my arm on the hospital steps. Sam holding on. Taylor and extra basil. Casey's pen on her forearm, copying Thomas's words before the growth came back.

Riley's voice on the radio saying I'm here.

That's the not-alone.

That's what you fight for.

He looked at what he'd written.

He looked at the mountains.

He closed the notebook.

Riley came out of the hospital and sat beside him on the curb.

They sat together in the parking lot in the October afternoon, the mountains around them old and enormous and ordinary, the way mountains were ordinary when they weren't doing anything to you anymore, when they were just mountains.

"How are you," Riley said.

"I don't know yet," he said. "I think I will be."

"Yeah," Riley said. "Me too."

They sat.

After a while Riley said: "I want to tell you something."

"Okay," he said.

"On the trail," Riley said. "Night one, night two, all of it — I was afraid. The whole time." They paused. "Not afraid in the ways that were useful. Afraid in the deeper way. The way that has nothing to do with whistles or mines." They looked at their hands. "Afraid that something was going to happen and I wouldn't have said the thing I meant to say. That I'd been not-saying it for three years and I'd keep not-saying it and then something would happen and —" they stopped.

Alex waited.

"I'm saying it now," Riley said. "I know it's not the right moment, I know we're sitting on a hospital curb and it's been nine days and —"

"Riley," he said.

They looked at him.

"It's the right moment," he said.

Riley looked at him for a moment.

Then they said the thing they'd been not-saying for three years.

And Alex said the thing he'd been not-saying for five.

And they sat on the curb in the October afternoon with the mountains around them and the ordinary world doing its ordinary things, and it was not a perfect moment by any reasonable measure — they were exhausted and frightened and sitting on concrete outside a hospital in Gatlinburg — and it was also exactly the right moment, which was the way the right moments usually worked, arriving not when you were ready but when you were true.

He held her hand.

She held his.

The mountains were just mountains.

Chapter Twenty-Two: Final Choice

Three weeks later Alex found the journal.

Not lost — he'd known where it was, in the top drawer of his desk in his apartment in Asheville, where he'd put it the night they'd driven home and hadn't touched since. The not-touching had been deliberate. The journal had nine days of things in it that he'd needed distance from, and he'd given himself distance, and now three weeks had passed and he was ready.

Or close enough to ready that the difference didn't matter.

He made coffee and sat at his desk and opened the notebook.

The first entries were strange to read.

Not because they were wrong — the observations were accurate, the details precise, the voice recognizably his. Strange because of the quality of not-knowing in them. The first pages had been written by a person who didn't yet have the category for what was happening, who was applying the vocabulary of camping and hiking and reasonable outdoor caution to something that required a completely different vocabulary. He read the entry from night one — *Strange sound from the ridge around 9pm. Probably nothing. Wind does weird things up here* — and felt the specific tenderness you felt for your previous self when your previous self was wrong in ways that were not their fault.

He kept reading.

The entries changed. He could track the vocabulary shift — the first time he wrote *whistle* with deliberateness rather than casualness, the first time he wrote *it* rather than *something*, the first time *Caller* appeared, arriving fully formed from nowhere, the right word before he had the right information.

He read the entry from the night of the voice. His mother's voice. He read what he'd written and what he'd crossed out and the small precise record of a person trying to be honest about what was happening to them while also being the person responsible for keeping five others safe.

He read Taylor's entries. Jordan's entries. The counting. The rules. The mine.

He read the last entry in the parking lot.

He sat at his desk for a long time after that.

The weeks since Gatlinburg had been specific in their texture.

Ruth had been right about the residue — for the first week, faintly, he'd still heard the four notes. Not the about-to-mean-something quality, not the pull, not the searching frequency. Just the notes themselves, like a song that had lived in the back of his mind for long enough to have taken up permanent residence. He'd told Riley, who had reported the same. They'd called Ruth.

Ruth had said: *it'll fade. Give it time.*

It had faded. By the end of the second week it was occasional — a moment here or there, the four notes surfacing during the specific liminality of falling asleep or waking up, the states when the mind's defenses were at their lowest. By the third week it was rare. By now, sitting at his desk with the journal open, he couldn't remember the last time he'd heard it.

He held this. The absence. The specific shaped silence where something had been.

Not loss. Something else. The silence of a cleared channel. The silence of Thomas Calhoun's sixty years finally having an ending.

He'd talked to Ruth twice since coming home.

The first call had been logistical — the documentation, the park service, the formal reporting of what had happened in the mine and what it meant for the northern section of the park. Ruth had connections in the service, people who'd worked with her quietly for years, who understood the hollow and the history and the specific kind of management it had required. The conversation about what had happened was complicated and long and Alex had deferred to Ruth on most of it, contributing the journal entries she'd asked for, the specific observations she needed to complete her own documentation.

She'd asked for the journal.

He'd said he wanted to keep it.

She'd been quiet for a moment and then said: *make me a copy.*

He'd made her a copy.

The second call had been shorter and different in register. Ruth had called to tell him that Helen's daughter had come to Gatlinburg. That the reunion had been — she'd paused there, selecting words. *What you'd expect*, she'd said. *And more than that. And some things you couldn't expect and some things that would take a long time.* She'd said that Charles had a sister in Knoxville who was seventy-one and had been told her brother died in a hiking accident in 2003 and was currently in the process of being told something else. She'd said the nameless young woman had told them her name. Priya.

Alex had sat with that for a moment.

Priya. Jordan's Priya. The person Jordan had said *complicated* about, at the beginning of the trip, in the first hour of the drive. Jordan and Priya figuring stuff out.

He'd called Jordan.

Jordan had picked up on the second ring and Alex had said her name and the silence on the line had lasted long enough that Alex had said *Jordan* and Jordan had said *I know. I know it's not* — and stopped. And then: *I know it's not the same person.* A pause. *But her name is Priya.*

Yeah, Alex had said.

I don't know what to do with that, Jordan had said.

I don't think you have to do anything with it, Alex had said. *Not yet.*

Yeah, Jordan had said. *Okay.*

He'd talked to Taylor once.

She'd called on a Tuesday evening and they'd talked for an hour, which was unusual — Taylor was not a phone person, had never been a phone person, and an hour-long call from Taylor carried the weight of someone who had decided the subject merited it.

She'd said the humming had stopped completely in the second week. She'd said she still had the list in her jacket pocket but that she'd stopped needing to read it. She'd said she was running again, six miles in the morning, the cold autumn air, the specific pleasure of her body doing what her body did.

She'd said: *I've been thinking about the mine.*

He'd said: *okay.*

She'd said: *not the pull. Not the draw. Just — thinking about it. About what it was. What it wanted. A pause. What it offered.*

He knew where this was going. He'd been there himself, at his desk, reading the last journal entry.

The not-alone, he'd said.

Yes, she'd said. *It found the real thing. That's what makes it — it didn't invent a false need. It found an actual need and offered a false version of it.*

Yeah, he'd said.

I keep thinking about that, she said. *About people who answered it. About why they stayed. A pause. They weren't foolish. They were lonely in a real way and the thing knew it and it offered something specific.*

And took everything, he said.

And took everything, she said. *Yes. A pause. I'm not excusing it. I'm just — I want to understand it. What it actually was.*

He'd thought about the chamber. About the about-to-mean-something. About the silence in the shape of the four notes pressing against every defense he had.

I think it was a very old thing that had evolved one mechanism for survival, he'd said. *And the mechanism worked on humans because humans have one*

specific vulnerability, which is loneliness. And it exploited that for a hundred and thirty years until someone figured out that sound could work both ways.

Taylor had been quiet for a moment.

That's a decent theory, she'd said.

You have a better one?

I have a different one, she'd said. I think it wasn't exploiting loneliness. I think it genuinely offered connection. The actual thing, not a simulation. And the cost of that connection was you — your selfhood, your individuality, absorbed into the collective. A pause. I think it was genuinely trying to not be alone. In the way that only something that large and old and completely without language could try.

Alex had sat with that.

That's worse, he'd said.

I know, Taylor had said. That's why I keep thinking about it.

He'd talked to Riley every day.

This was new — not in the fact of it, they'd talked every day since Gatlinburg, since the hospital curb, since the things said and the hand held in the October afternoon. New in the ease of it. The three-year gap closed, the not-saying done with, the specific relief of a thing finally being what it was rather than what it was almost.

Riley had gone back to their city. Alex was in his. The distance was four hours and they'd driven it twice already in three weeks, which was the kind of data point that told you something true about a situation.

He'd told Riley about Thomas Calhoun's journal entry. The one he'd been thinking about.

He came back in 1931, he'd said. Alone. No equipment. He went back into the thing that had taken six of his crew and he carved words on the wall in the dark.

Why, Riley had said.

Because he believed someone would come and need them, Alex had said.
That's the whole reason. Sixty years of believing someone was coming, and going back in one more time to leave them something.

Riley had been quiet.

Do you think he knew it would be you, Riley had said.

Not me specifically, he'd said. *Just — someone. Whoever came next.* He paused. *That's the kind of faith that doesn't require a specific object.*

That's the best kind, Riley had said.

He'd held that.

Yeah, he'd said. *It is.*

He closed the journal now and sat at his desk with his coffee and looked out the window at the mountains.

Not the Smokies — he was in Asheville, and the mountains visible from his desk window were the Blue Ridge, gentler and more domestic, the city tucked into them with the ease of long coexistence. He looked at them and thought about Calhoun Hollow and the north ridge and the specific quality of those mountains and found that he could look at them without the attended weight, without the sense of being observed, without the four notes rising in the back of his mind.

Just mountains.

He opened the journal one more time.

Turned to the last entry — the parking lot entry, the long one, the synthesis.

He read the last line.

That's what you fight for.

He looked at it for a moment.

Then he turned to the next blank page.

He wrote:

Asheville. Three weeks out.

I've been waiting to write this entry because I didn't know what it was going to say. I think I know now.

Ruth called yesterday. The park service has restricted access to the northern section of the park pending a full assessment. Ruth is leading the assessment team. She said the chamber is being documented by a team that includes a geologist, a biologist, and two people whose specific expertise I didn't understand and didn't ask about. She said Thomas Calhoun's carved text is being preserved. She said she's been asked to contribute her twenty-three years of documentation to the formal record.

She said she's going to donate it.

I asked how she felt about that.

She said: like I can finally stop.

I've been thinking about that. Like I can finally stop. The specific relief of something that has been running for a long time reaching its end. Thomas ran for sixty years. Ruth ran for twenty-three. Whatever I did in that chamber was three hours, and that's not the same, but I understand the feeling.

What comes after stopping is the question.

I think what comes after is the ordinary. Not the life before the mountain — that's not available anymore, the category has been changed by what happened in it. But a version of ordinary that includes what was learned. That carries it without being crushed by it.

Jordan and Sam. Taylor running six miles in the cold. Casey, who has been contacted by three separate academic institutions about her documentation of the event, which she finds overwhelming and useful in approximately equal measure, which is very Casey.

Riley, four hours away, driving the distance in both directions.

Marisol and David. The long work of that. The people who are not the same as before and are finding what they are instead.

Helen and her daughter. Charles and his seventy-one-year-old sister. Priya, whose name is Priya.

What I learned in the mountain: the not-alone that matters is specific. It has faces and names and particular habits and the way it feels is not the overwhelming connection of something ancient and total. It feels like a hand on your arm in a hospital parking lot. It feels like someone reading themselves back to themselves in the dark with a list they wrote for exactly that purpose. It feels like twelve years of friendship and extra basil and a journal entry that was wrong about the wind.

It is not transcendent. It is not absolute. It requires maintenance and attention and the daily choice to show up for it.

It is also the only thing worth the trip.

He looked at what he'd written.

He added:

One more thing. Thomas Calhoun's account — the full account, the sixty years of documentation — is being transcribed and archived by the Calhoun County Historical Society. Ruth told me this. She said they're calling it the Calhoun Archive.

She said they're looking for someone to write an introduction. Something that bridges the historical documentation with what happened three weeks ago. Something that explains — in terms accessible to whoever reads it next — what the mine was and what the growth was and what happened when someone finally got close enough to stop it.

She asked if I knew anyone.

I told her I'd think about it.

He looked at the page.

At the journal. At the nine days of records, the counting, the rules, the watching, the guitar, the chamber, Thomas Calhoun's words on the wall.

He looked at his desk.

At the pen in his hand.

He wrote:

I'll do it.

For Thomas. For the sixty years. For whoever comes next.

Don't answer the whistle.

He closed the journal.

Outside his window the Blue Ridge held their ordinary ancient silence, blue in the October afternoon, the light on them clean and cold and exactly what it was.

He picked up his phone.

He called Riley.

End of Chapter Twenty-Two

Epilogue: Journal Ending

The following are selected pages from a journal recovered from the backcountry of Great Smoky Mountains National Park, submitted as part of the Calhoun Archive documentation project. The journal was found at the Laurel Falls trailhead on October 14th, lodged behind the bulletin board at the ranger station junction — the same station where, as documented elsewhere in this archive, a warning was given to the journal's author at the start of the trip described within.

The journal is reproduced here in full, with the exception of entries already appearing in the primary account. What follows are the pages found after the final dated entry — pages the author does not remember writing.

— R. Calhoun, *Calhoun Archive, Vol. III*

October 14

Back at the trailhead. Everyone out. Feels unreal — the van is exactly where we left it, same dent in the quarter panel, same parking space. Five days and the world held its position.

Writing this quickly before we leave for the hospital. Don't want to lose the details.

The whistle came three times last night. Same pitch. Same direction. We didn't answer.

We don't answer.

October 14, later

Hospital in Gatlinburg. Waiting area. Bad coffee. The television is doing something with kitchens.

Jordan is outside with Sam. Riley is at the vending machine. Casey is calling the historian.

I have the journal and the coffee and the specific feeling of someone who has been holding something very tightly for a long time and is beginning, slowly, to let go.

The whistle came three times last night, I wrote.

I wrote that wrong. I'm not sure it was three times. I'm not sure it came at all. I'm not sure I slept.

I'll correct it later.

[Undated — estimated October 15-16, based on page position]

I keep thinking about the voice that used my mother.

Not with fear. Just — it found exactly the right thing. The specific sound that reached below every defense because it had been living in me since before I had defenses. The first voice. The first voice most of us hear.

It knew that. It identified it and used it.

I keep wondering how many voices it had learned before mine. How many people sat at campfires in the Smokies while it listened. How many voices went into it and stayed there, available, ready to be deployed.

How many first voices.

I don't think about this all the time. Just sometimes. Mostly at night, in the space between awake and asleep.

It's fine. It's getting quieter.

[Undated]

Correction to earlier entry: the whistle came four times on the last night. Not three.

The fourth time was after I was asleep. I heard it in the dream.

In the dream I answered.

I want to be precise: this happened in a dream. I was asleep. I said yes to something in the architecture of my own unconscious mind.

In the morning I woke up and I was oriented north.

I turned south.

I didn't write it in the journal that day. Writing it now.

I turned south.

[Undated]

The four notes are quiet today.

Most days they're quiet.

Some days less quiet.

Ruth says this is normal. Ruth says give it time. Ruth knows more about this than anyone alive and I believe her and some nights I hear it in the dark of my apartment, the four notes in the silence, and I believe her a little less at those moments and then morning comes and I believe her again.

This is probably what living alongside a thing feels like. The morning faith and the 3am doubt taking turns.

Thomas Calhoun heard it every day for sixty years.

I've heard it for —

[The sentence ends here. The next three lines are heavily scored through and illegible.]

[Undated]

I've been working on the introduction to the Archive.

It's harder than I expected. Not the writing — the writing comes the way writing comes, which is slowly and then all at once. Hard in the other way. The way that has to do with deciding what the story is.

There are several stories available:

The story of a thing in a mountain that recruited people for a hundred and thirty years and was stopped by a guitar and a counter-frequency unit and three hours in a chamber.

The story of Thomas Calhoun, who opened a door he couldn't close and spent sixty years trying.

The story of Ruth Calhoun, who spent twenty-three years building toward something she couldn't do herself.

The story of six friends in a van who drove into the Smokies in October and came out different.

The story of David, who said hello.

I don't know which story the introduction should tell. I think maybe all of them are the same story and I'm having trouble seeing the shape of it.

I'll figure it out.

I always figure it out eventually.

[Undated]

The four notes tonight. Louder than usual.

It's been a month. They should be quieter by now. Ruth said —

Ruth said give it time. She's right. She's right.

I turned on the light and read for an hour and went back to sleep.

In the morning they were quiet again.

[Undated — the following entries are written in a noticeably different hand than the preceding pages. The handwriting shares characteristics with the earlier entries but is less controlled, the pressure of the pen heavier, the letter formation subtly altered.]

introduction draft 1

The mine opened in 1887. A man named Thomas Calhoun broke through into a chamber and heard a sound and said yes and everything that happened after followed from that yes.

This is a story about sound. About what sound can do to a person when the person doesn't know to resist it. About what a hundred and thirty years of sound accumulates into. About what happens when someone finally brings a different sound into the room.

It is also a story about a group of people who went into the mountains and came out knowing something they didn't know before. About the specific cost of that knowledge. About what you carry out of the dark when you've been in the dark long enough to learn its shape.

I was in the dark.

I know its shape.

[A line here, struck through:] I know its shape and sometimes

[Undated]

introduction draft 2

Don't answer the whistle.

That's where it starts. That's the first rule, the oldest rule, the rule that predates documentation and predates Ruth Calhoun and predates the markers and goes all the way back to the communities that knew the hollow and watched what happened to the people who went in and learned the shape of the thing from the outside without having been inside it.

Don't answer the whistle.

I answered it.

Not the whistle — I was careful about the whistle. But the attention I paid it, the sustained deliberate focus of nine days of tracking and counting and cataloguing every instance —

[Several lines here, struck through heavily. The following is legible:]

that may be enough

that may have been enough all along

[End of struck section.]

It's been six weeks. The four notes are quieter. I'm sleeping better. Riley was here for the weekend and I didn't hear them once.

I'm fine.

I'm writing the introduction and it's coming along.

[Undated — the handwriting here has shifted further. The letter formation is recognizable but the pressure is heavier still, certain letters formed with slight differences that accumulate into something that reads, on the page, as almost-the-same.]

The introduction is almost done. I've been working on it every day.

I keep coming back to Thomas Calhoun's last entry on the chamber wall. *Do not stop*. The last two words. What he meant, which was: whoever comes next, do not stop. Keep going. The work continues.

I think about that a lot. The work continues.

The archive needs more than an introduction. It needs someone to maintain it. To continue the documentation. Ruth has done it for twenty-three years but Ruth is sixty-four and the mine is closed but the hollow is still there and the hollow has a history that

[The sentence ends here. A space of several blank lines. Then:]

I've been thinking about going back.

Not to the mine. The mine is empty. The mine is documented and restricted and Ruth is leading the assessment and there's nothing in the mine anymore.

But the hollow.

The hollow has a history that nobody has walked into and documented from the inside. Thomas's account starts from inside the chamber but the hollow itself — the approach, the terrain, the specific geography of where and how the thing extended itself outward from the source — that documentation doesn't exist.

I could do that. I have the journal. I have the methodology. I know the hollow better than anyone alive except Ruth.

Ruth would say no.

Ruth would say the mine is closed and the containment is permanent and there's no reason to go back.

But there are things in the hollow that the archive doesn't have. Things that would make the record complete.

I could be back in two days.

[Undated — the final pages of the journal. The handwriting here is significantly different from the opening entries. The letter formation has drifted into something that shares the original's architecture but not its character — like a piece of music played by someone who has learned it from a written description rather than from hearing it performed.]

leaving tomorrow

the hollow needs documentation that only I can provide

I've told no one because they would worry and there's no reason to worry the mine is gone the hollow is safe

I know the hollow

the four notes are very clear tonight almost like the first nights almost like

I know what I'm doing

the record needs to be complete

that's all this is

the record

I have the guitar

I know the way

don't

[Here the writing stops. The last page of the journal contains no words. Only this: a series of marks, drawn in the same heavy-pressured hand as the final entries, covering the page from edge to edge.*

Two parallel lines.

A third cutting through at an angle.

Repeated. Filling the page. The same mark, over and over, in the careful deliberate hand of someone who has a very specific thing they need to say and has found, at last, the only language they have left for saying it.]

The journal was recovered from the ranger station junction on October 14th.

The author was found at the Laurel Falls trailhead on October 17th.

He was disoriented but present. He did not remember the three days between.

He did not have the guitar.

The guitar was found the following spring by a park service assessment team at the mouth of a drainage in the northern section of the park, approximately forty meters from the sealed entrance to Calhoun Mine.

It had been placed carefully against a tree.

The strings had been removed.

No other explanation has been found.

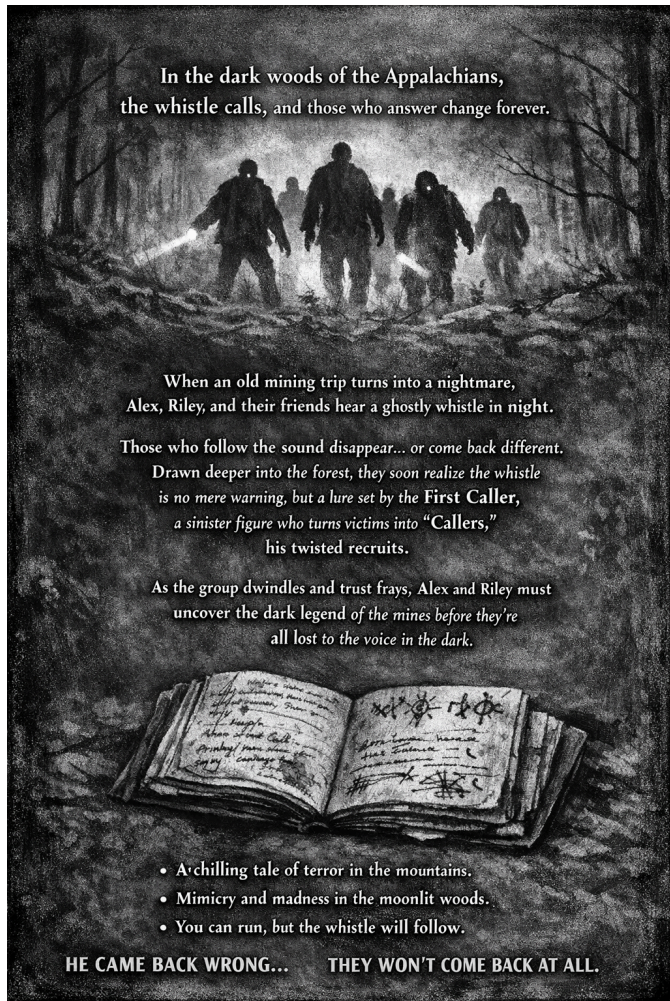
The Calhoun Archive introduction remains unfinished.

— R. Calhoun

End of Epilogue

End of Don't Answer the Whistle

The epilogue reframes everything. The journal entries drift gradually — the handwriting, the reasoning, the logic becoming almost-Alex while ceasing to be entirely Alex. The hollow documentation justification is the thing using his own analytical nature against him, the way it used Jordan's decency and Taylor's attention. The final page of ridge symbols is the last act of the self that's still in there — warning in the only language the conversion has left him. The guitar placed carefully against a tree with its strings removed is the image that lingers. And Ruth's cold final notation — *the introduction remains unfinished* — closes the book on the one note that shouldn't resolve.



Alden Esterhuizen
Feburary 2026